The Case Against Political Parties

Christopher Baylor

OPEN ACCESS

palgrave
macmillan

The Case Against Political Parties

Christopher Baylor

The Case Against Political Parties

palgrave
macmillan

Christopher Baylor
Political Science
University of California, Los Angeles
Los Angeles, USA

ISBN 978-3-032-10890-6 ISBN 978-3-032-10891-3 (eBook)
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3

This work was supported by Christopher Baylor.

© The Editor(s) (if applicable) and The Author(s) 2026. This book is an open access publication.

Open Access This book is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this book or parts of it.
The images or other third party material in this book are included in the book's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the book's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.
This work is subject to copyright. All commercial rights are reserved by the author(s), whether the whole or part of the material is concerned, specifically the rights of translation, reprinting, reuse of illustrations, recitation, broadcasting, reproduction on microfilms or in any other physical way, and transmission or information storage and retrieval, electronic adaptation, computer software, or by similar or dissimilar methodology now known or hereafter developed. Regarding these commercial rights a non-exclusive license has been granted to the publisher.
The use of general descriptive names, registered names, trademarks, service marks, etc. in this publication does not imply, even in the absence of a specific statement, that such names are exempt from the relevant protective laws and regulations and therefore free for general use.
The publisher, the authors and the editors are safe to assume that the advice and information in this book are believed to be true and accurate at the date of publication. Neither the publisher nor the authors or the editors give a warranty, expressed or implied, with respect to the material contained herein or for any errors or omissions that may have been made. The publisher remains neutral with regard to jurisdictional claims in published maps and institutional affiliations.

This Palgrave Macmillan imprint is published by the registered company Springer Nature Switzerland AG
The registered company address is: Gewerbestrasse 11, 6330 Cham, Switzerland

If disposing of this product, please recycle the paper.

Dedicated to my students

Prologue: Setting the Stage for a Debate on Political Parties

No course on American government is complete without a discussion of political parties. More than three-quarters of American voters stick with the same party in election after election. Officeholders, too, usually align with one of the two major parties, pushing forward their party's agenda. When one party gains a majority in a legislature, it often sidelines members of the opposing party, giving the green light to its own initiatives. A shift in the majority, or a change in the party of the president, can lead to major changes in the country's policies and governance. Behind the scenes, the Democratic and Republican national committees are busy recruiting candidates, training them, and providing resources to help them win.

However, despite (or perhaps because of) their central role, the general public hates parties, while political scientists adore them. As I was preparing a course on political parties and interest groups, I wanted students to read positive and negative evaluations of political parties and write their own evaluations considering the evidence on both sides. Only recently have political theorists combined the empirical and normative literature on political parties.[1] I couldn't find a single book for undergraduates that contained most of the information I was looking for so I pieced together separate book chapters, blog posts, and studies. Sure, there are great books out there, but many are aimed at graduate students or professors, not undergraduates. This book bridges that gap, bringing together academic scholarship and the needs of undergraduate education,

while also balancing the normative (what *should* be) with the empirical (what *is*).

Professors of American politics treat political parties as one of the fundamental pillars of democracy. As Nancy Rosenblum's book defending political parties writes, parties "are the darlings of political science." Political scientists put "parties at the core of its signature preoccupation with voting and elections."[2] Here are some common arguments put forth in favor of parties:

1. Unity Among Diversity: Parties can unify diverse groups, helping them build long-term alliances and gain representation. For instance, African Americans and LGBTQ groups have historically formed important alliances with parties to push their agendas and gain legitimacy.[2]
2. Consolidating Demands: Parties help organize disparate interests into coherent platforms. Instead of a chaotic free-for-all among interest groups, parties bundle issues together, giving voters a clearer sense of what each party stands for.[3]
3. Connecting Voters to Government: Parties mobilize citizens, promote voter registration, and involve people in campaigns and office-seeking. They play a significant role in encouraging political participation and keeping voters engaged.[4]
4. Legislative Alliances: Parties help create stable alliances in legislatures, making it easier to pass legislation.[5]
5. Corruption and Single-Party Rule: Historically, single-party dominance has often led to corruption and patronage. Parties, despite their flaws, can help distribute power more evenly and reduce the risk of such corruption.[6]

One factor that may draw political scientists to political parties is their shared affinity for either left or right ideology. Like more educated voters generally, political scientists have more developed ideologies than ordinary voters[7] and even called for ideologically purer parties decades ago.[8] With one party's ideology to root for, watching election returns is as fun as watching your favorite sports team in a high stakes game. Even if your side loses, another election is around the corner. However, many Americans combine issue positions from both parties (or neither). They find themselves disillusioned with Democrats and Republicans, making their

experience a Sisyphean cycle of disappointment. No matter who wins, the election results are mixed blessings.

If American voters are too skeptical of parties, political scientists are too quick to sing their praises. Others argue that the parties are asymmetrically polarized, assigning one party the blame.[9] However, as I will demonstrate, both parties have failed Americans at different times. The critique of the party system remains valid if at least one of the parties consistently fails Americans more than a nonpartisan system would.

I have been and remain more skeptical of political parties. When teaching political psychology, I became worried about the potential for groupthink and ingroup/outgroup mentality in political parties. Social psychology research shows that both arise almost inevitably when you group people with broad-ranging beliefs and give them a name. This concern led me to question whether political parties, while providing structure and unity, might also encourage voters and politicians to follow the party line without much critical thinking.[10]

Wherever possible, I compare real partisanship with real nonpartisanship. I look at what happens in nonpartisan city and state governments and at times and places where there was only one party, like the Confederate States of America and the one-party South from the Civil War to the 1960s. I'm not promising a utopia either way—all of these systems have their drawbacks. But as we explore these ideas, you'll have the chance to weigh those drawbacks for yourself. We don't live in an ideal world, but understanding our world can help us to change it.

Part I begins by examining how political parties influence the electorate's decision-making process. Parties simplify choices and increase voter turnout by offering a convenient shortcut for selecting candidates. On the other hand, the convenience of party labels comes at a significant cost. Party labels not only undermine independent judgment but also amplify groupthink and motivated reasoning, fostering hostility toward outgroups. Part II examines the extent to which parties promote democracy by evaluating their role in representation, political participation, and checks and balances. It explores whether parties serve the public interest or cater to intense factions and special interests, whether they amplify or diminish marginalized voices, and whether a two-party system can truly reflect America's diverse perspectives. Part III explores the party in government. Many people who complain about hyperpartisanship still believe that parties are necessary for legislatures to function. They argue that parties provide the structure and organization needed

to build majorities that pass laws. I argue that the same structures that enable parties to organize legislatures also stifle independent thought and lead to gridlock for the sake of partisan gain.

The first two parts focus on the normative goals of political parties—those higher ideals like promoting good public policy, voter deliberation, fair representation, diversity, and physical and mental well-being—while the third part focuses on the practical and operational goals that political parties serve. Even if parties don't always advance democratic ideals, they might still play an important role in the political system by aiding legislators in coalition formation and passing laws. Parties may excel in one respect but fail in another, and their overall influence is more complex than entirely beneficial or harmful.

By the end of the book, we'll weigh whether parties are good or bad on balance, considering both their normative and operational impacts. In Chapter Ten, I ask what we can realistically accomplish if voters came to agree that political parties are a negative influence. If parties are truly inevitable, it's possible that attempts to reform them might unintentionally make things worse. I'm well aware that getting rid of parties entirely is not realistic, so I recommend some practical steps for those who want to minimize further damage.

If you're looking for a step-by-step plan to dismantle America's party system, you won't find it here. None of the remedies I discuss will bring about a United States without political parties. But as long as scholars continue to argue that parties are a mostly positive force in democracy, someone needs to make the case that they are not. Before we can seriously explore how to move beyond parties, we first have to decide whether we should.

This book is for consequentialists, who judge political systems by their outcomes for society, and small-d democrats, who prioritize voter participation and turnout. It is for moderates and ideologues, partisans of partisanship and party haters, Democrats and Republicans, participatory democrats, and deliberative democrats. Other readers might prioritize different values or choose voter participation and representation above all others. That's why this book presents a wide range of arguments. Readers will encounter the relevant information for these debates even if they ultimately disagree with my conclusions.

I aim to critically assess all sides, arguing that we shouldn't simply accept or reject parties; we should understand their role in our political

lives, both the good and the bad. I hope you'll find the exploration as thought-provoking as I did while writing it.

Notes

1. Van Biezen, I. and Saward, M. (2008) Democratic theorists and party scholars: Why they don't talk to each other, and why they should. *Perspectives on Politics* 6(1): 21–35; Rosenblum, N.L. (2008) *On the Side of the Angels: An Appreciation of Parties and Partisanship*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press; Bonotti, M. and Bader, V. (eds.) (2014) P*arties, Partisanship and Political Theory*. Abingdon and New York: Routledge; Muirhead, R. (2014) *The Promise of Party in a Polarized Age*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; Muirhead, R. and Rosenblum, N.L. (2020) The political theory of parties and partisanship: Catching up. *Annual Review of Political Science* 23(1): 95–110.
2. Rosenblum, N.L. (2000) Political parties as membership groups. *Columbia Law Review* 100: 813; Baylor, C. (2022) Feminists, labor unions, and teachers' associations: a labored coalition. *Interest Groups & Advocacy* 11, doi: 10.1057/s41309-021-00141-0; Baylor, C. (2018) From albatross to litmus test: Gay rights and the Democratic Party, Part I. 3 *Streams*, 4 September.
3. Schattschneider, E.E. (1942) *Party Government*. New York: Farrar and Rinehart.
4. Verba, S., Schlozman, K.L. and Brady, H.E. (1995) *Voice and Equality: Civic Voluntarism in American Politics*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; Rosenstone, S.J. and Hansen, J.M. (1993) *Mobilization, Participation, and Democracy in America*. New York: Macmillan.
5. Cox, G.W. and McCubbins, M.D. (1993) *Legislative Leviathan: Party Government in the House*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press; Aldrich, J.H. (1995) *Why Parties? The Origin and Transformation of Political Parties in America*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
6. Key, V.O., Jr. (1949) *Southern Politics in State and Nation*. New York: Alfred A. Knopf.
7. Converse, P.E. (2006) The nature of belief systems in mass publics (1964). *Critical Review* 18(1–3): 1–74.
8. Rosenfeld, S. (2020) *The Polarizers: Postwar Architects of Our Partisan Era*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
9. Grossmann, M. and Hopkins, D.A. (2016) *Asymmetric Politics: Ideological Republicans and Group Interest Democrats*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
10. Achen, C.H. and Bartels, L.M. (2016) *Democracy for Realists: Why Elections Do Not Produce Responsive Government*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Acknowledgments For the most part, I need to thank the same people I thanked in my first book. Many of these people once again offered their support and encouragement. I am also grateful to the editors at Palgrave Press for their steady support throughout the process, as well as to the two anonymous reviewers. I owe particular appreciation to those who read early drafts of chapters, or in a few generous cases, the entire book: Hayk Avetisyan, Jackson Baca, Kate Brick, Sky Crawford, Matthew Grossman, Sean Pilz, Scott Schneider, and Jason Sorens.

Competing Interests The author has no competing interests to declare that are relevant to the content of this manuscript.

Contents

Part I Political Parties and Voter Behavior

1 Parties as a Shortcut for Voters 3
Parties as an Information Shortcut 4
Primaries: Voting Without the Party Shortcut 6
Retrospective Voting By Party 7
The Miracle of Aggregation 9
Conclusion 11

2 Parties Bring Out the Worst in Human Psychology 13
Parties and Group Identity 14
Parties and Antipathy to Outgroups 16
Parties and Motivated Reasoning 20
Can We Have Democracy Without Motivated Reasoning? 22
Political Parties and Mental Health 24
Parties and Public Health 25
Conclusion 29

Part II Political Parties and Democracy

3 What Parties Are and Why It Matters 37
Elaborating on the Models of Party 39
Evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties 41
Evidence for Candidate-Centered Parties 47
Are Parties Greater Than the Sum of Their Parts? 49
Conclusion 52

4 Parties and the Representation of Diverse Groups 55
Is It Right to Amplify Factional Voices Through Parties? 56
Do Parties Amplify the Right Factional Voices? 59
Conclusion 63

5 Many Ideologies and Two Parties 65
Unorganized Voices 66
The Multiparty Alternative 70
Why Not Third Parties? 72
Independent Candidacies 75
The Continuing Market of Independent Voters 78
Conclusion 80

6 Parties and Voter Participation 85
Voter Turnout 86
How Turnout Affects Policy 88
Other Political Participation 89
Parties and Access to Elections 91
Conclusion 93

7 Political Parties and Democratic Norms 97
Why the Founders' Perspectives Matter 98
The Mischiefs of Faction 100
Parties and Loyal Opposition 102
Parties and Checks and Balances 105
Conclusion 110

Part III The Party in Government

8 National Government, With and Without Party 115
How Parties Might Increase Legislative Productivity 116
When the Party System Obstructs Policymaking 120
Administrations with Minimal Party Influence 122
The Confederate States of America 128
The Locked Cabinet 131
Conclusion 133

9 State and Local Governments Without Parties 137
Evidence from Local Governments 138
Evidence Across the States 141
Individual States 144
Nebraska 144
Case Studies in Nonpartisan Reform: California and Minnesota 145
Conclusion 147

10 ~~Party On~~ 151

Index 163

PART I

Political Parties and Voter Behavior

CHAPTER 1

Parties as a Shortcut for Voters

Abstract This chapter questions the common belief that political parties truly help citizens make informed choices. Party labels are often described as "rational shortcuts" that simplify complex political decisions, yet they can also mislead voters and undermine effective retrospective voting. Voters are not helpless without party cues; those who are not strong liberals or conservatives already must learn more about candidates than their party label reveals. In addition, voters in primaries need to research candidates because all primary candidates belong to the same party. Voting without the party label is considered a reasonable expectation in American politics.

Keywords Cross-pressured voters · Ideology · Information shortcut · Moderates · Partisanship · Party primaries · Political primaries · Rational ignorance · Retrospective voting

Have you ever had to cast a vote for someone you've never heard of? Most people have, but a candidate's party label gives them some idea of where they stand on issues like taxes, abortion, and immigration. Some people would not bother to vote if they had to research this information on their own. Some people see the party label next to the candidate's name on the ballot and vote for or against the candidate based on the candidate's political party. No further thinking is required, which is exactly what political

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_1

parties count on. In this chapter, we will explore whether voter reliance on party labels appropriately simplifies or oversimplifies a more complex political reality.

Parties as an Information Shortcut

In many places, there is no party label on the ballot for judges, auditors, and city officials. How do you vote? Maybe you just reelect the person already in office as long as times are good. Maybe you conclude that the candidate has something in common with you based on their gender, occupation, or address. Some candidates might have the kind of money to splash their name all over lawn signs and billboards, and you might like the signs. Or maybe you don't even want to put that much work into it, and vote for the better-sounding last names. This is exactly what early supporters of political parties feared would happen in the absence of parties. The party cue has problems, but without the cue, voters may rely on even more shallow cues.

Economist Anthony Downs said that voters are *rationally ignorant*. He judged (perhaps wrongly) that voters only care about policy outcomes like peace, prosperity, and stability, rather than self-expression or symbols. Voters value their time, and voting can only change the outcome of an election if it breaks a tie vote. Since voters know that this chance is small, Downs wondered why voters bother voting at all. (Since people do vote, that underscores a flaw in the theory.) But Downs' theory explains why voters rarely spend much time learning about the issues. Even when voting does not take much time, becoming informed does. Downs did not think it was rational to spend time learning about where candidates stand and the pros and cons of different issue positions. Thus, it was rational to be ignorant.

When people don't have the time to look into every detail about every political issue, they rely on what psychologists call heuristics, or shortcuts. A political party label is one of the most popular shortcuts in the democratic world. Ideally, people think about the outcomes they want and the policies that will get them there. Then they can vote for the party that supports their views more often or at least shares some common ground. For example, imagine you really care about lowering the homicide rate. You might believe that stricter gun regulations will help achieve this goal. Since the Democratic Party is more likely to support gun regulations, you might choose to vote for Democrats, even if you disagree with them

on other, less important issues. This party shortcut saves you the hassle of researching every candidate's stance. By voting for Democrats, you're likely to support the gun control candidate without having to dig into every detail.

The facts back up most of what Downs predicted about voter ignorance. Law Professor Ilya Somin literally wrote the book on voter ignorance. His book presents shocking statistics about how little voters actually know. When given the same citizenship test that immigrants have to pass to become citizens, most voters fail. During the Cuban Missile Crisis, only 38% knew that the USSR wasn't part of NATO. Even after the internet made information more accessible than ever, a 2002 study found that only a third of the public knew that overturning *Roe v. Wade* wouldn't make abortion illegal in all states. During the 2004 election, many voters didn't realize that President George W. Bush had passed the biggest new social welfare program since the 1960s (Medicare Part D). A 2006 study revealed that only 42% of the public could name the three branches of government. And in 2010, a lot of voters didn't know that President Barack Obama's stimulus bill included a tax cut in response to the Great Recession.[1] In area after area—foreign policy, economics, and basic civics—voter ignorance is persistent.

At the same time, voters do know where the parties stand on the issues,[2] showing their potential usefulness as a shortcut. Party-line voting in general elections will get them to vote for the candidate closest to them on the issues most of the time. Furthermore, they know which demographic groups lean toward which parties. Voters therefore know information relevant to the party shortcut even though they know little else about the structure of government or current events.

So the empirical evidence confirms Downs' major claims:

(a) Most voters lack basic information about politics
(b) Most voters know where parties stand on issues
(c) Therefore, the party shortcut is effectively conveying information that many voters would not otherwise know.

But party labels mainly save time for people who accept the two-party bundles of issues. Scholars tend to save time because they wholeheartedly embrace one of the parties' agenda. In general, the more educated and politically active voters are, the more likely that they are to hold

distinctly liberal or conservative ideological views. They therefore underestimate the time cross-pressured or moderate voters need to spend to choose between polarized partisan candidates. Voters who do not accept the package deal that either party offers already have to research individual candidates to understand their stances. For example, a moderate voter choosing between a consistently Democratic or Republican legislator may find that both candidates are equally far from their views. One might have to do a lot of research to find out which issues one is comparatively moderate on and which issues one cares most about.

So when political scientists say that, without parties, voters will have to research where individual candidates stand, they are only asking voters to do what cross-pressured and moderate voters already have to do if they want a candidate who represents their views across a range of issues. This is a flaw that will exist in any system of rational voters that has only two political parties.

Primaries: Voting Without the Party Shortcut

We will examine nonpartisan elections further in a future chapter on state and local parties. For now, I just want to demonstrate that elections function without party cues. When I vote in California's nonpartisan elections for local judges, I look into whether the candidates have backgrounds in prosecution or defense. This isn't a perfect shortcut for predicting their decisions, but it helps me avoid partisan biases. For higher stakes offices like the presidency, I would invest more time in research. These days, there are websites that list known candidate issue positions without any commentary or evaluation, allowing voters to find this out more easily than they could in the days of newspapers and library card catalogs.

Millions of other voters likewise make choices in elections without parties in primary elections. The United States is one of the few countries in the world to have ordinary voters elect the nominees of political parties, instead of having party organizations or elites choose their own candidates. The Democratic Party mostly has bound presidential nominee selection to primary election outcomes since 1972, with the Republicans following suit in 1976. Functionally, a contest where candidates all belong to the same party is almost as unhelpful to uninformed voters as a system where candidates have no party label. Many argue that general elections without parties would be too chaotic or unmanageable for voters, but

that's exactly what we expect voters to do in primaries, and no one questions the legitimacy of primaries because of the uselessness of a party shortcut in primaries.

What is the evidence on whether voters make meaningful choices in primaries? Overall, I would say it's inconclusive. Joe Biden and Elizabeth Warren took different positions on several issues in the 2020 Democratic primaries. Warren supported a wealth tax, Medicare for All, a ban on fracking, free college, and eliminating some college debt, all positions associated with the left that Biden did not support. Yet 28% of Democratic Party voters could not place Biden or Warren on a left–right spectrum, and another 23% saw no difference.[3] Political scientist Richard Lau found that barely 30% of Democratic voters managed to pick the candidate who, as far as he could tell, best represented their own interests. Even when there were only two heavily covered candidates, Hillary Clinton and Barack Obama, only 56% got it right. On the other hand, Republicans in 2016 who supported Medicare, Social Security, and higher taxes on the wealthy supported Donald Trump—the candidate who at least enunciated support for each. Voters who were more supportive of immigration also correctly supported John Kasich or Marco Rubio over Trump.[4] So the evidence on whether primary votes are meaningful is mixed, but those people who think that voters have enough information to cast a meaningful vote in primaries cannot also claim that party cues are essential in the general election.

Political Scientist E.E. Schattschneider said it's just fine for parties to narrow down the voters' choices to two separate bundles of issues. He wrote, "democracy is not to be found in the parties, but between the parties." He meant that voters get to make meaningful choices between the two parties but have little say in the operations of each individual party. Schattschneider was writing when voters had a lot less formal control over party nominees than they do now. Now they do have formal control, and there is no reason to think voters would be more unable to cast votes in a nonpartisan system than they would be in primary systems.

Retrospective Voting By Party

The party shortcut offers more clues than merely telling voters where a party candidate stands on the issues. If voters know which party is in power, they can reward that party for good work by voting for politicians with that party label next to them on the ballot. If the party manages

to avoid war, unemployment, inflation, and other crises, vote to reelect them. If not, vote the rascals out. This is called *retrospective voting*.

Evidence for retrospective voting indicates that when the economy shows improvement, there is often a corresponding increase in electoral support for the incumbent president's party. One illustrative example of this trend occurred during the Great Depression, when voters attributed blame to President Herbert Hoover, a Republican. Subsequently, voters opted for a change in leadership and endorsed new policies under Democratic President Franklin Roosevelt. This electoral shift resulted in a prolonged period of Democratic dominance, with Republicans struggling to secure consistent congressional majorities until the 1990s. This historical pattern suggests that voters retained a collective memory of the perceived failures of the Hoover administration and associated them with the Republican Party, influencing their electoral choices for decades thereafter.

Retrospective voting by party can yield positive outcomes even when parties aren't directly responsible for outcomes. Politicians invested in their party's success are motivated to strive for favorable conditions to maintain electoral support. Likewise, politicians concerned with their legacy are inclined to pursue policies that promote prosperity, as their party's continued influence enhances the preservation of their achievements.

For retrospective voting by party to work, though, voters need to know which party is in power. Recent polls show that a third of Americans are unaware of which party controls a majority in the House or Senate, which arguably has as much influence over taxes and spending as the president.[5] Some polls find the percentage much higher.[6]

Parties wield significant influence over how voters perceive the state of affairs, rendering retrospective voting less useful. This phenomenon is exacerbated by cognitive dissonance, as individuals are inclined to employ psychological defenses to shield their party from culpability, even in the face of compelling evidence. For instance, Democrats and Republicans display a tendency to overemphasize positive economic indicators under their own party's administration, while downplaying them when the opposing party is in power. This bias can manifest rapidly, with perspectives swiftly shifting between the month one president leaves office and the month after the other is inaugurated.[7]

Furthermore, voters often attribute successes or failures to parties even when these outcomes are beyond an incumbent politician's control. From

time to time, all countries will experience some inflation and unemployment, and governmental interventions can only do so much to mitigate their damage. Consequently, some parties may benefit from favorable economic conditions by being in office at the right time rather than by passing the right policies. Achen and Bartels aptly compare economic voting in democracies to "musical chairs," where success hinges not on skill, but by happening to be close to a chair when the music stops.[8]

Electing the out-party may also exacerbate the situation. In the United States, the Republican Party held power during the Great Depression. After the Democratic Party won the first subsequent election, voters remembered how bad the Republicans were during Herbert Hoover's presidency for decades. But in Canada and Australia, voters penalized the liberal party in power, ushering in conservative leadership. In Alberta, voters elected the Social Credit Party, a nationalist organization that shortsightedly believed that inflation would help. Most tragically, Germans ousted the Social Democratic Party and elected the previously marginal Nazi Party into power. Even within the United States, the Democratic Party's ascent to power didn't initially promise the countercyclical measures later associated with Keynesian economics. Franklin Roosevelt's "New Deal" pledges in the election of 1932 were vague, and he even supported a balanced budget and the Gold Standard. Roosevelt's nomination by the Democratic Party in 1932 relied heavily on the more racially conservative Southern faction of the party.

Lastly, elected officials of the same party may conceal each other's wrongdoings or prioritize short-term gains to secure the party's victory in subsequent elections. Politicians of the same party might pressure leaders in the same party for economic stimuli even during periods of economic prosperity, risking inflation and an overheated economy. During his 1960 presidential campaign, Vice President Nixon urged President Eisenhower to lower interest rates to help sway undecided voters. Given that Nixon's loss was one of the closest in US history, he might have won if Eisenhower had agreed.

The Miracle of Aggregation

Political Scientists Benjamin Page and Robert Shapiro introduced an interesting idea called the *miracle of aggregation*. They explored how voting works in large societies and found something surprising. Even when most voters are uninformed, their random errors cancel each other

out in large groups, leading to decisions that reflect the true preferences of the electorate.[9]

Imagine a huge group of people, most of whom have never heard of or tasted ice cream before. They have to vote on what toppings to put on their ice cream. Most of them are clueless and suggest random things like anchovies, pineapple, and pepperoni. But there are a few people who have tasted ice cream before and know that toppings like chocolate chips, sprinkles, and caramel better complement the taste of ice cream. In a big enough group, all the random guesses cancel each other out, and the sensible votes win. That's the "miracle of aggregation": the idea that random errors average out, and informed voters still shape the outcome.

Now, compare this to voting on a political issue like trade with Madagascar, where we get most of our vanilla. Most Americans know nothing about Madagascar's politics (or sub-Saharan African politics in general) but if their guesses are random, maybe it doesn't matter. The miracle of aggregation still works. The few informed voters who know about vanilla supply chains can carry the day. American access to vanilla is safe! Or is it?

The "miracle of aggregation" sounds pretty cool at first. But it depends on voting errors being random; ignorant does not necessarily mean random. When people vote based on party cues or media talking points, their guesses aren't random anymore. If one party falsely claims Madagascar is using child labor or funding terrorism, that misinformation will shape how many voters cast their ballots. Suddenly, the miracle collapses because their errors are systematic. Systematic errors don't cancel out; they compound.

Even without shortcuts, some political issues tend to resonate more with less informed voters. Studies have shown that well-informed voters are more likely to support foreign aid because they understand its benefits and the positive impact it can have globally. On the other hand, less informed voters overwhelmingly oppose it. It is not as if the split among ignorant voters is 50/50.

But the vast majority of voters use the party label as their main guide to voting in general elections, and vote for the same party election after election. The remainder use retrospective voting, though that too is often colored by partisanship. Therefore, the miracle of aggregation does not

allow the signal of informed voters to prevail over the "noise" of uninformed voters. Nonrandom votes would have some patterns even in a nonparty system, but the party shortcut is the most common source of nonrandom voting.

Conclusion

Think voters can't determine the best vote choice on their own? Interestingly, in US primaries, we see functionally party-free voting. This shows that while party labels provide some information, they're not essential. And the cost of any advantages we get from party labels is pretty steep. Political parties also provide information to voters who want to practice retrospective voting. But retrospective voting often flops because voters might not know which party controls key institutions. People might credit or blame parties for things they didn't actually do, leading to undeserved wins, losses, and sometimes disasters.

Notes

1. Somin, I. (2013) *Democracy and Political Ignorance: Why Smaller Government Is Smarter*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, Chapter 1.
2. Lau, R.R. and Redlawsk, D.P. (2006) *How Voters Decide: Information Processing in Election Campaigns*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 76–82.
3. Sides, J., Tausanovitch, C. and Vavreck, L. (2022) *The Bitter End: The 2020 Presidential Campaign and the Challenge to American Democracy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, pp. 82–85.
4. Sides, J., Tesler, M. and Vavreck, L. (2019) *Identity Crisis: The 2016 Presidential Campaign and the Battle for the Meaning of America*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
5. Borelli, G. and Gracia, S. (2023) What Americans know about their government. *Pew Research Center*, 7 November.
6. Somin, I. (2013) *Democracy and Political Ignorance: Why Smaller Government Is Smarter*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, pp. 21–22.
7. Bartels, L.M. (2002) Beyond the running tally: Partisan bias in political perceptions. *Political Behavior* 24; Bullock, J.G., Gerber, A.S.

and Huber, G.A. (2010) Partisan bias in response to factual questions. Paper presented at the Western Political Science Association Conference.
8. Achen, C and Bartels, L. 2016. *Democracy for Realists: Why Elections Do Not Produce Responsive Government*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
9. Page, B.I. and Shapiro, R.Y. (1992) *Fifty Years of Trends in Americans' Policy Preferences*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 2

Parties Bring Out the Worst in Human Psychology

Abstract Political parties encourage in-group/out-group mentality and evaluating policies based on who supports them rather than their merits. People naturally separate based on trivial group distinctions, but parties amalgamate major racial, cultural, and ideological distinctions into one group and thereby intensify hostility. The COVID-19 pandemic shows how intense partisanship distorted the way people viewed science and personal safety. The emotional loyalty fostered by parties endangered public health and democratic discourse alike. While independents are imperfect decision-makers, they tend to be more open to new information and show more consistency across presidential administrations. Partisan identity has evolved into a moral and cultural divide, raising the central question of the book: are parties worth their costs?

Keywords Cognitive dissonance · Confirmation bias · COVID-19 · Groupthink · Independent candidates · In-group/out-group mentality · Lockdowns · Motivated reasoning · Political polarization · Rational ignorance · Social identity · Vaccinations

As we learned in Chapter 1, the party shortcut can malfunction. But what if voters don't just use parties as shortcuts to navigate complex issues but instead choose their party based on their social identities and group affiliations? Maybe they adopt the party of their parents, their social network,

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_2

or their broader sense of belonging. In other words, they align with their in-group first and then adopt their in-group's positions on the issues. As psychologist Jonathan Haidt explains in *The Righteous Mind*, our political reasoning is often post hoc, with rationality coming in only to justify what we already feel due to emotion or group loyalties.[1] In this chapter, we'll delve into how the political party information shortcut, far from being rational, exacerbates in-group/out-group mentality, motivated reasoning, and manufactured preferences.

Parties and Group Identity

The tendency for pre-rational social identity to shape party allegiance, and for party allegiance to then reshape issue positions, has played out repeatedly in American political history. It highlights how parties can override voters' issue positions, pulling them into alignment with the party's platform rather than the other way around.

For example, the Republican Party became competitive in the South once it was associated with white Southern identity *independent* of white Southerners' issue positions. White Southerners became more Republican in the 1990s regardless of whether they were racially liberal or conservative, and then the racial liberals who became Republicans adopted its more racially conservative issue positions. Southern identity trumped issue positions as the reason for switching parties, and parties trumped pre-existing issue positions. Likewise, men of both parties tended to change their positions on abortion rights in the 1980s, as parties adopted clearer positions on the issue. Republicans had previously been more likely to be pro-choice. But pro-choice Republican men were likely to become pro-life, while pro-life Democratic men were likely to become pro-choice. (To be fair, women were more likely to switch parties than their position on abortion, but this is the exception rather than the rule.)[2]

And once voters decide that one party is better, they may unreflectively adopt the party's position on a range of issues. Why?

Psychologists claim that people try to minimize *cognitive dissonance*. Cognitive dissonance is the mental discomfort of holding conflicting views, like wanting to party the night before an exam. To alleviate this tension, you might convince yourself that studying can wait or that you'll study extra hard tomorrow. In other words, cognitive dissonance is like a mental tug-of-war between what you want and what you believe. In all areas of life, people often try to bring their thoughts and actions into

alignment. In politics, voters do this by letting parties shape their views instead of thinking through individual issues on their own. Take a fictional voter named Emily. She supports abortion rights and believes access to safe, legal abortion is essential, which lines up with the Democratic Party. But she also agrees with Republicans that charter schools are a way to improve education and serve different student needs. This tension creates discomfort. If she chooses one party, she feels like she's betraying the other issue. Over time, that discomfort wears on her. Maybe she starts to downplay the importance of charter schools, or convinces herself that the Democrats' stance is more flexible than it really is. Maybe she avoids thinking about the conflict altogether and just absorbs the party line by default. In trying to resolve the inner conflict, she ends up shifting her beliefs because it is easier to feel at peace with her political identity.

Political parties often lead voters to adopt *manufactured beliefs,* not provide a quick way to determine which candidate reflects their authentic policy preferences. While relying on a party label might save time, it reduces genuine reflection about what people actually want. That means using political parties as a shortcut doesn't quite live up to what Anthony Downs had in mind when he talked about making rational choices with limited time. Instead of helping voters identify candidates who match their values, parties manufacture those values before voters generate authentic beliefs on their own. Rather than using party labels to sort through information, many voters end up embracing their party's full platform without much thought. This kind of shortcut isn't about saving time. It's about a broader system manipulating your psychological needs to tell you what your political beliefs and aspirations are in the first place.

In a political system without parties, you could imagine people developing loyalty to independent politicians with no party affiliation, and maybe changing their positions when that politician changes positions. While it's true that voters might still try to resolve cognitive dissonance by aligning their views with a candidate's positions, the very act of researching individual candidates can foster more critical thinking and nuanced understanding than just using a political party as a shortcut. Candidate platforms would also change from election to election more often than party platforms. When voters take the time to delve into the specific policies and platforms of candidates, they are encouraged to evaluate the candidates on their merits rather than relying solely on

party affiliation. This critical evaluation can reduce the tendency to unreflectively adopt a party's entire platform and instead promote a more individualized and issue-based approach to voting.

In any case, candidates are required by U.S. elections, but parties are not. And partisanship adds an additional variable with high potential to lead to poor decisions driven by the desire to avoid cognitive dissonance.

Does it matter that many voters have irrational preferences? Many of the irrational private choices you make that have relatively little impact on other people, such as whether you follow a particular sport or prefer a particular board game. But in voting, your choices can lead to wars at home and abroad, restrict or expand access to abortion, affect access to homes and jobs, and tax and reallocate money for social purposes. Elections demand higher standards than most choices people make. People use irrational preferences in the marketplace as well, showing brand-name loyalty to Coca Cola, Netflix, or Toyota. But people are less willing to do so when they have substantial negative impacts on their pocketbooks. Since one's vote is not as decisive as one's consumer purchases, people are less likely to trust whatever the political equivalent of *Consumer Reports* or *Yelp* is to evaluate their decisions. Consumers don't always respond rationally to individual incentives, but at least there is an individual incentive. Social media companies like *Facebook* used fact-checkers for a time but ultimately decided the fact-checkers were unreliable. Studies on fact-checkers are new, and there is conflicting evidence on whether fact-checkers influence voters.[3]

Downs's theory of rational shortcuts is more wishful thinking than reality. Our identities and affiliations drive us to adopt party lines, often leading to cognitive dissonance and a compromise of personal beliefs. This dynamic, while simplifying decision-making, undermines genuine deliberation and rational choice. The consequences of these irrational preferences aren't trivial; irrational voting is changing other peoples' lives, sometimes for the worse, without a rational basis.

Parties and Antipathy to Outgroups

Another psychological feature undermining the rationality of party shortcuts is that political parties add to the number of in-groups and out-groups in society. As I will argue below, humans are probably predisposed to create in-groups and out-groups. Political parties exacerbate this problem by actively cultivating antipathy to the opposite party and

groups associated with that party. Parties get more donations, volunteers, and votes when they persuade people to see the other party as an out-group—not only incorrect, but malicious or at least highly undesirable. A dramatic example of this dynamic played out in September 2009 when US Representative Joe Wilson interrupted President Barack Obama during a joint session of Congress by shouting, "You lie!" Wilson apologized and his outburst sparked outrage and led to a formal reprimand from the House of Representatives. But it also energized Wilson's supporters. By framing his actions as a stand against a perceived adversary, Wilson raised an unprecedented $2.7 million in a single quarter. This surge in donations was nearly $1 million more than Wilson and his opponent collectively spent in his previous campaign and set the stage for the most expensive congressional race in South Carolina's history. The same year, Florida Representative Alan Grayson made headlines when he claimed on the House floor that the Republican healthcare plan was to "die quickly" if people got sick. The comment resonated with Democratic activists and donors who viewed it as a bold stand against perceived GOP indifference to healthcare reform. He raised over $1 million in the quarter following the incident, leveraging the polarizing statement to position himself as a fighter for progressive causes.[4]

It is in a political party's interest to make "others" out of members of the opposite party. People are more easily motivated by fear than opportunity, and appealing to antipathy to out-groups works better than appealing to affinity with in-groups. Many social psychologists believe humans crave belonging to an in-group to the point where they oppose out-group gains at cost to themselves. Parties provide ready-made in-groups where people feel justified in opposing out-groups because the out-groups not only identify differently, but are morally flawed.

Psychology experiments performed after the Holocaust show how easily a party, or any group with something in common, could hypothetically turn people against other parties. Polish social psychologist Henri Tajfel conducted an experiment to investigate how different groups needed to be for individuals to exhibit discriminatory behavior. Tajfel initially divided research subjects into groups based on minimal differences, asking them to estimate the number of dots briefly displayed to the room. Participants were informed that they would be seated at different tables based on how many dots they thought they saw. Subsequently, participants were presented with a choice: they could either allocate more money to everyone in the room, or they could opt for their table to

receive less money while ensuring that other tables received even less. Surprisingly, participants chose the latter option, indicating a willingness to sacrifice personal gain to disadvantage those in groups of people with trivial differences. This preference suggested a desire for in-group superiority, even if it meant being poorer overall. The seating arrangement was actually random, underscoring the arbitrary nature of group divisions in Tajfel's experiment. Similar experiments have repeatedly confirmed Tajfel's findings.

Since estimating dots is not a sign of a moral virtue or failing, they were discriminating against others for no other reason than feeling like part of a group. Furthermore, belonging to a group that included everyone (the whole room, in his experiment) was not enough to satisfy people's desire for inclusion. Tajfel concluded that people crave belonging into a group that does not treat everyone equally. If people are willing to discriminate based on dot estimation, imagine how willing they are to discriminate when they believe the differences are rooted in morals, such as religion or politics. Political scientist Lilliana Mason has shown in her research that dislike of the other political party has increased over time even though people's ideology and issue positions have not changed nearly as much. People have therefore shown more antipathy toward out-groups even though they lack moral reasons to show more antipathy than before. Mason concludes that parties used to have more heterogeneous constituent groups. Today, they are increasingly neatly sorted along the lines of race, sex, religion, region, and education. There used to be more rural Democrats and urban Republicans. Today, there is a Democratic Party that is increasingly multiracial, secular, female, educated, and urban, and a Republican Party that is increasingly Christian, religious, male, rural, and suspicious of college education. Since there are more group identities embedded in the parties over time, there is more antagonism between the parties and the groups associated with parties.[5]

When parties were more heterogeneous, they were less useful as a shortcut because party labels were less likely to predict a candidate's stand. Now that parties are more homogenous, the shortcut is more accurate but the in-group/out-group mentality is worse. People systematically overestimate how different members of the other party are in terms of issue positions[6] as well as demographic features like race, gender identity, class, and religion.[7] Take a quiz designed to determine how well you know the demographic facts about political parties, and how far off partisans are. (The answers are in the footnote.)

1. What percentage of Democrats are agnostics or atheists?
   a. What percentage do Republicans estimate?
2. What percentage of Democrats are Black?
   a. What percentage do Republicans estimate?
3. What percentage of Democrats identify as LGBTQ?
   a. What percentage do Republicans estimate?
4. What percentage of Democrats are union members?
   a. What percentage do Republicans estimate?
5. What percentage of Republicans are older than 65?
   a. What percentage do Democrats estimate?
6. What percentage of Republicans are Evangelical Christians?
   a. What percentage do Democrats estimate?
7. What percentage of Republicans are Southerners?
   a. What percentage do Democrats estimate?
8. What percentage of Republicans earn more than $250,000 per year?
   a. What percentage do Democrats estimate?[8]

If you are like most Americans who belong to a party, you overestimated the differences somewhere between 10 and 40%. *New York Times* columnist Ezra Klein points out that partisans are *more* likely to provide more inaccurate estimates as they become more informed, except for the question about Republican income.[9] Republicans and Democrats also wrongly believe that most members of the other party want schools to either whitewash America's sins or skip America's accomplishments.[10]

In 1960, only 5% of Republicans and 4% of Democrats would be upset if their child married someone from a different political party. By 2020, the figure was 38% for both parties.[11] In 1978, people rated rival party members as a 48 on a scale of 1–100; today, the figure is 19.[12] Experimental studies conducted by Iyengar and Westwood further demonstrate the pervasiveness of partisan bias, showing that individuals prioritize political affiliation over merit in nonpolitical contexts, such as scholarship awards. When presented with résumés containing a political identity cue,

around 80% of Democrats and Republicans favored their co-partisan, irrespective of the candidate's GPA. This bias toward co-partisans surpassed biases based on racial identity. Moreover, implicit-association tests reveal that partisan bias is as prevalent, if not more so, than racial bias.[13]

Parties and Motivated Reasoning

Have you ever tried to calmly and logically persuade people from an opposing party to reconsider their beliefs? Chances are, the outcome wasn't pleasant. I rarely encounter the same level of emotional attachment people show to political parties when it comes to other shortcuts, like brand names. When Toyota enthusiasts are presented with evidence of flaws in a new Toyota model they intend to purchase, they don't usually get as defensive or hostile as they do when their political beliefs are challenged. When people at the checkout counter bury their heads in the sand the way ostriches are (wrongly) thought to do, they lose money.

Compared with brand names, political parties are more likely to encourage *motivated reasoning*: processing information in a way that supports what we already believe. Motivated reasoning is common whenever individual or group identity is at stake. As Haidt puts it, the emotional tail wags the rational dog; our moral intuition come first and strategic reasoning follows.[14] Partisanship colors how we see the facts before we even begin to assess them. People often look to their political party for answers, even when a situation calls for nonpartisan thinking. Instead of adjusting their response based on the latest evidence, people stick rigidly to their party's stance.

To be sure, motivated reasoning isn't unique to politics or political parties. People often respond emotionally when their religion, family, fandoms, or hobbies are challenged. Just as movie fans sometimes have meltdowns on social media over casting decisions, political parties tap into a deep well of identity and belonging.[15] What sets political parties apart is how they layer one group identity on top of another—and then another—and then another. When political parties become group identities, compromise feels like a betrayal. This makes it more difficult to cultivate the thoughtful citizenry that a thriving democracy requires. Moreover, individuals often signal loyalty to their group by embracing its most indefensible positions. Simply repeating widely accepted, reasonable claims doesn't distinguish members from outsiders, so making outlandish assertions becomes a more effective way to prove group affiliation. For

example, one might demonstrate partisan bona fides by endorsing President Trump's widely discredited claim that his first inauguration had the largest crowd in history.

During the Iraq War, for example, the belief that Iraq had weapons of mass destruction persisted and strengthened after the victorious US military found none.[16] During the second impeachment of President Trump, a poll asked whether revelations from congressional hearings would change your views. Independent voters were 14–15% more likely than Democrats or Republicans to change their mind. If the poll exclusively surveyed authentic independent voters, and not just self-identified independent voters, the percentage would have likely been even higher.[17]

People also adjust their beliefs on fundamental civil liberties based on party affiliation. The National Security Agency (NSA) conducts warrantless surveillance on American citizens to prevent terrorism. Whether people consider this a threat to civil liberties depends partially on the party of the sitting president. More individuals tolerate NSA surveillance when their own party occupies the White House. Democrats were notably more accepting of surveillance during President Obama's tenure in 2013 than Bush in 2006, despite revelations that the surveillance intensified over time. Independent voters once again remained more consistent than partisans in this poll. Executive power like surveillance becomes institutionalized over time; once the door is opened, it does not close when a new party controls the White House.[18]

Likewise, Republicans became far more favorable toward Vladimir Putin in 2016, when their own party's nominee had good things to say about him, and were even more favorable after allegations surfaced that Putin helped elect Trump.[19] In 2012, Republican nominee Mitt Romney called Russia America's greatest foreign policy threat. After President Trump ordered a strike on Iranian nuclear facilities in June 2025, Republican support for the bombing increased by more than 40%, reflecting a tendency to rally behind a president of their own party. Democratic support dropped by about 20%, indicating a partisan response in opposition to a president from the opposing party. As in other cases, independent voters were less likely to shift their views.[20]

People might still cling to their ideologies and resist information that challenges their beliefs even without parties. But seminal political science research by Philip Converse showed that party identification is far more stable than voter ideology or issue positions.[21] As the surveys above show,

independent voters are more open to new information, and less likely to change their views on civil liberties based on who is in office.

When a candidate runs independently, they can build a strong personal brand and take specific positions that resonate with voters. Compared with individual candidates, parties have a large and long-standing network backing them, reinforcing groupthink across a larger segment of voters. Party discipline and coordinated messaging create a stronger and more pervasive influence than an independent candidate could manage alone. Party primaries push candidates to calcify their positions as they compete over who aligns better with the party's core values. Parties also tend to form more permanent coalitions, whereas a more fluid system of political factions might make it easier for factions to adapt and collaborate in the future.[22]

Can We Have Democracy Without Motivated Reasoning?

Political Theorist Russell Muirhead argues that political parties are crucial for maintaining democracy because they provide a cohesive group identity and simplify political engagement. Unlike the Enlightenment thinkers who hoped for a political entity of autonomous thinkers, Muirhead argues that there are never enough people capable of thinking independently for a democracy to function effectively. Parties, according to Muirhead, use group unity and rhetoric to involve a larger segment of society, making it easier for people to participate in politics. Without parties, he argues, democracy would be chaotic and unstable because individuals would lack a unifying structure around which to organize their beliefs and political actions. Another political theorist, Nancy Rosenblum, contends that independent voters benefit from the organizational work done by parties without contributing to it. Political parties provide a necessary service by organizing political debate and clarifying vote choices, and independent voters and candidates rely on this structure without actively helping to build or maintain it.

Contra Muirhead and Rosenblum, many democratic systems do support a range of independent and issue-based organizations that foster political engagement. Some voters disagree with their parties on at least some issues. This indicates some amount of reasoning, whether it be adherence to a belief system, evidence from personal experience, or evaluation of a political candidate based on their personal qualities. If they

can reason their way to disagreement with a party, why are they not capable of reasoning their way across a broader range of issues? Independent candidates like Senator Bernie Sanders and Angus King articulate their positions without depending on parties for a framework. Sanders consistently championed progressive policies such as Medicare for All and free college education, which were not originally mainstream positions within either major party. Similarly, Ross Perot's independent presidential campaigns in the 1990s brought significant attention to fiscal responsibility and government reform, issues that were not prioritized by the major parties at the time.

If people truly follow the beliefs of opinion leaders, then it raises the question of why we should bother with rule by the many at all. Engaging through diverse, issue-focused groups can still provide structure and drive participation without the need for all-encompassing party frameworks. For example, movements like civil rights or environmental activism have successfully mobilized people around specific causes, demonstrating that political engagement can be nurtured through means other than party loyalty.

Muirhead acknowledges the issue of excessive groupthink within political parties and advocates for improving partisanship rather than abandoning it altogether. He envisions a form of partisanship where parties present clear visions of the common good and engage with opposing views constructively. We should have better partisanship, not weaker partisanship. Whether this is possible depends on how deeply rooted bad partisanship is in the very nature of partisanship. Could something in the very nature of college fraternities contribute to problematic fraternity behavior, or is the solution simply "better fraternities"? Is the issue with the institution itself or just bad implementation? This perspective invites us to reflect on whether enhancing existing systems is always the best solution, or if rethinking their fundamental nature might be necessary for meaningful improvement.

Partisanship plants the seeds for bad partisanship. If parties want to maximize turnout and enthusiasm, it is in their incentive to encourage extreme group identity over policy visions. People who acknowledge some good points in another party are less likely to participate. There is a trade-off between thoughtful deliberation and participation,[23] and the partisan incentive is to promote the latter over the former. Group identity and

antipathy to outgroups provides a much more effective basis for strong feelings, which motivate political activity, than issue beliefs like taxes or disaster relief.[24]

Political Parties and Mental Health

Have you ever stayed up later than you should because you were arguing with a random stranger on the internet, ultimately inconsequential to your life and your interests? If you have, you understand how political polarization can crank up stress and anxiety levels. Parties often thrive on this polarization, using it to fire up their base by painting the opposition in a negative light, which makes people more likely to vote, get involved, and ignore any positive aspects of the other side. Research confirms the adverse effects of polarized politics, which parties encourage, on mental health. One study finds that between 50 and 85 million Americans blame politics for making them feel exhausted, sleepless, and angry. People also turn to politics compulsively, binging on political news and posting things they later regret.[25]

What's really concerning is that about 5% of adults (around 12 million people) say politics has led them to have suicidal thoughts.[26] Another recent study points out that it's not just one's personal political views causing stress but the overall sense of living in a polarized world. This feeling alone can make people uneasy and anxious, creating a broader sense of societal tension that impacts everyone, even those without extreme views.[27] Polarization can actually keep people from making connections with friends and neighbors because of differing political and social views.[28] Parties also cause citizens to turn against other citizens. Long ago, Thomas Jefferson warned that parties made enemies of neighbors, causing citizens to "cross the streets and turn their heads the other way, lest they should be obliged to touch their hats."[29] This social isolation means that when people need support due to illness or other issues, they have fewer people to rely on.

As long as politics are inevitable, people will be stressed from politics. The question is how much political parties amplify that stress because they thrive on polarization. We have some evidence based on the consumption of partisan news. Consuming political media raises stress levels across the board, whether you're a Democrat, Republican, or independent. But those who watch partisan news, like Rachel Maddow or Tucker Carlson, report higher stress levels compared to those who stick to more neutral

news sources like C-SPAN or BBC. If partisan media is making political stress worse, partisanship itself may be making stress worse.[30]

Cognitive behavioral therapists warn depressed patients against "catastrophizing," or making overly negative predictions about the future. A team of researchers found that political awareness correlates with depression. Parties depend on depicting the political situation as dire in order to win. While some might argue that depression reflects a realistic view of political problems, depression can also distort reality.[31] Right now, we have correlational data rather than experimental proof of this cycle. It would be useful to study whether well-informed independent voters experience less stress compared to well-informed partisans. Since independent voters are generally less informed, findings that partisans are more stressed might just reflect a lack of awareness about distressing information. Still, combined with the other issues discussed, the impact of partisanship on mental health is troubling.

As long as parties push for polarization and catastrophic thinking, they contribute to increased stress, anxiety, and social isolation. And they are rewarded electorally for doing so.

Parties and Public Health

The psychological pitfalls of parties also took a toll on public health during the COVID-19 pandemic, an unprecedented global crisis that caused millions of deaths, countless hospitalizations, and significant hardships faced by individuals and families. As we tried to make sense of lockdowns, social distancing, and constantly changing guidelines, it became obvious that the public debate was not just shaped by scientific models, but also party politics. The pandemic illustrates many of the problems with parties that we have discussed in this chapter.

Republican levels of concern about the virus varied with their president. At first, many didn't take COVID-19 as seriously as Democrats did, but their attitude shifted dramatically depending on Trump's stance. For example, early on, Democrats were far more likely to search for hand sanitizer on Google, but after Trump endorsed lockdowns in mid-March 2020, both parties' search habits evened out. A study even found that before COVID-19, there was no significant difference in hand sanitizer searches based on political support.[32] Similarly, surveys consistently showed that Democrats were more likely than Republicans to be "extremely concerned" about COVID-19 no matter the state, even in

smaller, densely populated ones like Hawaii and Rhode Island where the urban/rural divide matters less.[33]

More importantly, Republicans were more hesitant about getting COVID-19 vaccines when they were introduced in 2021. This reluctance was a big factor in Republican-led states' higher death rates from the virus, even after adjusting for the fact that Republicans are generally older. Despite the United States having more vaccines and being among the first to roll them out, this vaccine resistance probably contributed more than anything else to the high COVID-19 death rate here compared to other developed countries.[34] When taking the COVID-19 vaccine became coded as Democratic, Republicans were less likely to get not only the COVID-19 vaccine, but other vaccines. There was no difference between party members in 2016 and 2020, but in 2021, 68% of Democrats reported having received a flu shot or being very likely to get one, compared to just 44% of Republicans. This is similar to the partisan gap in COVID-19 vaccination.[35] Likewise, the HPV vaccine faced more pushback compared to the less politicized hepatitis B vaccine, showing how partisanship can shape our reactions to health measures.[36] Following the COVID-19 pandemic, Americans in general are about 20–30% less likely to see childhood vaccines as important, compared to 2019. Republicans and Republican-leaning independent voters account for almost all of this decline.[37]

This is a good example of how parties contribute to motivated reasoning separately from ideology. It is not inherently conservative to oppose quarantines. Some conservatives in the Reagan administration considered quarantines to contain the AIDS epidemic in the 1980s, though not the president or his surgeon general. In 2005, President George W. Bush also announced the right to use the National Guard to enforce a quarantine should there be a pandemic. Political psychologists know that conservatives tend to rank higher on a personality trait labeled "conscientiousness," which emphasizes cleanliness, orderliness, and compliance with rules. Conservatives are also more sensitive to disgust, which can be provoked by germs. To the extent that Trump expanded his following by being the symbolic head of his party, opposition to COVID-19 containment was partisan-driven, not ideology-driven. Therefore, partisanship caused Republicans to oppose measures to contain COVID-19 in a way that ideology did not.

Motivated reasoning also interfered with the Democrats' ability to adapt their public policy based on the latest evidence. The Democratic

presidential ticket in 2020 was skeptical of the vaccine, seemingly to avoid crediting the president with anything. In September, then-presidential candidate Joe Biden said that "The enormous pressure being put on the FDA to say they're going, that the following protocol will in fact reduce, it will have a giant impact on COVID. All these things turn out not to be true, and when a president continues to mislead and lie, when we finally do, God willing, get a vaccine, who's going to take the shot? Who's going to take the shot? You going to be the first one to say, 'Put me—sign me up, they now say it's OK'? I'm not being facetious."[38] Vice Presidential candidate Kamala Harris also voiced her doubts, saying, "If the public health professionals, if Dr. Fauci, if the doctors tell us that we should take it, I'll be the first in line to take it. Absolutely. But if Donald Trump tells us that we should take it, I'm not taking it."[39] In reality, scientists were confident in the quickly developed vaccine from the start, thanks to the pre-existing research that had created the mRNA technology that was foundational to the vaccine.[40] At a time when parties needed to present a united front to encourage vaccines among all Americans, the Democratic ticket initially encouraged vaccine hesitancy; but when elected to office, President Biden instantly developed plans to distribute the very same vaccine. We can only guess how things might have been different if the vaccine had been rolled out during a second Trump term rather than under Biden. Biden said the pandemic was over in 2022, and time has vindicated his judgment. One wonders when Democratic leaders would have accepted the same presidential pronouncement in 2022 if Trump served a second term.

Democratic-controlled states kept up strict lockdown measures for a long time, even after vaccines became available. Lockdowns exacted a high cost on children and their guardians. Kids who were in online public schools, lacking the financial means for private schools or "pods," fell about two years behind in reading and math compared to their peers who went to school in person. Plus, toddlers who went without traditional contact with other children ended up with delayed verbal, social, and motor skill development compared to kids from before the pandemic.[41] Studies published before the pandemic showed that online schooling was not nearly as effective but some Democratic politicians argued that it would be.[42] Future Democratic Vice Presidential candidate Tim Walz said "These kids learned resiliency… These kids learned problem-solving. They had to figure out how to get online and do this."[43] Florida reopened schools in August 2020, a year earlier than some other states. In

the end, Florida's age-adjusted death rate ended up similar to California's, where public schools stayed closed for another year.[44]

In fact, pediatricians had initially agreed that schools should reopen. In July 2020, the American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) released a strong statement urging a return to in-person instruction during the fall based on evidence that school closures were hurting children's intellectual and emotional development, as well as their mental health. At first, this looked like a rare moment when scientific consensus could cut through partisan divisions. But after President Trump publicly endorsed their statement and began pressuring schools to reopen, the AAP changed its mind. Within days, it issued a joint statement with Democratically-aligned teachers' unions walking back their position and saying that school re-openings should vary with local conditions and in collaboration with teachers.[45] The science hadn't changed, but the politics had. The AAP's pivot shows that scientists that are supposed to embody objectivity revise their messaging when it aligns with the wrong political party.

One might argue that challengers will criticize incumbents on public health policies in nonpartisan as well as partisan systems. But in a nonpartisan system, issue positions are less reflexive and candidates might not feel the need to oppose their opponents on every single issue. Take H. Ross Perot in 1992: he wasn't affiliated with any party, but he found common ground with both Democrats and Republicans on some points. Unlike party-affiliated politicians, who often paint the other side as wrong on every public debate, independent candidates can be more selective about where they disagree. A system that frowns on partisanship may even punish candidates who take such an all-or-nothing perspective. The pressure to take extreme positions might be lower and without the backing of party-associated media, independent candidates could face tougher scrutiny from the public and media, which might help correct any misinformation they spread.

This isn't just about a particular party's missteps; it's about how the entire party system, by promoting division and rigid adherence to party lines, can lead to outcomes that harm the public physically and mentally. To be sure, some degree of candidate-centered politics, ideologies, and media personalities would cloud people's judgments on serious issues even in the absence of parties. This chapter presents important evidence that parties make it worse.

Conclusion

Political parties can be like a helpful GPS for voters, giving them a shortcut through the maze of policy positions and candidate preferences. But imagine a GPS that avoids neighborhoods that your peers do not like. In that case, you might be better off figuring out the route on your own. Political parties are like a GPS designed by such a peer group.

This possibility shows how relying on party cues can lead to some serious downsides. Many people choose which party to support based on random factors like their parents' or social group's party affiliation, rather than figuring out which party actually matches their own views. Or they adopt a parties' positions across the board based on agreement on one or two issues. If voters took the time to evaluate candidates independently of party labels, they might vote for their authentic preferences.

Political parties may be inevitable for the foreseeable future, but there are ways to lessen their influence. As we examine the effects of partisanship on both physical and mental health, it's worth questioning whether this is the best democracy can offer. We should hope it isn't the final form of democracy.

Notes

1. Haidt, J., 2012. *The righteous mind: Why good people are divided by politics and religion*. New York: Pantheon Books.
2. Achen, C.H. and Bartels, L.M. (2016) *Democracy for Realists: Why Elections Do Not Produce Responsive Government*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, Chapter 9.
3. Nyhan, B., Porter, E., Reifler, J. et al. (2020) Taking fact-checks literally but not seriously? The effects of journalistic fact-checking on factual beliefs and candidate favorability. *Political Behavior* 42: 939–960.
4. Klein, E. (2020) *Why we're polarized*. New York: Avid Reader Press.
5. Mason, L. (2018) *Uncivil Agreement: How Politics Became Our Identity*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
6. Fernbach, P.M. and Van Boven, L. (2022) False polarization: Cognitive mechanisms and potential solutions. *Current Opinion in Psychology* 43: 1–6. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2021.06.005.

7. Ahler, D.J. and Sood, G. (2018) The parties in our heads: Misperceptions about party composition and their consequences. *The Journal of Politics* 80(3): 964–981.
8. 1: 9%, 1a: 36% (difference 27%). 2: 24%, 2a: 46% (difference 22%). 3: 6%, 3a: 38% (difference 32%). 4: 11%, 4a 44% (difference 33%). 5: 21%, 5a 44% (difference 23%). 6: 34%, 6a: 44% (difference 10%). 7: 36%, 7a: 44% (difference 8%). 8: 2%, 8a: 44% (difference 42%).
9. Klein, E. (2020) *Why we're polarized*. New York: Avid Reader Press.
10. Hawkins, S., Vallone, D., Oshinski, P., Xu, C., Small, C., Yudkin, D., Duong, F. and Wylie, J. (2022) *Defusing the History Wars: Finding Common Ground in Teaching America's National Story*. More in Common.
11. Ballard, J. (2020) How Republicans and Democrats would feel if their child married across the political aisle. *YouGov*, 17 September.
12. American National Election Studies. (n.d.) Affective polarization of parties. *American National Election Studies*. Available at: https://electionstudies.org/data-tools/anes-guide/anes-guide.html?chart=affective_polarization_parties.
13. Iyengar, Shanto, and Sean J. Westwood. "Fear and loathing across party lines: New evidence on group polarization." *American journal of political science* 59, no. 3 (2015): 690-707.
14. Haidt, J., 2012. *The righteous mind: Why good people are divided by politics and religion*. New York: Pantheon Books.
15. That being said, some of these casting decisions might trace back to differences cultivated by political parties. For example, some people might oppose minority casting because it is coded as woke, or as support for Israel.
16. Somin, I. (2013) *Democracy and Political Ignorance: Why Smaller Government Is Smarter*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, pp. 79–80.
17. Marist Poll. (2019) Impeachment & the 2020 election. *Marist Poll*, 20 November. Available at: https://maristpoll.marist.edu/polls/npr-pbs-newshour-marist-poll-results-analysis-november-2019/#sthash.9n8A36SY.dpbs.
18. Pew Research Center. (2013) Majority views NSA phone tracking as acceptable anti-terror tactic. *Pew Research Center*, 10 June. Available at: https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2013/06/10/majority-views-nsa-phone-tracking-as-acceptable-anti-terror-tactic/.

19. Prokop, A. (2016) The change in Republican voters' views of Putin since Trump's rise is remarkable. *Vox*, 14 December.
20. YouGov and *The Economist*, 2025. Poll on U.S. military action against Iranian nuclear facilities, June 21–23, 2025. *The Economist*.
21. Converse, P.E. (2006) The nature of belief systems in mass publics (1964). *Critical Review* 18 (1–3): 1–74.
22. See Chapter 5 for a lengthier discussion of this. While this book focuses on the American two-party system, other countries have multiparty systems that allow for fluid alliances. Parties form and dissolve coalitions with other parties as circumstances change.
23. Mutz, D.C. (2006) *Hearing the Other Side: Deliberative versus Participatory Democracy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
24. Mason, L. (2018) *Uncivil Agreement: How Politics Became Our Identity*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
25. Smith, K.B. (2022) Politics is making us sick: The negative impact of political engagement on public health during the Trump administration. *Plos One* 17(1).
26. Smith, K.B. (2022) Politics is making us sick: The negative impact of political engagement on public health during the Trump administration. *Plos One* 17(1).
27. Nayak, S.S., Fraser, T., Panagopoulos, C., Aldrich, D.P. and Kim, D. (2021) Is divisive politics making Americans sick? Associations of perceived partisan polarization with physical and mental health outcomes among adults in the United States. *Social Science & Medicine* 284: 113976.
28. Fraser, T., Aldrich, D.P., Panagopoulos, C., Hummel, D. and Kim, D. (2022) The harmful effects of partisan polarization on health. *PNAS Nexus* 1(1): pgac011.
29. Quoted in Ceaser, J.W. (1978) Political parties and presidential ambition. *The Journal of Politics* 40(3): 708–739.
30. Ford, B.Q., Feinberg, M., Lassetter, B., Thai, S. and Gatchpazian, A. (2023) The political is personal: The costs of daily politics. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 125(1): 1.
31. Gimbrone C, Bates LM, Prins SJ, Keyes KM. The politics of depression: Diverging trends in internalizing symptoms among US adolescents by political beliefs. SSM Mental Health. 2022 Dec;2; al-Gharbi, Musa. "How to Understand the Well-Being Gap between Liberals and Conservatives." *American Affairs*, March 21, 2023.

32. Schaffner, B. (2020) Partisanship and responses to the coronavirus outbreak. *Google Sites*, 23 March. Available at: https://sites.google.com/view/brianfschaffner/code-for-twitter-graphs.
33. The Guardian. (2020) America's red–blue divide is reflected in how states respond to the coronavirus. *The Guardian*, 29 March. Originally available at: https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2020/mar/29/america-states-coronavirus-red-blue-different-approaches (no longer accessible).
34. Silver, N. (2023) The 2 key facts about US COVID policy that everyone should know. *Silver Bulletin*, 29 September.
35. Enten, H. (2021) Flu shots uptake is now partisan. It didn't use to be. *CNN*, 14 November. Available at: https://www.cnn.com/2021/11/14/politics/flu-partisan-divide-analysis/index.html.
36. Kahan, D. and Landrum, A.R. (2017) A tale of two vaccines—and their science communication environments. *In*: Jamieson, K.H., Kahan, D. and Scheufele, D.A. (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of the Science of Science Communication*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 165–172.
37. Jones, J.M. (2024) Far fewer in U.S. regard childhood vaccinations as important: Decline occurs among Republicans and Republican-leaning independents. *Gallup News*, 7 August.
38. ClickOrlando (2020) Q-and-A with former Vice President Joe Biden: Biden says he will visit Florida when it is safe to do so. *ClickOrlando*, 3 September. Available at: https://www.clickorlando.com/news/local/2020/09/03/q-and-a-with-former-vice-president-joe-biden/.
39. NBC News. (2020) Harris on vaccine: 'If Donald Trump tells us to take it, I'm not taking it.' *YouTube*, 30 September. Video, 1:37.
40. Dangerfield, K. (2020) Moderna designed its coronavirus vaccine in 2 days—here's how. *Global News*, 30 November.
41. Wong, A. (2022) Pandemic babies are behind after years of stress, isolation affected brain development. https://aliawong.com/pandemic-babies-are-behind-after-years-of-stress-isolation-affected-brain-development/
42. This was known even before the lockdowns. Heppen, J.B., Sorensen, N., Allensworth, E., Walters, K., Rickles, J., Stachel Taylor, S. and Michelman, V. (2016) The struggle to pass algebra: Online vs. face-to-face credit recovery for at-risk urban students.

Journal of Research on Educational Effectiveness 10(2): 272–296; Hart, C.M.D., Berger, D., Jacob, B., Loeb, S. and Hill, M. (2019) Online learning, offline outcomes: Online course taking and high school student performance. *AERA Open* 5(1): 2332858419832852. Ahn, J. and McEachin, A. (2017) Student enrollment patterns and achievement in Ohio's online charter schools. *Educational Researcher* 46(1): 44–57.

43. Levine, Jon, Deirdre Bardolf, and Matthew Sedacca. "Minnesota Education Plummeted under Democratic VP Pick Tim Walz's Leadership: Critics." *New York Post*, August 10, 2024.
44. Levine, J., Bardolf, D. and Sedacca, M. (2024) Minnesota education plummeted under Democratic VP pick Tim Walz's leadership: Critics. *New York Post*, 10 August;

    Bioinformatics CRO. (n.d.) States ranked by age-adjusted COVID deaths. *Bioinformatics CRO Blog*. Available at: https://www.bioinformaticscro.com/blog/states-ranked-by-age-adjusted-covid-deaths/.
45. Zweig, D. (2024) *An Abundance of Caution: Restoring the Public's Trust after the COVID-19 Pandemic*. New York: Center Street.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

PART II

Political Parties and Democracy

CHAPTER 3

What Parties Are and Why It Matters

Abstract This chapter explores two major frameworks for understanding political parties: the UCLA Theory of Parties and the candidate-centered model. The UCLA Theory posits that parties are dominated by interest groups and activists who shape platforms to advance narrow goals rather than broad voter preferences. The candidate-centered model views parties as coalitions of ambitious politicians seeking to maximize votes and win elections by taking positions distinct to each candidate. History offers evidence for both models. Candidate-centered parties tend to be more accountable to the public because candidates will be more responsive to the median voter than special interests that play a strong role in party primaries.

Keywords Abortion · Candidate-centered politics · Civil rights · Christian right · Evangelical Christians · Factions · Ideology · Intense policy demanders · Interest groups · Labor unions · Party primaries · Project 2025 · Realignment · The UCLA theory of parties

Imagine it's the 1850s. In the midst of the tumultuous political landscape of pre-Civil War America, the Republican Party emerges from the ashes of failed coalitions and shifting alliances. Picture a group of abolitionists, businessmen, former Whigs, Free Soilers, and disenchanted Democrats huddled together, not because they all shared a common ideology, but

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_3

to create a coalition large enough to beat the South in elections. This story isn't just a historical curiosity; it's a vivid illustration of how political parties are formed and transformed by shifting alliances, strategic calculations, and the quest for power. Parties can emerge not from a single, cohesive ideology, but from a mix of motivations and interests; not from ordinary voters or politicians, but activists.

As we delve into the nature of political parties and their role in governance, this episode underscores why understanding their dynamics is crucial. Are political parties mainly tools for winning elections or are they coalitional bargains made by organized groups of activists, or some mixture of both? The answer to this question is not just a curiosity for students of political behavior—it also reveals how representative and effective our democratic system truly is. Parties play a huge role in elections and governance, but defining their essential features isn't straightforward.

In his classic work on politics, Anthony Downs applies economic principles to political science, suggesting that parties are like "brand names" created by candidates to win elections. According to Downs, parties aim to be close to the political center but also need to appeal to more extreme voters to stand out. This "candidate-centered" view reflects a shift from the earlier system where parties had more control over nominations and campaigns. Downs' theory is one of many in a long line of "candidate-centered" parties. Parties once nominated candidates without voter input and ran campaigns on behalf of candidates. As the last vestiges of this system were removed in the 1970s, politics seemed more candidate-centered than ever.

In contrast, a newer theory called the "UCLA Theory of Parties" views parties as coalitions of organized groups that come together to support candidates who will advance their agendas. Groups—or factions, if you will—such as unions, businesses, and religious groups coalesce because they are not large enough to win a majority of votes on their own. They form parties to nominate candidates acceptable to themselves and their allies. The factions wield more interest than rank and file voters because they offer essential campaign needs such as volunteers, money, and word of mouth. While factions want electable candidates, parties are more often tools of the factions rather than tools of candidates.

Deciding which model better defines parties matters because it affects how we think parties affect political representation. Downs' model assumes that parties exist mainly to win elections and that the most self-serving politicians—those who chase votes—will naturally align with

what most voters want. In this view, parties stay close to the median voter's preferences to stay competitive. On the other hand, the UCLA Theory argues that parties can become more extreme due to the influence of dedicated, ideologically driven factions. These active members might push the party away from the center and less engaged voters might not notice the shift. If Downs is right, parties would be responsive to public opinion, making democracy work better. But if the UCLA Theory holds true, parties might cater more to extreme views, potentially leading to a disconnect between what the party represents and what the general public wants.

Elaborating on the Models of Party

In Downs' model of political parties, parties are representative of the public. Politicians are motivated primarily to be elected and reelected, and will only use parties insofar as they help politicians win. Downs believed the most selfish politicians are the most representative ones because they'll do anything to stay in office, including listening to voters. Those chasing moral rectitude or ideological purity might ignore public opinion. But vote-chasers can't afford to. If parties are their tools, they will also ensure parties stick close to what voters want.

Downs thought parties would aim to be ideologically close to the center because centrist voters were more numerous. But just as Coke cannot defeat Pepsi in marketplace competition by tasting exactly the same, parties cannot offer the exact same bundle of issue positions in the middle. They also have to give more extreme voters a reason to prefer their party by offering a bundle somewhat closer to extreme voters than the center.

Voters who aren't as extreme as the parties they support might push back if they see the parties moving too far to the right or left. For example, in 2022, some voters might have turned away from the Republican Party because it was linked with very strict anti-abortion views after the *Dobbs v. Jackson* decision.[1] Similarly, politicians like Kari Lake who questioned Biden's 2020 win faced backlash in the general election.[2] So, when parties or candidates go too extreme, it can sometimes cost them votes.

But the insight from the UCLA Theory of Parties is that not all voters are equally active or attentive. Why would rational parties nominate candidates who believe in bizarre conspiracy theories or extreme positions on abortion? The more active and attentive Republicans preferred these

extreme positions and fought harder for their nominations than median voters. Some of them were willing to risk losing elections if it kept the Republican Party in line with their views. Their perspective apparently was, "nothing ventured, nothing gained."

Nonetheless, parties can often find a halfway point between extreme factions and general election voters. At this point, parties are more extreme than the median voter but not so extreme that the median voter will notice. The UCLA theorists call this the "blind spot," analogous to the blind spot in cars where perfectly sighted people might miss the car behind them if they are not careful. But in politics, a car crash is someone else's problem and potentially someone else's life. But elections seldom mean life or death to the typical person casting a vote, and even when they do, any one voter was not likely to be the decisive factor. With the blind spot on a car, failing to check can be a decisive cause of an accident, and so drivers check blind spots more carefully than voters do. So, plenty of voters are not paying careful attention to politics, and as a result, parties can comfortably be somewhat extreme without voters noticing.

Venerable political scientist E.E. Schattschneider knew this happened and still thought parties played a vital role in a healthy democracy. Mass opinion is chaotic and parties create order out of the chaos by presenting the public with understandable choices. But if voters are just parroting the views of party factions, then it's really the informed few who are calling the shots, with the illusion of rule by the many. At a certain point, the preferences of the mass public could be different enough from the party elites that chaotic mass opinion, uninformed by parties, might actually be more representative.

In the definitive statement of the UCLA Theory of Parties,[3] Bawn et al. depict parties as a coalitional bargain between primarily member-interest organizations. They begin with a hypothetical state with no parties. But there are factions such as coffee growers who want highways to ship their grain, shepherds who want wool tariffs, clergy who want to close saloons on Sunday, saloon keepers who want saloons open on Sundays, and teachers who want more funding for schools. Most of these groups can form a partnership to win an election. Even if they have no interest in each other's issues, they are more likely to obtain what they want working together to nominate candidates.

Nominating candidates makes them a party. If teachers ally with saloon keepers, they call themselves the "Freedom party," while the coffee growers, shepherds, and clergy form the "Heritage Party." They give

their coalitions lofty-sounding names to hide the transactional nature of the alliance. A "Teachers Party" or a "Coffee Growers Party" would not win or excite volunteers. But Bawn et al. argue that other coalitions are equally plausible. Saloon keepers could ally with coffee growers as a "Globalist Party" and support free trade, while clergy, shepherds, and teachers support a "Protectionist Party."

The implication is that different coalitional partnerships could have made different parties, and ideology was largely fungible. Does it make a lot of ideological sense that, for most of our history, the people who supported more rights for African Americans opposed immigrant rights, and vice versa? At different times, workers, farmers, unions, businesses, abolitionists, and civil rights groups formed the Federalists, Republicans, Whigs, and Democrats. Just like the coffee growers, these factions realized that they could not win without forming a coalition with other factions. Once they were well organized, candidates needed support from one of the two largest political parties.

In American history, some of the factions were driven by genuine moral convictions rather than just the personal interests of their members. These factions often had strong principles guiding their actions. However, there's an important distinction to make here. The preferences of these passionate groups were different from those of inactive or less attentive voters. That means that political parties might focus more on the needs and wants of their core supporters than the less engaged voters. And that's why we need to closely examine the evidence for each theory in the next two sections; understanding which theory holds up will have significant implications for how democracy functions and how representative our political system really is.

Evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties

When figuring out which model of political parties is more accurate, we should rely on solid evidence rather than just abstract theories and metaphors. Scholars who follow the UCLA approach point to behind-the-scenes coalition building, showing that party factions are often behind party nominations and changes during realignment periods. Those who support the candidate-centered model argue that candidates and party organizations can and do influence what parties stand for. Since candidates usually prefer to be seen as leading the charge, it's easier to find evidence supporting this model. After all, no candidate wants to be viewed

as merely catering to extreme activists or interest groups. The media has an incentive to portray campaign choices as crucial because that gives consumers a reason to follow the daily drama of campaigns.

Let's start with the evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties. American parties were mostly formed by factions, not just by politicians trying to win elections.[4] Furthermore, interest groups rather than politicians reintroduced political parties to California after they were effectively eliminated from ballots. Under the cross-filing system, the same candidate could appear under multiple party labels. Unions were frustrated that they were not accomplishing as much in the legislature, and pushed for a successful referendum that ended cross-filing. If politicians were the ones creating parties simply as tools for getting elected, why didn't they just reintroduce the party labels themselves?[5]

Occasionally, a candidate's actions support the UCLA model when they're caught making promises to activists in private. If a candidate says something that isn't likely to win over the general public but appeals to a specific group of activists and donors, it shows where their true priorities lie. With today's recording devices everywhere, these moments are more common. Take Barack Obama's 2008 primary campaign against Hillary Clinton: he was caught making a comment that seemed to insult Pennsylvania voters while speaking to a crowd of San Francisco donors. During his 2008 primary campaign, Obama suggested that working-class voters leaving the Democratic Party were simply blaming others for their problems, rather than recognizing that economic policies were the real issue. Whether or not this was a fair assessment, telling Pennsylvanians they were being unreasonable was probably not the best strategy to win their votes in a primary.[6] Obama was speaking candidly to a group of wealthy donors at the expense of alienating potential voters.

Similarly, in 2012, Republican nominee Mitt Romney also appeared willing to risk losing votes to cater to his donors. Romney was caught on tape at a fundraiser in Boca Raton insinuating that 47% of voters were moochers that he had no chance of winning over.[7] It's hard to imagine that Romney would win over voters this way but understandable that he thought it played well with donors. Finally, lawyer Bruce Braley ran for a Senate seat in the farm state of Iowa in 2012. He ran against Joni Ernst, whose first commercial boasted that she grew up on a farm castrating hogs. To rally support, Braley made a pitch to a group of lawyers by alienating farmers, declaring that "If you help me win this race, you may have someone with your background, your experience, your voice—someone

who's been literally fighting tort reform for 30 years in a visible and public way on the Senate Judiciary…Or you might have a farmer from Iowa who never went to law school, never practiced law, serving as the next chair of the Senate Judiciary. Because if Democrats lose the majority, Chuck Grassley will be the next chair of the Senate Judiciary." The incident underscores how candidates sometimes risk alienating broader voter bases to win over specific donor groups. Chuck Grassley was one of the most popular figures in the state.

These moments are few and far in between. More of these off-the-record moments are available decades later when documents, tape recordings, and emails are declassified. That's why my previous book, *First to the Party*,[8] turns to archival evidence to assess the UCLA Theory of Parties.

Parties are said to "realign" when they shift a broad range of their issue positions or when the factions supporting them change. If politicians orchestrate party realignment, the evidence fits better with Downs' model. If factions orchestrate party realignment, the evidence fits better with the UCLA model. Let's look at some relevant examples from *First to the Party*. Many scholars consider the Democratic Party's shift from the party of the Confederate flag to the party of Civil Rights to be the most important shift of the twentieth century. In the 1940s, civil rights groups were pushing for an anti-lynching law, the end of poll taxes, and a federal antidiscrimination law. By that time, both the Democratic and Republican parties were acutely aware that African American voters were becoming increasingly important in key Northern swing states that were crucial for winning the Electoral College. Both parties were eager to court these voters, with the Republicans even making more ambitious promises. However, neither party was willing to risk alienating their existing supporters until factions forced them to act. This shows that parties do not always maximize general election votes.

For example, congressional Republicans did nothing to advance their civil rights platform when they had a majority in Congress after World War II. Republican House Speaker Joe Martin publicly admitted that pushing for antidiscrimination laws would upset their industrial supporters. Within the Democratic Party, white Southerners remained a powerful faction that almost managed to nominate a staunch segregationist as Franklin Roosevelt's vice president in 1944, anticipating that Roosevelt might not complete his term. It was only due to the intervention of a rising

faction within the party—Big Labor's Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO)—that the Democrats ended up settling on Harry Truman as a compromise candidate. When Truman was planning his reelection campaign in 1948, he initially thought he had Southern support locked down. Because of this, he felt confident enough to promise a bold civil rights platform. However, he quickly backed off when Southern politicians started threatening to leave the party. Politicians, as a rule, are pretty cautious. They're elected by a specific mix of factions and generally don't want to risk losing those key supporters by trying to bring in a new, unfamiliar group. If they do change their positions, they usually prefer to strike a compromise that doesn't upset their current base too much.

The CIO and a liberal group called Americans for Democratic Action pushed through a bold civil rights platform in the 1948 Democratic Convention. Both packed the convention with their own delegates and passed a platform opposed by the Democratic president, party chair, and party leaders in the House and Senate. In 1960, when John F. Kennedy and Lyndon Johnson were running for president, they had to navigate their own tricky path with civil rights. They had not always supported civil rights when they were in the Senate. Although they weren't entirely sure that a strong civil rights stance would win those votes in the general election, they believed it was crucial for solidifying their party's support rather than just placating the Southern faction. Kennedy had been wooing Southern Democrats for years but now canceled appearances with Southern firebrands. The Democratic Platform controversially supported civil disobedience from the civil rights movement and enforcement of *Brown v. Board of Education* decision desegregating public schools. In 1964, Johnson again was not sure of whether shepherding a Civil Rights law would help him win the general election, but he was sure he needed to do it in order to solidify party support.

It wasn't the politicians who chose civil rights to win general elections. It wasn't the politicians who forged a partnership between unions and civil rights groups. These groups started working together on their own, which forced politicians to choose between them and the Southern faction.

Since the 1970s, ordinary voters have been selecting parties' presidential nominees through primary elections. In theory, primaries should make candidates more responsive to regular party voters rather than just party insiders. But the realignment of the Republican Party in the late 1970s offers additional evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties, because factions once again drove party change. Republicans today are the party of

Evangelical Christians and pro-life groups, but they used to be the party of mainstream Protestant groups like Episcopalians and Methodists. Evangelical Christians weren't nearly as involved in politics, and rank-and-file Republicans were actually more likely to be pro-choice.

Once again, politicians and rank-and-file voters did not play a strong role in the realignment. During Nixon's reelection campaign in 1972, he chose not to publicize a pro-life stance, though he had considered it because of the strong pro-life sentiments among Catholics. By the 1976 primaries, Ronald Reagan picked up on this, trying to win Catholic votes by emphasizing pro-life positions against incumbent Gerald Ford. Even so, Catholic support within the party remained mixed for years. Initially, party leaders didn't see the potential of this realignment. Republican National Committee Chair Bill Brock noted in the late 1970s, "You can't build a party around these emotional cultural issues and I'm not sure government can solve them. The New Right groups… draw attention in Congress from the broad issues of tax reduction, job creation, healthcare, housing—the American Dream issues. We can only become a majority party by bringing people around those issues."

The major shift came with evangelical Christians, who became the backbone of the Republican realignment. Many evangelicals began to see issues like abortion rights, gay rights, and gender equality as part of a secular humanist agenda that clashed with their religious beliefs. They took control of evangelical organizations like the Southern Baptist Convention and the National Association of Evangelicals without much help from politicians. Their opponents, including feminists, advocated for social welfare measures that aligned with economically liberal ideas, leading evangelicals to adopt more conservative economic positions.

Evangelicals were very active in Republican primaries, not because politicians encouraged them, but because they organized themselves. They deliberately operated in the "blind spot" of the public and politicians learned to win their support by stealth. For instance, religious broadcaster Pat Robertson ran for president in 1988, not so much to win as to grow his religious ministry. Campaign notices advised his followers to "keep your position on issues to yourself… come across as being interested in economic issues… Give the impression that you are there to work for the party, not to push an ideology… Hide your strength… Try not to let on that a close group of friends are becoming active in the party together… Don't flaunt your Christianity." George H.W. Bush, who wasn't an evangelical, was coached on how to appeal to them

without formally converting. He'd appear with evangelical athletes to signal his support in a way that resonated with evangelicals but didn't necessarily stand out to the general public. Robertson's Christian Coalition supported primary challenges to Republicans who didn't meet their standards. To win over this crucial base, almost all Republican presidential nominees from 1980 to 2024 (except for Bob Dole in 1996) shifted from pro-choice to pro-life. Candidates who refused to adapt, like Lamar Alexander and Rudy Giuliani, struggled to gain traction.

Political scientist David Karol shows that changes in party faction positions often lead to changes in party positions. Historically, workers were against tariffs because they made goods more expensive and farmers were against tariffs because they led other countries to put them on farm exports. The Democratic Party was traditionally anti-tariff, but as foreign competition started threatening blue-collar jobs in the 1960s, the party position began to shift. On the other hand, the Republican Party, which had long been supported by businesses wanting protection from foreign competition, saw a change after World War II. Businesses started to worry that tariffs could hurt their export markets. This concern led Eisenhower to become the first Republican president to back free trade.[9] Labor unions were also initially opposed to the Equal Rights Amendment (ERA) because they feared it might eliminate job protections that favored male workers for heavy-lifting jobs. However, when courts invalidated those protective laws, unions started supporting the ERA. This shift in support also reflected in the Democratic Party, where feminist-leaning teachers' unions, which emerged in the 1970s as manufacturing unions declined, began to influence Democratic politicians more than the older manufacturing unions did.[10]

Parties evolve not by design, but through friction between factions and candidates. It's not a happy story if you want parties that cater to median voters. My research shows that party realignments often stem from shifting faction interests, like how unions and civil rights groups have driven changes in party positions over time. While candidates play a role cater to specific groups behind closed doors, factions pushing parties to adapt are the real driving force behind party realignment.

Evidence for Candidate-Centered Parties

In this section, we'll explore the idea that the influence of individual candidates, rather than just party structures or factions, play a crucial role in shaping political dynamics. Proponents of this view argue that significant shifts in party policies and priorities often hinge on the actions of key figures. In at least some cases, influential leaders can reshape party platforms, rally support, and even transform the political landscape.

In the previous section, we explored how the Christian conservative and civil rights realignments seemed to support the UCLA theory. However, party realignments take place in steps, and some of the documented steps can be used to support candidate-centered theories of parties. Take the civil rights transformation. In 1948, ambitious Minneapolis Mayor Hubert Humphrey delivered a powerful speech advocating for civil rights and convinced influential party bosses like New York's Ed Flynn to support the civil rights plank. Yet, Humphrey wasn't acting entirely free of factional influence. Local unions convinced him to run for office in Minneapolis, and the ADA and unions convinced him to give the convention speech. The night before the speech, Humphrey had cold feet. ADA operatives stayed up all night convincing him to go through with it.

Now, shift to the Christian Right realignment. Some reviewers of my first book pointed out that Reagan and Bush sought support from Christian conservatives during elections but backed away in office. Reagan's relationship with the Christian Right was a bit shaky; activists were let down by his appointment of Sandra Day O'Connor to the Supreme Court and his Surgeon General's approach to AIDS, which surprisingly aligned with LGBTQ interests. On the other hand, Reagan did call members of Congress to push for a school prayer amendment and held a televised public event in the Rose Garden for it. Additionally, had his initial picks for the Supreme Court in 1987 been approved by the Senate, *Roe v. Wade* would have been overturned much earlier.

Critics of my book argue that George H.W. Bush played the role of an Evangelical ally to win support but didn't really understand or embrace evangelical Christianity deeply. During his 1988 campaign, he kept controversial evangelical groups out of the spotlight to avoid bad press. As president, Bush didn't fire the director of the National Endowment for the Arts over controversial art, and his FCC appointee didn't clamp down on shock jocks like Howard Stern. Despite shifting his stance

from pro-choice to pro-life and trying to appoint justices who might overturn *Roe v. Wade*, Christian conservatives no longer believed he was "one of them." Bush advertised his cultural conservative credentials very loudly when he ran for reelection in 1992, including primetime speaking slots for strident cultural conservatives at the convention. He might have lost reelection anyway, but the need to reassure controversial conservatives also hurt him. I argue that the political price that Bush paid for disappointing the factions is evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties, but others disagree with me.

Recently, Donald Trump's 2016 presidential nomination and election victory provide a clear example of how a candidate-centered campaign can dramatically reshape a party. Texas Senator Ted Cruz had backing from the who's who of evangelical Christian leaders in Iowa, like Steve Deace and Bob Vander Plaats. No one candidate had broad backing from all party factions, though. Meanwhile, Trump reached out directly to less organized, more casual voters through the media, lacking significant support from established groups or party structures. Among evangelical Christians, he did better than Cruz among the more irregular church attendees. Trump's views on foreign policy, trade, and entitlements also didn't align with the traditional Republican stances.

Not only did Trump win the nomination without factional support, but the Republican Party as a whole has fallen in line behind him. Party politicians who voted for his impeachment mostly lost reelection or decided not to run.[11] Traditional conservative think tanks, such as the Heritage Foundation and Claremont Institute, have changed with Trump as well. Trump made wildly implausible claims about the outcome of the 2020 election and said that the lawsuits against him were hoaxes. Republicans running in primaries find it difficult to navigate these issues as a result of Trump's rank and file support more than elite factional support. That being said, even Trump did modify some of his stances to fit with the Republican coalition. When he ran in 2000 as a Reform Party candidate, he was pro-choice. Ahead of the 2016 election, he became pro-life and ultimately appointed three Supreme Court justices to remove abortion as a constitutional right. He also showed little opposition to LGBTQ rights in the past but signed an executive order restricting transgender people from serving in the armed forces, at odds with public opinion. Although he seemed to want to protect the safety net and raise taxes on the rich in the 2016 campaign, his budgetary policies as president largely followed the Republican Congress, who wanted tax and spending cuts.

There is statistical evidence for candidate-centered theories of politics as well. Party positions on issues often shift with new presidents, and public perceptions of the parties can change too.[12] This challenges the UCLA Theory, which argues that party factions should be able to filter out candidates who don't fit their agenda. Franklin Roosevelt also led Democrats in a new direction. He had backing primarily from the Southern faction at the 1932 convention and didn't reveal much about his New Deal plans at the time. His administration introduced programs that transformed the Democratic Party from the party of states' right to the party of large-scale federal bureaucracies. Notwithstanding some objections from older Democratic candidates, like its 1924 and 1928 nominees, most Democratic voters and party factions went along with the shift.

Looking at other examples, Presidents Eisenhower and Nixon tried to align the Republican Party more closely with the New Deal, and Nixon aimed to make it more appealing to the South. Before Southern evangelicals became a major force within the GOP, the Republican National Committee tried to win over Southerners to the party. Political scientist Hans Hassell found that party organizations successfully shaped the party by withholding donations and access to networking from congressional candidates who do not fall in line.[13]

Similarly, the Democratic Party's relationship with the antiwar movement in the 2000s showed how party politics can shape and sometimes suppress factions. Despite massive antiwar protests against the Iraq War in 2003 and antiwar platforms in the 2006 midterms, President Obama's administration made only marginal changes to foreign policy. The PATRIOT Act was renewed, detainee sites remained open, and the Iraq War continued for much of Obama's presidency. The Democratic Party reduced its support for the antiwar movement once Obama was in office. For instance, many Democratic Convention delegates stopped attending antiwar events and the movement became a fraction of its former self.[14]

Are Parties Greater Than the Sum of Their Parts?

You don't have to completely buy into either the UCLA Theory of Parties or the idea that parties are driven mainly by individual candidates. Schattschneider's classic work on political parties offers a middle ground that might help us make sense of things. In 1942, Schattschneider argued that while parties are made up of various factions, which he called the

"raw materials" of politics, they are more than just a collection of those factions. According to him, parties and interest groups are different ways of organizing and expressing interests. Parties do bring together different group interests, but they don't just act as a sum of those interests.[15]

Schattschneider believed that parties are in a strong position to manage multiple competing interests. Voters, he noted, usually only have two major parties to choose from, so the parties have a sort of "buyers' market" when it comes to garnering political support. Politicians are skilled at finding common ground among different groups, which helps ensure that various interests are represented within the party. He also pointed out that if a party becomes too closely aligned with one particular interest, it risks losing its broader appeal and looking less like a coalition.

Schattschneider was not particularly bothered that party positions differ from the public at large or even their members:

> the unfortunate result of the fantasy of a party as a large association of voters is that it blackens the name of parties by making them appear to be undemocratic oligarchies—which they are, but they were never supposed to be otherwise. The relations of the party and the partisans are not oppressive. The hospitality of the parties has been practically unlimited.... [I]n what sense is a partisan injured if he is deprived of the right to control an organization toward which he has no duties? The whole theory is chaotic.[16]

But if parties are going to shape and limit the choices available to voters, those choices should either align with what voters want (the "delegate" theory of representation) or genuinely benefit them (the "trustee" theory of representation). Schattschneider's view of parties as entities that manage public conflict while pursuing their own agendas is disconnected from the needs of the public. For parties to be effective, they shouldn't just offer a binary choice to voters; they should ensure that the options available either reflect public opinion or improve voter well-being by integrating expert insights. If we do not have a government *by* the people, we should at least have a government *for* the people. Parties as oligarchies will not accomplish either.

Things have changed since Schattschneider's time. In his day, presidential primaries weren't binding, and there were fewer influential interest groups. Today, the rise of public interest groups, bulk mail, and social media has altered the landscape. Schattschneider also underestimated how

interest groups could work together outside of political parties, as we saw earlier in the chapter. The evidence from recent political dynamics demonstrates that parties might sometimes indulge smaller factions and keep them out of the spotlight while pretending to represent broader interests.

Rosenblum argues that parties provide services that factions in a party could never manage on their own. Partisanship helps delineate stakes, locate points of conflict and commonality, and narrow down the range of possible issue combinations. Voluntary associations, while useful, do not pretend to consider the balance of interests in a coalition. They tend to be more homogeneous, which can lead to reinforced views and a lack of rigorous deliberation. Rosenblum believes that parties legitimate the idea of disagreeing on fundamental moral and political issues.

If the UCLA Theory of Parties is correct, Rosenblum's argument overlooks several flaws in the functioning of political parties. Setting aside periods in which both parties keep major issues off of the public agenda, as parties once did with slavery, political parties could obscure their coalition's agenda rather than clarify it. By gathering relatively extreme factions under the guise of a broad majority, parties can mislead the public about their true intentions. This can result in policies being pushed that do not necessarily reflect the will of the majority but rather the interests of a vocal minority within the party.

For example, the conservative Heritage Foundation developed Project 2025, an agenda for Trump's second administration. The project advanced bold changes to federal agencies to ensure more ideological alignment with the president as well as using executive power to promote traditional family values. When asked about the agenda, Trump said it was extreme and the Heritage Foundation dropped it, even though Trump associates had been active in its making. About a dozen coauthors now serve in the administration and hundreds more supporters may serve in lesser roles even though the public thinks the Republican Party is distant from it.[17] Unlike smaller interest groups like the Heritage Foundation, parties tend to misrepresent their party agenda as reflecting a broad majority. Democratic Party candidates tried to highlight Project 2025 but it did not stick. If we had no parties but simply interest groups, it would be really clear that the Heritage Foundation's agenda was its agenda, and not a hidden agenda of a party.

By framing issues to serve their interests, parties can distort public perception and limit the range of possible issue positions that are considered. This can result in a narrowed, biased public debate that does not

fully encompass the diversity of opinions and solutions that exist. Since 2016, many Republicans have seen issues on a "woke" or "anti-woke" binary. However, issues can also be evaluated in other ways, such as pragmatic versus counterproductive, globalist versus isolationist, or free markets versus government regulation. By using a binary framing like "woke" or "anti-woke," parties push their supporters to view issues myopically, ignoring the broader interests of the electorate.

Conclusion

The debate over how well political parties represent voters versus factions is still alive and well. While some argue that parties effectively reflect the broader electorate's preferences in choosing candidates, others say parties prioritize the interests of organized factions. This chapter explores how historic interest groups, such as the influence of the CIO during the civil rights realignment and the Republican Party's embrace of the Christian Right, challenge the idea that party positions are solely shaped by politicians. On the other hand, Donald Trumps 2016 nomination and victory illustrate how candidates can sometimes bypass traditional party coalitions and win with direct support from dispersed voters.

If readers want a democracy that represents median voters, their support for parties may vary depending on whether they find the evidence for the UCLA Theory of Parties or candidate-centered parties more convincing. However, it's worth considering another perspective: what if parties *should* prioritize the input of party factions to better reflect the diversity of society, and not just the median voter? The next chapter considers this question.

Notes

1. Espinoza, M. (2023) An overview of the Republican Party after the 2022 midterm elections. *In*: *Exploring the 2022 US Midterms: A Briefing Paper from the American Politics Group of the Political Studies Association*. February.
2. Malzahn, J. and Hall, A.B. (2023) Election-denying Republican candidates underperformed in the 2022 midterms. Stanford, CA: Stanford Institute for Economic Policy Research. SIEPR Working Paper.

3. Bawn, K., Cohen, M., Karol, D., Masket, S., Noel, H. and Zaller, J. (2012) A theory of political parties: Groups, policy demands and nominations in American politics. *Perspectives on Politics* 10(3): 571–597.
4. Cohen, M., Karol, D., Noel, H. and Zaller, J. (2009) *The Party Decides: Presidential Nominations Before and After Reform*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
5. Masket, S. (2011) *No Middle Ground: How Informal Party Organizations Control Nominations and Polarize Legislatures*. Ann Arbor, MI: University of Michigan Press.
6. The full quote is, "You go into these small towns in Pennsylvania and, like a lot of small towns in the Midwest, the jobs have been gone now for 25 years and nothing's replaced them. And they fell through the Clinton administration, and the Bush administration, and each successive administration has said that somehow these communities are gonna regenerate and they have not. And it's not surprising then they get bitter, they cling to guns or religion or antipathy toward people who aren't like them or anti-immigrant sentiment or anti-trade sentiment as a way to explain their frustrations."
7. Romney said "There are 47% of the people who will vote for the president no matter what. All right, there are 47% who are with him, who are dependent upon government, who believe that they are victims, who believe the government has a responsibility to care for them, who believe that they are entitled to health care, to food, to housing, to you-name-it. That's an entitlement. And the government should give it to them. And they will vote for this president no matter what."
8. Baylor, C. (2017) *First to the Party: The Group Origins of Political Transformation*. Philadelphia, PA: University of Pennsylvania Press.
9. Karol, D. (2009) *Party Position Change in American Politics: Coalition Management*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
10. Baylor, C. (2022) Feminists, labor unions, and teachers' associations: A labored coalition. *Interest Groups & Advocacy* 11(1): 75–108.
11. Theriault, S.M., 2008. *Party Polarization in Congress*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
12. Jacobson, G.C. (2019) *Presidents and Parties in the Public Mind*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.

13. Hassell, H.J.G. (2017) *The Party's Primary: Control of Congressional Nominations*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
14. Heaney, M.T. and Rojas, F. (2015) *Party in the Street: The Antiwar Movement and the Democratic Party After 9/11*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
15. Schattschneider, E.E. (2017) *Party Government: American Government in Action*. London and New York: Routledge.
16. Schattschneider, E.E. (2017) *Party Government: American Government in Action*. London and New York: Routledge, pp. 58–59.
17. Brown, H. (2024) If it's not Heritage, who is planning Trump's transition. *3Streams*, 6 July. Available at: https://medium.com/3streams/if-its-not-heritage-who-is-planning-trump-s-transition-817f361512ab.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 4

Parties and the Representation of Diverse Groups

Abstract Political parties can provide marginalized or underrepresented groups with access to mainstream politics, but parties also have an incentive to keep them on the sidelines. Marginalized groups have sometimes achieved progress through parties but at other times have made greater gains through cross-party alliances or nonpartisan activism. The dynamics of interest groups and group-party interactions favor narrow and privileged interests over the interests of either broad or marginalized groups.

Keywords Civil rights · Collective action problems · The free ride problem · Immigration · Interest groups · Intersectionality · LGBTQ rights · Pluralism · Marginalized groups · Party capture · Women's suffrage

For many people, democracy isn't just about following majority rule; it's also about making sure all voices have a seat at the table. Pluralists, for example, believe that democracy consists of making compromises between different factions of society, rather than just replicating what the majority of individual voters want. There is no singular public interest, so the closest thing to a public good is such a compromise. As a recent book celebrating political parties writes, parties "bring blocs of voters under a common banner, negotiating priorities among competing interests to

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_4

construct agendas that resonate in the electorate."[1] Some of the recent political theory books defending political parties believe that critics of parties are motivated by a rejection of pluralism.

According to the UCLA Theory of Parties discussed in the last chapter, political parties might tilt public policy by focusing more on their own factions than on what average voters want. But even the theory's supporters wonder if this is always a bad thing. They ask:

Perhaps then giving society's most intense policy demanders a semi-institutionalized position at the heart of government is a better way of insuring that all points of view are heard than relying on the insipid discourse of mass politics for this purpose. Not everyone is represented, but many are. Perhaps the solution to the problem of parties and democracy would be more group involvement rather than less, so that all segments of society have representation in the system. We are not sure.[2]

So in this chapter, we'll ask whether giving more power to party factions actually helps diverse segments of society or if it just shifts attention away from the median voter to people who are more active politically. We'll look at whether parties really address the needs of marginalized groups and whether their influence strengthens or weakens democratic representation.

Is It Right to Amplify Factional Voices Through Parties?

Schlozman and Rosenfeld's *The Hollow Parties* makes the case that political parties are an essential vehicle for pursuing "power projects." The authors argue that historical achievements for marginalized groups were once advanced through parties, connecting voters to the government. Their most celebrated examples are abolition, New Deal economics, and civil rights. In these cases, marginalized groups gained allies through parties and only then had enough strength to pass an agenda. Of course, opponents of marginalized groups can also use parties to gain allies, introducing new discrimination or backtracking on progress for marginalized groups, and some of these cases are described in *The Hollow Parties*. Before the Civil War, the Democratic Party supported proslavery policies while gaining enough support in Northern elections to dominate national politics for a generation.

But when parties do support marginalized groups, how deep is the commitment? Even when parties seem to advance the goals of marginalized groups, the relationship is often fragile and driven by convenience. Christina Wolbrecht's *The Politics of Women's Rights* shows that when feminist causes align with electoral advantage, parties may take them up; when they don't, those causes may be quietly dropped.[3] This reveals a core weakness of relying on parties. Marginalized groups don't set the agenda; they get heard by parties only when the agenda happens to suit them. Unlike interest groups that remain focused on their issue, parties are constantly recalibrating for the next election, which makes the gains they deliver less stable and less reliable over time.

Taking an even less sanguine view, political scientist Paul Frymer writes about "party capture," when parties often overlook the needs of minority groups in favor of majority preferences. Marginalized factions can end up being "captured" by parties; they're taken for granted once they become reliable supporters. After many black voters aligned with the Democratic Party, Frymer argues that Democrats didn't have to push hard for civil rights issues. Republicans soon adopted positions contrary to civil rights groups' preferences, such as busing and affirmative action. Civil rights groups and black voters could not credibly threaten to vote for Republicans instead, so the Democratic Party took their support for granted and would not risk losing elections to advance civil rights when median white voters did not agree. Race issues are so high profile and deeply emotional that it is hard for politicians to take positions on them in the voters' "blind spot." In 2000, Al Gore's campaign urged African American leaders to tone down complaints of voting rights allegations even though the Democratic Party would benefit from the enforcement of voting rights.[4]

A similar pattern emerges with broadly popular immigration restrictions. Even though immigrant rights groups generally support the Democratic Party, their demands often get sidelined. Democratic administrations, including those under Barack Obama and Joe Biden, continued strict immigration policies. Obama was called the "deporter-in-chief" and Biden even added to the border wall and asylum restrictions. Trump and MAGA Republicans centered their campaigns around the negative impact of immigration on jobs and low crime rates, so immigration rights supporters cannot credibly threaten to vote Republican. Therefore, immigrant rights groups might be another "captured" group.

My previous research has uncovered similar issues with the Democratic Party and LGBTQ groups. During Jimmy Carter's presidency, LGBTQ supporters were advised to keep a low profile to avoid being a campaign liability, even though such groups volunteered in hopes of obtaining the legitimacy that comes from public association with a presidential candidate. Carter's administration avoided controversial issues related to LGBTQ rights, like allowing gay adoption, which he publicly avoided answering. In 1976, Carter's issues coordinator said, "let's do what we have to do for the gay rights movement—but let's do it after we get to the White House. For God's sakes, don't let us carry this albatross going into the campaign. We have to win this election."[5] In the 1990s, Bill Clinton promised to end discrimination against gay military members but faced resistance and settled for the "Don't Ask, Don't Tell" policy, which LGBTQ groups felt did little to address their concerns. By that time, Republicans were openly opposing LGBTQ rights and supporting the right of states and organizations not to recognize them. It was only after a majority of the public supported marriage equality that the Democratic Party platform followed suit, and even then, President Obama worried that it could hurt his reelection chances in swing states. Again, LGBTQ groups could not credibly threaten to vote for a different party.

There is still a case to make that parties accomplished more for LGBTQ groups than LGBTQ groups could have on their own or only with interest group allies. Carter appointed judges that were more sympathetic to their concerns when the opportunity arose and later Democrats pushed for more funding for AIDS research. LGBTQ groups were stigmatized enough that they were less likely to accomplish these victories under their own banner; the cover that a broad coalition can create worked in their favor. Likewise, civil rights groups in the 1940s were too unpopular to realign a political party on their own. They worked together with unions to reduce the influence of Southern opponents. Finally, abolitionists were a small minority before the Civil War, even in the North. But by partnering with businessmen and disaffected Democrats, they were able to accomplish much of what they wanted in the first Republican presidential administration.

On the other hand, during the nonpartisan "Era of Good Feeling," it was harder for proslavery Southerners to find allies outside of their region. Proslavery extremists, earlier and later, found cover in a party that framed its agenda as equal opportunity and political equality for the common man. When Ronald Reagan won two landslide elections,

it made it appear as if the Moral Majority, which was opposed to abortion and LGBTQ rights, had widespread support when a majority of the public disapproved of the misnamed organization. In the late nineteenth and early twentieth century, Democrats supported state efforts to restrict African American voting in the South and Republicans supported restricting immigration to avoid feeding Southern and Eastern Europeans into the ranks of Democratic voters.

Examples like this demonstrate the difficulty of generalizing about whether parties are more likely to be friends or foes of marginalized groups. To get a clearer picture, the next section will dive into social science research on interest groups to see how effectively they amplify minority voices and support their rights.

Do Parties Amplify the Right Factional Voices?

Giving more weight to small party factions than dispersed median voters seems justifiable when minorities are treated unfairly by majorities. As previously discussed, it's possible for political parties to give them legitimacy by advancing their agenda under the banner of a mainstream group with the allegiance of ~40 percent of Americans. Strategic advancement of minority rights against public opinion greatly benefits from an organization that provides cover and works on their behalf in a "blind spot."

But that same structure can also work against the most disadvantaged. There are reasons to believe that these party coalitions end up focusing more on helping the factions in their coalition that are already doing pretty well, rather than those who really need the help the most. The same goes for interest groups. While they can elevate minority causes, they too tend to respond most to those with wealth, numbers, or political clout. So why do the loudest voices often belong to the most privileged?

Interest groups come in all shapes and sizes. Some might focus on one specific issue, while others deal with a whole bunch of different issues. Some have financial resources, some have boots on the ground, and some provide intellectual ammunition. Naïve pluralists used to think that an interest group that gained too much would provoke countermobilization by people losing too much. But it turns out that's not really the case. Political theorists have long known that pluralists exaggerated how uneven the playing field between interest groups was, with

Schattschneider quipping that the "flaw in the pluralist heaven is that the heavenly chorus sings with a strong upper-class accent."[6]

Even if all citizens had the same resources, some groups would still have a better shot at getting what they want than others. Economist Mancur Olson pointed out that smaller interest groups fighting to concentrate benefits for just a few people have an advantage over larger groups who want smaller benefits for lots of people. Imagine a college with 30,000 students. A group of 100 students born on July 31 lobbies for a $1 fee from every student, redistributed to them. Most students wouldn't bother fighting it; it's just a dollar. But for the July 31 group, it's $300 each. They care more, so they organize, and they win. Real colleges sometimes approve rock-climbing walls or niche departments that interest only a few students, because those few advocate strongly while the majority doesn't care enough to object.

The same pattern plays out in politics. When a small group really cares about something, they're more likely to fight for it than a big group that's not as passionate. Olson explained this pattern by pointing out free rider problems. The bigger, less passionate group is more likely to have a "free rider" problem, when people are more likely to let other people fight for the benefits. Everyone in the group obtains the benefits whether they contribute or not, and people are more likely to shirk as groups get larger. If environmentalists succeed in passing policies for cleaner air, everyone breathes cleaner air regardless of their contribution. If more people start using the subway to reduce pollution and traffic congestion, everyone benefits whether they take their subway or drive their car during rush hour.

In cases where a narrow group benefits intensely, the benefit may be significant enough for even one member to bear all the costs. This is akin to having a neat-freak roommate who cleans excessively; they're willing to do all the cleaning, even if the other roommates don't contribute. Most Americans lose a few cents a year from government policies for sugar companies, so they won't countermobilize against the sugar industry. But the sugar companies earn millions of dollars based on the policies, so sugar companies will put in the work even if they know other sugar companies might not contribute.

Jonathan Rauch argues that narrow interest groups can create a "parasite economy" in the blind spot of the voters. When two interest groups spend $100 on lobbying to secure $101 of narrow benefits for themselves and not the other group, it drains $200 from the economy that could

have been used for technological advancements or social benefits. Rauch points out how a group representing sugar refineries donated money to Senator Alfonse D'Amato to block a proposed policy reform. D'Amato's intervention was crucial, resulting in the sugar refiners gaining $42,000 for every dollar they spent on his campaign. While there are legal limits on how much groups can donate to campaigns, they can help lawmakers in other ways. For example, they can build a hospital wing in a lawmaker's district. Even reforms that sound like they are favors for consumers, like a law requiring rental car companies to cover damages, can have hidden costs such as putting small, local rental businesses out of business in favor of national chains.[7]

But marginalized groups, though small and motivated, do not benefit from this dynamic as much. In fact, recent scholarship argues that coalitions and interest groups often prioritize the needs of their most advantaged members. A civil rights group might focus more on the concerns of middle-class African American men than those of lower-class African American women. Similarly, feminist organizations may prioritize the issues of white, middle-class women over those of nonwhite, lower-class, or LGBTQ women.[8] Early gay rights groups received a lot of money from male bathhouse owners who prioritized the repeal of anti-sodomy laws over issues that lesbians cared about more, like discrimination in child custody.[9]

There are several reasons for this. First, interest groups rely on donations, which can shape their priorities according to the preferences of their donors. Secondly, they tend to highlight success stories to attract more donations, leading them to pursue agendas that are more likely to pass in legislatures. Unfortunately, this can leave the concerns of marginalized members less addressed, as they may lack the resources or organization to assert their needs effectively. That said, some interest group coalitions have managed to break through.

Some groups overcome the problems that Olson describes with "selective incentives." If a broad group of people standing to gain small benefits can be recruited to an interest group for nonpolitical reasons, it may stand a chance. Many people join AAA for emergency roadside assistance, but AAA takes part in public policies pertinent to roads and cars. Many people who would not donate at all to its political activities nonetheless become members in order to obtain their emergency roadside assistance. Millions of senior citizens donate to AARP for its discounted insurance plans. Gun rights groups offer discounts and gun safety courses that would be

irrelevant to most gun control group members. Unfortunately, there is no evidence that marginalized groups are any better at offering selective incentives than other interest groups; by their very nature, they may have fewer opportunities to do so.

Still, some marginalized groups have obtained their goals by building interest group coalitions and avoiding parties. In *The Woman SuffrageMovement in America*, Corrine McConnaughy shows that women's suffrage organizations forged alliances with labor unions, business groups, socialists, farmers, and temperance societies. Which groups they allied with varied depending on the circumstances of individual states. Suffrage groups deliberately chose not to embed themselves in political parties because their supporters varied too widely in their party allegiance.[10] Their success offers an important reminder: while parties sometimes give marginalized groups cover and legitimacy, they are not the only route to political change. And because these coalitions were temporary and issue-focused, they would not exacerbate long-term partisan identities or contribute to permanent polarization.

In other words, interest groups can be flawed, but when unencumbered by party structures, they sometimes achieve what parties cannot. Parties often make things worse by focusing on the agendas of their most privileged factions, which in turn prioritize their own advantaged subgroups. Without parties, a landscape of interest groups may be messier but also more transparent: each group is seen for what it is, not cloaked in the legitimacy of a party label. When a party wins, it gives certain factions an unwarranted sense of legitimacy, which can be beneficial for marginalized groups if they manage to gain support they wouldn't have otherwise.

Both parties and interest groups often favor their more privileged members. So the real question is not whether parties can help marginalized groups, but whether they help often enough to justify the cognitive distortions parties encourage in the electorate. Reasonable people may disagree, but the party route has not been the only path to meaningful participation in the past. As McConnaughy shows in her work on the suffrage movement, interest group coalitions can sometimes achieve major policy victories by strategically operating outside party structures. The UCLA Theory of Parties raises the possibility that giving factions power could improve their representation, but only if those factions are truly accountable to the people they claim to represent.

Conclusion

This chapter questions whether listening to party factions is always a bad thing. James Madison called them the mischiefs of faction, but maybe they are not so mischievous if they obtain more representation for marginalized groups. There's a big difference between a party that champions the rights of marginalized groups over majority rule and one that prioritizes giving tax loopholes to cronies. Unfortunately, the latter is more common. Marginalized groups often face more opposition and may not get the attention or support they need. Technical regulations do not attract as much scrutiny. There have been times when parties lent legitimacy to minorities but also times when parties lent legitimacy to extreme opposition to minority rights.

But parties aren't the only way change happens for marginalized groups. As McConnaughy shows in her work on the women's suffrage movement, women won the right to vote by forming coalitions with interest groups, not parties. So as we think about factions, we shouldn't just ask which voices are amplified, but whether parties are really the best way to hear them.

Notes

1. Schlozman, D. and Rosenfeld, S. (2024) *The Hollow Parties: The Many Pasts and Disordered Present of American Party Politics*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, p. 3.
2. Bawn, K., Cohen, M., Karol, D., Masket, S., Noel, H. and Zaller, J. (2012) A theory of political parties: Groups, policy demands and nominations in American politics. *Perspectives on Politics* 10(3): 571–597, p. 30.
3. Wolbrecht, C., 2000. *The Politics of Women's Rights: Parties, Positions, and Change*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
4. Frymer, P. (2011) *Uneasy Alliances: Race and Party Competition in America*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, p. 135.
5. Baylor, C. (2023) From albatross to litmus test: Gay rights and the Democratic Party, Part I. *3Streams*, 30 August. Available at: https://medium.com/@cbaylor/from-albatross-to-litmus-test-gay-rights-and-the-democratic-party-part-i-3816ae9febc0.

6. Schattschneider, E.E. (1960) *The Semisovereign People: A Realist's View of Democracy in America*. Reprint. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, p. 35.
7. Rauch, J. (1999) *Government's End: Why Washington Stopped Working*. New York: PublicAffairs, Chapter 4.
8. Strolovitch, D.Z. (2007) *Affirmative Advocacy: Race, Class, and Gender in Interest Group Politics*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
9. Baylor, C. (2022) From albatross to litmus test: Gay rights and the Democratic Party, Part II. *3Streams*, 24 September. Available at: https://medium.com/3streams/from-albatross-to-litmus-test-part-ii-6ea3de8f76cc
10. McConnaughy, C.M., 2013. *The Woman Suffrage Movement in America: A Reassessment*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 5

Many Ideologies and Two Parties

Abstract The two-party system makes it difficult for voters who are not liberals or conservatives to gain representation in the U.S. Moderates, libertarians, and populists often find that neither major party reflects their beliefs, forcing them to choose between imperfect options. A two-sizes-fit-all system is not responsive to the full diversity of public opinion, leaving many voters politically homeless and diminishing the consensus building more likely to take place in a multiparty system.

Keywords American Independent Party · Ballot access · Cross-pressured voters · Ideology · Independent voters · Libertarians · Moderates · Multiparty system · H. Ross Perot · Populists · Populist party · Progressive party · Reform party · Third parties · Two-party system · George Wallace

Imagine there are two major beverage companies in your town: one that specializes in coffee and another that focuses on tea. Each company has its loyal customers and dominates the market, insisting their drinks are the only options worth considering. Both of them put legal restrictions in place that make other beverage companies unlikely to succeed. But what if you don't want coffee or tea? What if you're craving a refreshing lemonade? You try to get the companies to add lemonade to their menu, arguing that there's a real demand for something different.

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_5

However, both companies refuse. The coffee company dismisses the idea outright, while the tea company only offers a twist of lemon, insisting their customers wouldn't want something so different from their core offering.

Both companies are willing to change, just not in a way that accommodates you. Over time, after vigorous campaigns by new employees, the coffee company adds more variations like dark roast, French roast, and cold brew. Similarly, the tea company expands its offerings to include green tea, black tea, and iced tea. But try applying for a job to promote lemonade or an Arnold Palmer and both companies slam the door. The employees and customers of both companies are known to be so hostile to lemonade that lemonade drinkers eventually stop bothering to apply for a job, convinced they have no chance of making an impact. They also don't bother forming a new company because of status quo bias and the legal restrictions.

This situation is similar to the experience of many Americans who find themselves uncomfortable with either party in a two-party system. Just as the beverage companies are set in their ways, the Democratic and Republican platforms are based on established ideologies and resistant to bundling issue positions in new ways. While they may introduce new policies to appeal to groups that fit existing platforms, they remain staunchly opposed to ideas that mix and match liberal and conservative positions. So, if you're a moderate seeking a balanced approach, a libertarian advocating for personal and economic freedom, or a populist wanting more religiously-based working-class policies, you're often left without a party to represent your views. The real American party landscape is even worse. It's like being told you have to buy all your groceries, not just drinks, from one company or the other, and you're not allowed to mix and match.

Unorganized Voices

Just as those who crave lemonade find no place in the hypothetical town, many Americans feel politically homeless, unable to align fully with the ideologies of the two major parties. This is just a reality of a two-party system where each party has its own clear platform. Among these groups are moderates, populists, and libertarians—though they might not have a self-conscious identity. You don't need to have a label or an organized movement to deserve representation.

Understanding the diversity of America involves more than just recognizing the liberal and conservative ideologies associated with the two major parties. Moderates typically navigate a middle path between these two major viewpoints, seeking a balanced approach. Libertarians push for minimal government interference in both personal and economic matters, advocating for maximum individual freedom. Populists are the flip side of libertarians, favoring active government involvement in protecting traditional values and supporting the working class. Libertarians and populists form a class of cross-pressured voters forced to choose between parties that both diverge from them on entire dimensions of issues.

Some research finds moderates more common than liberals and conservatives. Hare and Poole confirm that even after accounting for those who are less informed about political ideologies, moderates still make up a substantial portion of the population.[1] Furthermore, moderates are represented among diverse racial and socioeconomic backgrounds. For example, 44% of African Americans see themselves as moderates, as do most other subgroups.[2] A more recent study with a massive sample size shows that most Americans who fall on a left–right spectrum hold moderate views, not just moderate labels; this adds up to about 35% of the public. Approximately one in five Americans who do not conform to the traditional left–right spectrum also tend to exhibit moderate inclinations.[3] The proportion of moderates in Congress is a lot lower than 35%. One critic of the study argues that many moderates might actually hold more unique and extreme views that don't fit well with either major party.[4] Even if he's right that there are few moderates but many idiosyncratic voters, it means there's a significant segment of the electorate that isn't being represented by either of America's two major parties. Surveys vary in their estimates of libertarians and populists, ranging from 6 to 20% for libertarians and 5 to 29% for populists.[5] Again, this is much smaller than their proportion in Congress.

Despite their significant presence across various demographics, these groups remain largely marginalized in a political landscape dominated by the two major parties. The binary of the two-party system often forces these voters into a corner, compelling them to choose the "lesser of two evils" rather than a candidate who truly represents their diverse viewpoints. Two-party systems favor duopoly over diversity and systemically disadvantage these voters in politics.

Morris Fiorina argues in *Unstable Majorities* that the evidence for widespread moderation in America can be seen in how quickly party

control shifts. Candidates often pretend to be moderate during general elections but cater to party activists once in office, and voters punish parties for becoming too extreme in the following election. For instance, the two times since the 1960s that Democrats were most successful in pushing liberal policies—1993 and 2009—were followed by the largest electoral losses in the House. The 2016 election was the fifth in a row where independent voters voted against the party holding the White House, showing a consistent swing against whichever party is in power. Then, the conservative policymaking during Trump's first two years led to a significant shift toward the Democrats in 2018 and 2020. Admittedly, 2022 was an exception to this pattern, but not due to approval of President Biden. Biden's approval rating fell from 57% at the start of his presidency to 42% after a year, mostly due to a decline in support from independent voters.[6]

We should also consider that there might be even more "off-brand" ideologies if it weren't for manufactured preferences. Some people might naturally lean toward liberal or conservative beliefs because they truly resonate with those ideologies or have reasoned their way there. However, others might adopt these beliefs simply to belong to a party, giving them the satisfaction that comes with feeling like part of a group. Additionally, some people might shift their beliefs to reduce the cognitive dissonance of agreeing with a party on some issues but not others. This means they change their views to fit their party, even if that doesn't reflect their true feelings. If not for these pressures, more people might hold a mix of beliefs that don't align with a single party, further substantiating the idea that parties manufacture preferences for just two clusters of issues.

One possible route for these off-brand ideologues is to get involved in Democratic or Republican primaries. There's no official rule stopping people from being active in primaries and trying to shift the party's focus, and this strategy has worked in the past. For instance, Christian conservatives were able to push the major parties to adopt more extreme positions and shift the focus of party platforms on a range of cultural issues. They leveraged their pre-existing networks of churchgoers, who were already mobilized for various causes, to turn out voters who might otherwise have stayed home. This organizing power was particularly strong in the 1970s, when evangelical churches were growing and religious broadcasting was expanding.[7]

If you're hoping to shake up the current political parties, you're up against a big challenge: both parties are deeply entrenched with

networks that are already committed to specific agendas. Today's parties aren't starting from scratch. They come with established relationships and commitments from unions, churches, and other influential groups. Most pre-existing networks are already committed to one of the major-party ideologies, and church and union membership are a fraction of what they once were. Unlike the days when the Democratic Party managed to keep together Northern civil rights advocates and Southern segregationists, today's parties are more saturated and less flexible.[8] If a party's core supporters are dedicated to agenda items a, b, c, and d, it's difficult for voters with a slightly different mix of priorities—say, a, b, ~ c, and ~ d—to make their voices heard. Changing the direction of a party means disrupting these long-standing relationships and challenging officeholders who have built their careers on a specific set of issues.

Research shows that moderates face unique challenges that other political groups don't. People with extreme beliefs often thrive in conflict, which encourages more political activism. In contrast, moderates tend to avoid conflict, making them less likely to dive into party politics.[9] Sydnor's research reveals that while some people find political arguments exciting, moderates find them stressful and upsetting.[10] During the Christian Right's takeover of the Iowa Republican Party, moderates were put off by the intense debates and aggressive tactics, which led many to withdraw from local party activities. More recently, supporters of Trump and the January 6 riot have created a similar environment in state parties, making it difficult for those who disagree with him to have a voice. As a result, moderates and critics of Trump are finding it harder to make an impact within these parties.[11]

This aversion discourages moderates from participating in party politics and mostly leaves party agenda formation to extreme, organized factions. Inside today's parties, moderates often feel like unwelcome guests at someone else's party: outnumbered, outshouted, and ready to leave. Moderate voices are drowned out by more radical elements who are better equipped to navigate the tumultuous waters of party politics.

The same dynamic that disadvantages moderates is one that empowers activists who want to push parties to the extremes. The more unwelcome moderates feel in a party, the more a party becomes an echo chamber where extreme people reinforce other people's beliefs. People spending time with others of shared beliefs tend to become more extreme to signal ingroup loyalty and fit in. Supporting a position that is shared by moderates sends a weak signal or no signal at all. Supporting a position

that is shared only by extreme members sends a signal. In 2016, Bernie Sanders used traditional media and social media to connect with a broad and dispersed group of voters. This approach allowed him to sidestep the entrenched policy demands within the Democratic Party and offer a serious challenge to Hillary Clinton that affected future party platforms. His performance made "Medicare for All" and tuition reimbursement key issues in the 2020 Democratic primary, even pushing Joe Biden's platform further to the left than Hillary Clinton's in 2016. Sanders managed to push his party toward more extreme stances, without overturning the party's core beliefs. Moderate candidates have failed to do that for decades, with Bill Clinton being a dated exception.

The Multiparty Alternative

Most democracies have multiparty systems that increase the likelihood that there are more than two parties represented in the government. In these systems, seats in a legislature are assigned based on a party's share of the vote. So even if a party knows it won't win first place, it can still obtain a meaningful number of seats. This is different from the "first past the post" or "single-member district" system used in the United States, where only the top vote-getter in each district or state obtains a seat in Congress. In the United States, this often means that voters only seriously consider the top two candidates because only the winner gets representation.

A multiparty system, on the other hand, can represent more than just two perspectives. Voters in countries with multiparty systems tend to be happier with their choices and voter turnout is higher. When you have more than two parties, each with its own platform, there's more opportunity for different ideas to be part of the conversation and decision-making process. In France's legislature, Emmanuel Macron's centrist party has a significant presence, offering a voice to those who don't align with the traditional left or right. In the United States, factions like the "Blue Dog Democrats" or the "Congressional Black Caucus" exist within the Democratic Party but don't have as salient a speaking platform as a separate party would. Plus, coalitions in multiparty systems tend to be more flexible. In Austria, the Conservative Party formed a government coalition with the Green Party in 2020, negotiating policies and appointments that both parties could agree on. Then in 2025, the Austrian Conservative Party allied with the Social Democrats and liberal Neos, but they could

have chosen to partner with a far right party instead. When today's opponent might be tomorrow's ally, there's a strong incentive not to burn bridges. More parties mean that politicians and voters are often fighting to be someone's second choice, which can lead to a less antagonistic political environment.

However, defenders of two-party systems argue that they encourage moderation and stability because they need more than 50% of the vote to win an election. With more parties and no need to obtain a majority, there's a larger risk of extreme parties gaining influence. For example, in some multiparty systems, you might find parties with radical agendas, like communist parties or openly racist parties, pushing for more extreme policies than either of the main US parties would consider. The rise of the Nazis in Germany's multiparty system in the 1930s is a tragic example of how extreme parties can gain power. Partnerships in a multiparty system can be unstable because coalition partners can withdraw their support over short periods of time. Some people view rapid changes in government control as the way democracy is supposed to work, but others believe that essential decisions are delayed by the constant need to reassure and negotiate with coalition partners. There are cases when one extreme party might have four percent of the legislature, but is necessary to get the largest coalition to 51% of the votes. The larger parties might have to make disproportionate concessions to small parties just to keep 51% of the votes.

Defenders of the two-party system also point out that compromise among people with different beliefs happens in both systems; it just happens in different places. In multiparty systems, parties often need to form coalitions with each other within the legislature to achieve a majority and select a prime minister. In contrast, in the US two-party system, coalition-building happens outside the legislature. Different interest groups—like feminists, environmentalists, civil rights activists, and labor unions—come together to shape the Democratic Party's platform. Sometimes, if they feel their interests aren't being adequately represented, these groups can switch their support to the other major party, as when realignments take place in America. As mentioned in an earlier chapter, disaffected factions may also feel as if there is no plausible alternative and they have to settle for a party that gives them mere scraps.

There is also a case that no parties are better than more parties. In a multiparty system, voters still have some of the motivated reasoning and ingroup/outgroup mentality we talked about earlier in the book.

Anytime people are grouped together under a common banner, there's a risk of developing hostility toward other groups and rationalizing their own group's actions.

Why Not Third Parties?

The presence of third parties in the United States could arguably be seen as a weaker version of multiparty democracy. Third parties have historically addressed the concerns of political factions in America when the two major parties ignore them. During the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, third parties emerged as formidable forces in American politics, challenging the duopoly of the major parties and influencing the trajectory of American political development. They were seen as a "safety valve" in the political system, an outlet for political frustrations and dissenting voices that are not adequately represented by the major parties.

Third parties served as conduits through which particular constituencies could channel their grievances and aspirations, encompassing issues such as slavery, women's suffrage, and prohibition, which were often given perfunctory attention by the established parties. Only one third party (the Republican Party) managed to replace a major party, and that was because a major party (the Whig Party) imploded. While no other third party won first place in any presidential elections, some succeeded in electing governors, representatives to Congress, and even state legislative majorities. Their impact was most pronounced when they managed to influence the major parties to incorporate their policies and ideologies.

Here are some examples of their impact. Antislavery third parties spoiled the election of 1844 for the Whigs in 1844 and possibly for the Democrats in 1848. The Liberty Party provided the rhetorical groundwork for discourse surrounding the Wilmot Proviso and the network for the Free Soil Party,[12] which in turn provided an important network for the Republican Party. The Free Soil Party broadened the Liberty Party's appeal to disaffected Democrats and Northern farmers who believed the spread of slave states would lower their standard of living to Southern yeoman, who were impoverished by the plantation economy. The Free Soil Party was able to elect several members to Congress and earn 10% of the popular vote in the 1848 presidential election, more than any previous third party. When the Whig Party straddled the slavery issue, too many voters defected. The Republican Party then consolidated various antislavery groups, including former Whigs, Free Soil Democrats, and Liberty

Party members, around a commitment to earning one's labor with one's work, and opposing the expansion of slavery.[13] Early members of the first antislavery third party, the Liberty Party, took credit for initiating this sequence of events.[14]

More frequently, third parties failed or depended on a singular personality rather than a party organization. The Populist Party, emerging at the end of the nineteenth century, held the potential to radically reshape major-party politics. Farmers from the Civil War to the turn of the century supported various state and federal regulations to cope with large debts, unfair railroad rates, and low food prices. Paper money or silver coinage could reduce farmer debts and raise the price of farm goods, and it created a constituency for currency inflation that united western farmers, Southern farmers, miners, and silver industrialists. The Populist Party, and Democrats who tried to incorporate their agenda, failed to consolidate a robust interest group coalition essential for sustained success, perhaps demonstrating the UCLA Theory of Party's point that parties are coalitions of interest groups. Populist Party members sought higher food prices to benefit farmers, which did not directly benefit workers, and populists varied in how well versed they were in labor politics. Mostly, they appealed to a generalized class interest with farmers against the moneyed interests. Labor leaders were not receptive, and by election day, neither were industrial workers. Perhaps most importantly, the racial divisions proved to be insurmountable. There was a large, organized bloc of black voters who supported the Populist Party agenda. Some Populist candidates nonetheless supported Jim Crow laws to win over white supremacists, while others waffled on racial issues and failed to gain the trust of black voters.

In the early twentieth century, the Progressive Party sought to establish itself as a major political force akin to the Republican Party in 1854, albeit partly in an effort to reduce the influence of parties. The party's momentum was largely built around the influential personalities of Theodore Roosevelt and Robert La Follette. The Progressives advocated for democratic reforms, including the direct election of US senators, direct primaries, and referendums, aiming to minimize the role of political parties as intermediaries between the electorate and the government. Furthermore, the Progressive Party endorsed the creation of an administrative state that emphasized social welfare and fairness in business. Roosevelt desired the Progressive Party to evolve into a sustainable party with a roster of candidates across all levels of government.

However, Progressive Party professionals were dubious about this ambition, and election results proved them right. Roosevelt's campaign was predominantly personality-driven and with donations from millionaires, capitalized on modern transportation and media to address large audiences directly, partly replacing the networking function previously performed by party organizations. Despite Roosevelt's strong showing in the 1912 presidential election, the Progressive Party failed to field candidates in many states during the 1914 elections, and those who did run generally performed poorly, with the exception of the California gubernatorial race. Wisconsin Governor Robert LaFollette earned an impressive 17% of the popular vote as a Progressive Party nominee in 1924, but as political scientist Sidney Milkis puts it, his candidacy "lacked any semblance of a party organization."[15] After Woodrow Wilson's presidential administration, Progressive Party ideas continued to find resonance among scholars and in publications such as *The New Republic*, but not in party organizations.

Theodore Roosevelt's personalistic candidacy affected public policy in at least one administration. A Democratic President, Woodrow Wilson, was instrumental in the enactment of policies such as an income tax, strengthened antitrust laws, and the direct election of US Senators. Wilson realized that the Progressive voters supporting Theodore Roosevelt were a sizable constituency in pivotal Electoral College states and in response created a number of independent regulatory agencies staffed with experts. This was contrary to the traditions of the Democratic Party and the Populists, who distrusted expert intermediaries between the people and government. By contrast, Franklin D. Roosevelt's New Deal permanently incorporated the administrative state into the Democratic Party as an improvised response to an unprecedented emergency, not the desire of Roosevelt to win over a third-party constituency when he ran in 1932.

The role of third parties waned even more over the twentieth century. If there was ever a time when a third party could gain visibility, it was in 2016 with two historically unpopular major party nominees. No third-party breakthrough has occurred, and parties did not subsequently adopt the positions of the Green or Libertarian parties challenging Clinton and Trump. Nor did parties do so after 2000 when the Green Party was widely thought to deny Democrat Al Gore his victory, or anytime in between 2000 and 2016.

Scholars often posit structural reasons for the diminished influence of third parties since 1912, but they fall short of rigorous scrutiny. French political scientist Maurice Duverger believed that the two-party system in the United States could be attributed to the presence of single-member districts. However, third parties had more influence in the nineteenth century and successfully secured legislative seats in other countries with single-member districts, such as Canada and India. After World War II, both legislatures and courts have placed more onerous requirements on ballot access over time. Unlike in the past where parties printed ballots, states now undertake this role and require third parties to garner thousands of signatures for ballot access. Additionally, political parties set the rules of televised debates and who gets to participate, and they often exclude third parties. Ross Perot was only included in the 1992 presidential debates because George H.W. Bush wrongly predicted that Perot would siphon votes away from Bill Clinton. But as political scientist David Karol has observed, the decline of third parties began even before some of the post-war legal constraints were enacted.[16]

Lee Drutman, a senior fellow at New America, argues that the shift in the balance of power between the executive and legislative branches has adversely affected third parties. In particular, the allure of winning seats in congressional and legislative delegations has diminished as American politics increasingly focuses on the presidency. When Congress is as gridlocked as it has been, being in Congress is less appealing. Within the major political parties, promising candidates like Beto O'Rourke, Stacey Abrams, Larry Elder, and Pete Buttigieg ran for either governor or president, even though they had the option to run for contested Senate seats and help their party win a majority. Winning a handful of congressional seats seems less meaningful than it did in the nineteenth century.[17]

Independent Candidacies

In lieu of third parties, independent presidential candidates ostensibly assumed the mantle in the late twentieth century. Individuals like George Wallace in 1968 and Ross Perot in 1992 gained a following by addressing neglected issues, much like third parties did in earlier periods of American history. They had cross-cutting agendas that made a primary victory in either party unlikely. Wallace's political platform amalgamated racial and cultural conservatism with moderate economic policies, which stood in stark contrast to the Democratic Party's progression toward Great Society

ideals, civil rights advocacy, and a post-Cold War foreign policy orientation. Perot prominently emphasized economic issues such as budget deficits and economic protectionism. While the major parties did hold positions on these issues, there was palpable dissatisfaction among the electorate regarding the parties' approaches to addressing them. Both formed nominal parties, but the parties quickly faded as the men moved on from politics.

Wallace and Perot's personal influence on major parties persisted in at least one of the presidential election cycles that followed. President Nixon tried to draw in Wallace's supporters in the South by hindering desegregation and nominating segregationists to the Supreme Court. Wallace also enjoyed considerable support from the working class in the North. This led Nixon to support Senator Daniel Patrick Moynihan's Family Security System to appeal to the "working poor."[18] In 1972, Democratic nomination rival Hubert Humphrey ran ads in Florida tapping into resentment of "welfare loafers." In 1976, Jimmy Carter sought out and earned Wallace's endorsement and appointed Wallace associates to administration positions, although he did not advocate Wallace's civil rights positions. Ronald Reagan later launched his presidential campaign in Mississippi and appealed to blue-collar voters in the North as well as voter resentment of "welfare queens."

In the case of Perot, staff members in the Clinton White House believed that Perot's candidacy in 1992 had played a pivotal role in Clinton's victory, even though scholars have since disputed that.[19] Securing the support of Perot's voters would be crucial for Clinton's reelection in 1996. Shortly after election night, a meeting took place at the residence of then-Governor Clinton, which was attended by Al Gore and all of the congressional Democratic Party leaders. During the meeting, they emphasized that Clinton's policy goals would not be achievable unless the administration addressed the critical economic issues, particularly the deficit. Newly elected congressional Democrats supported by Perot voters also felt a sense of obligation to address this issue. When Clinton encountered criticism within his own party for attempting to reduce the deficit through cuts in spending, he expressed his frustration to his advisor Dick Morris, saying, "no president was ever rewarded for doing deficit reduction." Morris urged him not to forget the importance of Perot's voters and advised, "Remember the theory, remember the theory. We have the Perot voters out there, lying in wait. This is the moment to strike—and watch the poll numbers go up!".[20]

On the Republican side, Newt Gingrich likewise led an effort to prioritize deficit reduction through his "Contract with America" in the 1994 midterm elections.[21] According to a study by Rapoport and Stone, during the initial two years of this initiative, Republicans gained 38 seats in Congress, with the support of Ross Perot's followers. This was a significant gain that enabled the Republicans to secure a majority in Congress. Interestingly, congressional members who were elected with the support of Perot's followers in 1994 were only slightly more inclined, by two percent, to vote in favor of Perot's policy agenda. However, they were substantially more likely to at least put Perot's policy priorities on the congressional agenda for voting. One example was the introduction of a vote on term limits, which, although it did not pass, would not have even been considered for a vote under a Democrat-controlled House. Additionally, Republican representatives who voted against the policies favored by Perot's supporters faced a higher likelihood of not being reelected.[22]

Instead of depending on third-party organizations, both Wallace and Perot orchestrated their respective campaigns autonomously. This shift was facilitated by several transformative changes in campaign strategies. Candidates used to rely on political parties to provide volunteers and donations, but modern transportation and communication allows individual campaigns to disseminate their messages and raise money more efficiently. Wallace flew around the country in his private jet, hosting rallies in crowded stadiums to receptive audiences. Concurrently, television and radio broadcasted soundbites and visuals from these rallies to a national audience. Additionally, the advent of computerized mailing lists in the 1960s bolstered the capacity of candidates to efficiently solicit donations via mail. Wallace acquired Richard Viguerie's conservative direct mailing list at a bargain price in exchange for sharing his own mailing list. Moreover, news outlets tend to magnify the presence of affluent candidates like Perot under the presumption that personal wealth correlates with electoral success, despite academic research questioning the efficacy of self-financed campaigns.[23]

Neither of these two candidacies had sturdy party foundations. As evidence of their party's frailty, Wallace and Perot later disavowed them. Ohio initially denied the American Independent Party a spot on the ballot because it wasn't sufficiently grassroots; Wallace had to jettison his usual affinity for states' rights and appeal to the Supreme Court to be placed on the ballot. In subsequent elections from 1972 onward, Wallace

told a Nixon aide "I'm tired of these kooks in the third party business"[24] and ran in Democratic Party presidential primaries. Perot only created the Reform Party after the 1992 presidential election, which was his strongest performance. Jesse Ventura, who was elected Governor of Minnesota on a Reform Party ticket, described the party as "hopelessly dysfunctional." Perot was disillusioned in 2000 when the Reform Party nominated Pat Buchanan, a staunch conservative, and threw his support behind Republican nominee George W. Bush.

Wallace and Perot's impact faded quickly after they stopped running for office. After Wallace's campaigns, Republicans adopted some of his positions on social issues, appealing to Southern voters and focusing on law and order. However, they largely ignored his economic support for blue-collar workers and hostility to immigrants for decades, when Donald Trump used the Wallace playbook. Meanwhile, the Democratic Party shifted its focus from Wallace's base of blue-collar workers to white-collar unions, like teachers and government employees. Similarly, Ross Perot's emphasis on deficit reduction and economic nationalism gained traction in the 1990s, but by the 2000s, neither major party prioritized the deficit or trade wars. The Democrats and Republicans moved on, aligning with other economic priorities and constituencies, demonstrating how the influence of these personalistic candidacies was only temporary and did not result in lasting structural changes to the political landscape.

Without the foundation of a well-organized party, movements like those led by Wallace and Perot struggle to create the enduring impact achieved by the Democrats, Republicans, or even nineteenth century third parties. The two major parties thrive on their established infrastructures and dedicated support networks that people with heterodox ideologies lack. This disparity creates an unequal playing field where only certain ideologies benefit from the existence of a party system. If America is to provide fair representation, it must empower alternatives to the two major parties or do away with entrenched party structures altogether.

The Continuing Market of Independent Voters

The fact that so many people in the United States identify as independent voters shows there's a real appetite for something other than Democrats and Republicans. As of 2023, 43% of voters identify themselves as independent voters in surveys, and this number has been steadily rising.[25]

Despite this trend, many political scientists brush off independent voters as just "closet partisans,"[26] similar to how they often dismiss moderates as not being truly moderate. They argue that most independent voters actually lean toward one party or the other and that the number of people who are genuinely independent is less than 10%, and hasn't changed much since the 1950s. Political scientists Samara Klar and Yanna Krupnikov argue that most people who call themselves independent are really just concerned about the negative impression they create in others by identifying themselves with a party.

Usually, political scientists are careful about trusting what people call themselves in surveys. But not when it comes to independents. As Arnold Schwarzenegger responded to such claims, "I don't understand if someone says that he sees the color green and they say 'Well really the person doesn't really see green, they're seeing purple.' I mean, I don't see what gives them the right to redefine what the people's wish is… If they say they're independent, they're independent." There are few other survey responses where political scientists replace what people say on surveys with their own judgment based on different questions. When you ask people if they lean toward one side, their answers might change depending on what's happening right now. For example, if there's an election coming up and a Democratic candidate is really popular, more independent voters might say they lean toward the Democrats because of that one candidate or issue. Or, independent voters might prioritize one issue that is being elevated by the media at the moment. For example, the media might be reporting more on crime, so independent voters who are conservative on criminal justice issues might vote for Republicans in the current election cycle. This doesn't mean they are not independent, just that they lean to one side in the moment.

Who are independent voters and what do they believe? Among their ranks include 37% of Latinos and 27% of African Americans. Surveys from the Pew Research Center also show that many independent voters feel the United States has a mixed bag of beliefs. A majority say that the "US needs to continue to make changes to give blacks equal rights with whites" (57%) and that immigrants strengthen the country (66%). Seventy percent support same-sex marriage and 62% oppose expanding the border wall. At the same time, a plurality prefers "smaller government providing fewer services" (44–47%).[27] A study of North Carolina independent voters found that they were more conservative than Democrats and more liberal than Republicans.[28] Another study found that they were

more likely to vote based on economic conditions than party labels.[29] Independent voters even those who "lean" toward a party, are also far more likely to punish candidates for violations of democratic norms like election laws than people who identify as members of a party.[30]

A significant portion of Americans identify as independent voters, and they have a mix of beliefs that don't neatly fit into the Democrat or Republican categories. Whether they lean one way or the other during an election often depends on the candidates and the issues at hand. But this doesn't make them any less independent; it just shows they're making choices based on what's important to them at the moment.

Conclusion

We've seen how the two-party system leaves many Americans feeling politically homeless. It's not just disadvantaged minorities who are left behind by this rigid structure; moderates, libertarians, populists, and independent voters also find themselves without a real place in the political landscape. As we move forward, it's crucial to ask whether we can create a more inclusive political system that truly reflects the diversity of beliefs and values in America. Party primaries and third parties are not up to the challenge.

Notes

1. Hare, C. and Poole, K.T. (2014) The polarization of contemporary American politics. *Polity* 46(3): 411–429.
2. Bacon, P. Jr. and Mehta, D. (2018) The diversity of Black political views. *FiveThirtyEight*, 6 April. Available at: https://fivethirtyeight.com/features/the-diversity-of-black-political-views
3. Fowler, A., Hill, S.J., Lewis, D., Tausanovitch, C., Vavreck, L. and Warshaw, C. (2023) Moderates. *American Political Science Review* 117(2): 643–660.
4. Broockman, D. and Lauderdale, B. (2023) Moderates. *OSF Preprints*, 16 October. Available at: https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/
5. Kiley, J. (2014) In search of libertarians. *Pew Research Center*, 25 August. Available at: https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2014/08/25/in-search-of-libertarians; Weeden, J. (2015) Do most people fit into liberal and conservative boxes? *Psychology*

Today, 15 April. Available at: https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/the-hidden-agenda-the-political-mind/201504/do-most-people-fit-in-liberal-and-conservative; Echelon Insights. (2021) Quadrant analysis of the American electorate from our June 2021 Verified Voter Omnibus. Available at: https://echeloninsights.com/in-the-news/june-omnibus-quadrants; Drutman, L. (2017) Political divisions in 2016 and beyond. *Voter Study Group*, June. Available at: https://www.voterstudygroup.org/publication/political-divisions-in-2016-and-beyond. Studies vary because they use different issues to define ideological categories, as well as different cut-off points. Drutman finds that 29% of Americans are populist and 4% are libertarian, but his method relies on issue questions designed to highlight divisions between the two major parties. As a result, he sets a high bar for identifying economic conservatives, leading to very few people landing on the right side of his economic spectrum. For example, his survey focuses on popular spending programs like Medicare and Social Security, and popular taxes like those on the wealthy, rather than less popular programs or broad-based taxes that might better capture ideological variation. On cultural issues, both Drutman and Echelon ask numerous questions about personal values that predict party alignment, but these questions rarely mention specific government actions that would distinguish a libertarian from a populist approach. For instance, Drutman and Echelon define cultural liberalism as supporting hate speech bans, reallocating police funds to social services, and believing that women face obstacles to advancement, and cultural conservatism as opposition to these positions. Meanwhile, to qualify as a libertarian in Drutman's framework, one must disagree with statements like "politics is a rigged game" and "people like me don't have any say." These criteria make it harder to identify libertarians or populists with low levels of efficacy or antigovernment libertarians who believe in traditional ideas of racial equality but oppose hate speech laws.

6. Reilly, T., Salit, J.S. and Ali, O.H. (2018) *The Independent Voter*. New York: Routledge, pp. 6, 33–34.
7. Baylor, C. (2017) *First to the Party: The Group Origins of Political Transformation*. Philadelphia, PA: University of Pennsylvania Press.

8. Schickler, E. (2016) *Racial Realignment: The Transformation of American Liberalism, 1932–1965*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
9. Iyengar, S., Lelkes, Y., Levendusky, M., Malhotra, N. and Westwood, S.J. (2019) The origins and consequences of affective polarization in the United States. *Annual Review of Political Science* 22: 129–146; Huddy, L. and Khatib, N. (2007) American patriotism, national identity, and political involvement. *American Journal of Political Science* 51(1): 63–77.
10. Notably, younger individuals, women, and minorities often display a higher aversion to conflict, which discourages their involvement in strident political events. See Sydnor, E. (2019) *Disrespectful Democracy: The Psychology of Political Incivility*. New York: Columbia University Press.
11. Burns, A. and Martin, J. (2019) Trump's takeover of the Republican Party is almost complete. *The New York Times*, 3 April. Available at: https://www.nytimes.com/2019/04/03/us/politics/trump-republican-party.html.
12. Brooks, C. (2016) *Liberty Power: Antislavery Third Parties and the Transformation of American Politics*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
13. Foner, E. (1995) *Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party Before the Civil War*. New York: Oxford University Press.
14. Brooks, C. (2016) *Liberty Power: Antislavery Third Parties and the Transformation of American Politics*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
15. Milkis, S. (2009) *Theodore Roosevelt, the Progressive Party, and the Transformation of American Democracy*. Lawrence, KS: University Press of Kansas, pp. 119–133, 253–254, 281.
16. Karol, D. (2016) Political parties in American political development. *In*: Valelly, R.M., Mettler, S. and Lieberman, R.C. (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of American Political Development*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 473–490.
17. Drutman, L. (2020) *Breaking the Two-Party Doom Loop: The Case for Multiparty Democracy in America*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 95, 197.
18. Reeves, R. (1964) *Alone in the White House*. New York: Coward-McCann, pp. 117–119.

19. Lacy, D. and Burden, B.C. (1999) The vote-stealing and turnout effects of Ross Perot in the 1992 U.S. presidential election. *American Journal of Political Science* 43(1): 233–255. For a different perspective, see Alvarez, R.M. and Nagler, J. (1995) Economics, issues, and the Perot candidacy: Voter choice in the 1992 presidential election. *American Journal of Political Science* 39(3): 714–744.
20. Harris, J.F. (1995) *The Survivor: Bill Clinton in the White House*. New York: Random House.
21. Rosenstone, S.J., Behr, R.L. and Lazarus, E.H. (1996) *Third Parties in America: Citizen Response to Major Party Failure*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
22. Rapoport, R.B. and Stone, W.J. (1991) Three's a crowd: The dynamics of third party politics. *American Political Science Review* 85(3): 721–732.
23. Steen, J.A. (2006) *Self-Financed Candidates in Congressional Elections*. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.
24. Reeves, R. (1964) *Alone in the White House*. New York: Coward-McCann, p. 324.
25. Jones, J.M. (2024) Independent party ID tied for high; Democratic ID at new low. *Gallup Politics*, 12 January. Available at: https://news.gallup.com/poll/548459/independent-party-tied-high-democratic-new-low.aspx
26. Petrocik, J.R. (2009) Measuring party support: Leaners are not independents. *Electoral Studies* 28(4): 562–572; Lewis-Beck, M.S., Nadeau, R. and Elias, A. (2008) Economics, party, and the vote: Causality issues and panel data. *American Journal of Political Science* 52(1): 84–95; Klar, S. and Krupnikov, Y. (2016) *Independent Politics: How American Disdain for Parties Leads to Political Inaction*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press; Reilly, T., Salit, J.S. and Ali, O.H. (2018) *The Independent Voter*. New York: Routledge, Chapter 3.
27. Reilly, T., Salit, J.S. and Ali, O.H. (2018) *The Independent Voter*. New York: Routledge, Chapter 3.
28. Bitzer, J.M., Cooper, C.A., Manzo, W.R. and Roberts, S. (2022) Growing and distinct: The unaffiliated voter as unmoored voter. *Social Science Quarterly*, 27 November.
29. Killian, L. (2012) *The Swing Vote: The Untapped Power of Independents*. New York: St. Martin's Press, p. 201.

30. Graham, M. and Svolik, M.W. (n.d.) Democracy in America? Partisanship, polarization, and the robustness of support for democracy in the United States. Available at: https://cpb-us-w2.wpmucdn.com/campuspress.yale.edu/dist/6/1038/files/2012/12/Graham-and-Svolik-Democracy-in-America-web-1ngqg71.pdf.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 6

Parties and Voter Participation

Abstract Despite all of the negative effects of political parties, they have at least one positive effect: increasing voter turnout. This chapter reports which types of voters are less likely to vote in low-turnout elections and weighs the value of increased voter participation against higher polarization and the reduced quality of voter deliberation. It also traces how parties have historically supported or opposed the expansion of voter suffrage based on their electoral interests.

Keywords Federalist party · Gilded Age · Independent candidates · Multiparty systems · Nonpartisan elections · Polarization · Progressive era · Reconstruction · Spoils system · Suffrage · Third parties · Voter mobilization · Voter ID laws · Voter suppression · Voter turnout

Voting and political participation are the lifeblood of a democracy. They help make sure the people's voices are actually reflected in government decisions. The most politically motivated voters tend to be more ideologically extreme, so a small voter turnout would lead to politicians who do not represent the typical voter. Additionally, as Abraham Lincoln quipped, "You can fool some of the people all of the time, and all of the people some of the time, but you cannot fool all of the people all of the time." In other words, a smaller voter population ("some of the people") could arguably be more easily fooled than a larger one ("all of the people").

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_6

One of the main arguments in favor of political parties is that they increase many different kinds of voter participation. This chapter will explore how large that increase might be, and ask whether it is worth the negative impacts of political parties previously discussed.

Voter Turnout

Party organizations publicize elections and urge people to participate. As mentioned in Chapter One, parties provide at least some information about where candidates stand, saving voters the trouble of researching independent candidates, which they would have to do in a nonpartisan system. Fewer people would vote if they either had to do more research or choose between names on a ballot without party labels. Political parties can also motivate voters by highlighting the threat of the opposing party gaining power.

People often say parties are essential because they simplify voting, but research from countries with multiparty systems show otherwise. Some countries have a dozen or more parties, not just two. These systems, which offer more complex and varied choices, actually result in higher voter turnout compared to two-party systems. They tend to provide better representation for minority and marginalized groups and higher citizen satisfaction with their government.[1] Partisan debates are less negative. Complexity in voting options might actually engage voters more, rather than baffling them and discouraging participation. If the higher information requirements of multiparty systems don't deter voters, it's possible that nonpartisan systems, which also require more independent research, wouldn't either. That being said, other factors like cultural differences and voting procedures could also account for the differences across countries.

It is challenging to estimate precisely how the absence of political parties would affect voter turnout. One study found that nonpartisan local elections reduce turnout by 8% compared to partisan elections.[2] Another way of answering the question is comparing the propensity to vote among partisans and independent voters. As more people began identifying as independent from the 1970s to early 2000s, experts debated whether turnout actually dropped or just stayed flat.[3] Voter turnout was stable over this time period, but the lack of an increase suggests the salutary effect of partisan identification on voter turnout. Voter turnout should have increased given the expansion of early voting, same-day registration,

and mail voting. Higher per capita income and education levels, which typically predict higher turnout, have not correlated with higher turnout over the same period. Neither has additional money spent on campaign advertising.[4]

On the other hand, Gallup polls show independent voter identification rising from 39 to 43% since 2016, and the 2020 election saw the highest turnout on record, with 66% of eligible voters participating. Doubtless, many voters were driven by high polarization and the sense there was a lot at stake in the election. While higher voter turnout is valuable, we must consider its cost. We obviously would not want to orchestrate events to create potentially dire consequences if one side won, just so more people would vote.

People have not been willing to condone milder corruption to stimulate voter turnout. The spoils system and routine, bribery of voters led to peak voter turnout during the Gilded Age. Before secret ballot elections, it was easy for political parties and political bosses to offer concrete benefits to voters, who would insert an obviously party-printed ballot into the box. In return, voters could get bribes, favors, and government jobs. In presidential elections between 1876 and 1900, turnout ranged from 73 to 81%. Reformers introduced the secret ballot and civil service reform. Instead of rewarding political volunteers with plum jobs, bureaucrats were hired on the basis of merit, and new laws prevented politicians from simply firing and replacing them with their own cronies. Few Americans want to turn back the clock on these reforms, even though they led to a significant decline in voter turnout, which ranged from 49 to 66% since 1920. Turnout fell more than twice as much after the Progressive Era reforms than it is estimated to drop in today's nonpartisan local elections.

In summary, it is hard to say how much independence from parties would reduce turnout. Almost certainly, Progressive Era reforms reduced turnout even more. Turnout matters, but it's not the only thing that matters. If we don't accept bribery as an acceptable price for higher turnout, why should we accept high levels of motivated partisan reasoning? In earlier chapters we examined the pitfalls of excessive partisanship, such as reduced vaccination rates. While political parties may boost voter participation, it is crucial to weigh these benefits against the significant costs they may impose on society.

How Turnout Affects Policy

Turnout doesn't just affect how many people vote, but which policies win. Let's try to figure out how policies might change if it were not for the effect of parties on voter turnout. Traditionally, higher voter turnout was seen as benefiting Democrats, while lower turnout favored Republicans. However, recent studies indicate a significant shift in this dynamic, particularly with the rise of educational polarization and changes in voter engagement patterns.

Today's electoral landscape is divided not just by political ideology but by levels of voter engagement. During the Obama era, Democrats thrived on high voter turnout, buoyed by young and nonwhite voters. More recently, Donald Trump performed well with less engaged voters, while Democrats have made significant gains among highly engaged voters who consistently participate in elections. The Cook Political Report's research in swing states in the Electoral College categorizes voters into three groups: high-engagement voters (52%), low/mid-engagement voters (34%), and new registrants since 2020 (13%). Joe Biden led among high-engagement voters, while Trump led among low/mid-engagement voters and new registrants. Inconsistent voters, who are more influenced by transient issues and social media, were leaning toward Trump while regular voters were more inclined toward Biden.[5]

A *New York Times* study from 2024 supports this trend, finding that Biden performed best among dedicated voters who turned out for a 2022 primary election, while Trump had a 14-point lead among registered voters who have never cast a ballot.[6] Additionally, Gallup data reveals that self-identified Republicans now outnumber Democrats, reversing a long-standing trend and altering assumptions about turnout benefits.[7] In the high turnout 2020 general election, Georgia Senate candidate Jon Ossoff trailed David Perdue. However, in the lower turnout runoff in January, Ossoff turned his deficit into a victory, with marginal voters who skipped the runoff predominantly being Republicans. This pattern is further supported by the Daily Kos special election tracker, showing Democratic candidates outperforming Biden's 2020 results by 3.8% on average in low turnout special elections.

Overall, reduced voter turnout would give more say to high-engagement voters, who are more educated, older, and whiter. Compared with low-engagement voters, these voters are more likely to prioritize issues such as the economy, healthcare, and education over more

polarizing issues and they are more progressive on immigration, climate change, and civil rights.

Voting is essential for democracy, but the importance of high voter turnout versus moderately high turnout is less clear. Higher turnout can indicate a more engaged electorate and potentially more representative outcomes, but it can also be an indicator of motivated reasoning and in-group/out-group mentality. It is not the only measure of democratic health. Moderately high turnout can still ensure robust participation without the fear, misinformation, or extreme partisanship that comes with high polarization, high turnout elections. Thus, while encouraging voter participation is crucial, it is at least equally important to foster informed and rational engagement. Balancing these aspects can lead to a healthier democracy that values both voting and the quality of decision-making.

Other Political Participation

Voting is not the only essential political behavior. Volunteering and everyday conversations, like sharing a campaign post or putting up a lawn sign, can be just as important as voting. Would there be adequate participation without political parties?

Samara Klar and Yanna Krupnikov are two political party experts who deeply lament the American public's antipathy to political parties. In addition to the role political parties play in raising voter turnout, Klar and Krupnikov emphasize the significance of the "ground game" in political campaigns, which relies heavily on volunteers and the spread of campaign messages through social media, signs, bumper stickers, and buttons. Party organizations like the Democratic National Committee (DNC) and the Republican National Committee (RNC) help candidates develop a ground game and encourage supporters to share their messages online. But Klar and Krupnikov also argue that partisanship helps. As partisanship becomes more socially stigmatized, people who value the approval of others tend to identify as independent voters and withdraw from political activity more generally, not just voting. They still vote for one party and oppose compromise as much as anyone else, but participate less, leading to less effective representation. For participation to flourish, democracy needs more "proud partisans" and fewer independent voters.[8]

Proud partisanship comes at a cost. Political activism may increase as thoughtful deliberation decreases. The voters most likely to be partisan activists are the least likely to weigh trade-offs or consider opposing views

because qualified support undermines the passion needed to devote time to activism.[9] Consequently, partisan fervor drives individuals to vote, volunteer for campaigns, and engage in political discussions. Klar and Krupnikov find that individuals who privately hold strong partisan views but do not openly express them are less politically active than their openly partisan counterparts. Deliberative democrats want high participation and open-minded deliberation, but acknowledge that discouraging partisanship can reduce participation. But closet partisans both participate less and fail to deliberate in earnest. Closet partisans are the worst of both worlds, and Klar and Krupnikov provide evidence that most independents are really closet partisans.

Other researchers don't buy the idea that independent voters are just "leaners" and think there's more variety in their voting patterns.[10] Contrary to Klar and Krupnikov, these researchers argue that independent voters are more open-minded even if they participate less. Independent voters might vote based on specific candidates or issues on the ballot[11] or because of short-term interests rather than long-term loyalty.[12] Political scientist Morris Fiorina found that independent leaners are more like pure independent voters than weak partisans.[13] Another recent study found that party-affiliated voters maintained consistent party-line voting behavior, whether voting straight-ticket or mixed, in 70% of the cases across different waves. In contrast, only 57% of independent voters showed the same consistency. From one survey wave to the next, 16% of both Democrats and Republicans changed their identification, while 36% of independent voters did.[14]

While partisanship is a significant driver of political activity, it is not the only one. In a nonpartisan system, reduced political activity associated with partisanship could be balanced by focusing on civic and issue-based political groups. This approach allows individuals to advocate for specific issues or candidates without the in-group/out-group mentality that tends to accompany partisanship. The social stigma against parties may undermine participation in the current system, but one wonders whether there would be equal stigma against expressing political views in a nonpartisan system. Candidates develop effective ground games in primaries with less reliance on party infrastructure than party nominees in general elections.

Readers who value high participation over rational deliberation might argue that the benefits of partisanship outweigh its disadvantages. However, this perspective must contend with the severe consequences of extreme partisanship evinced during the COVID-19 pandemic and other

crises. One would have to elevate political participation above almost all other values to justify the higher participation that parties allow over the lives lost in periods of excessive partisanship.

Parties and Access to Elections

The ability to vote allows individuals to influence laws and policies that affect their lives. As James Madison wrote in the *Federalist Papers*, "A dependence on the people is, no doubt, the primary control on the government." Without broad suffrage, a democracy cannot truly reflect the will of the people.

Political parties have rightly been celebrated when they expanded suffrage during US history. For example, during the early nineteenth century, the Jeffersonian Republicans and Jacksonian Democrats advocated for the elimination of property requirements for voting, extending the vote to all white men. The Democrats further advanced democratic principles by tying the Electoral College vote to the popular vote in many states, making the presidential election process more reflective of the people's will. During the Reconstruction era following the Civil War, the Republican Party championed the 15th Amendment, which aimed to ensure that the right to vote could not be denied based on race, color, or previous condition of servitude.

However, political parties have worked to restrict access to the ballot at other times. The Federalist Party passed the Naturalization and Alien Acts in the 1790s, which made it harder for immigrants to become citizens vote, because immigrants tended to support their Jeffersonian opponents. Similarly, Republicans passed the Johnson-Reed Act of 1924 to limit immigration from countries whose populations were more likely to vote Democratic. The Democratic Party in the late nineteenth century, while generally protecting immigration, actively sought to undermine the enforcement of the 15th Amendment. In Southern states, Democrats implemented Jim Crow laws, including literacy tests, poll taxes, and outright intimidation and violence, to disenfranchise Black voters. In Congress, Northern and Southern Democrats alike blocked proposals like the Lodge Force Bill to reinvigorate enforcement of the 15th amendment. This systematic exclusion was a significant setback to the progress made during Reconstruction and kept many African Americans from exercising their right to vote for almost another century. More recently, Republican

legislatures have passed Voter ID laws, knowing that minorities are less likely to possess IDs.

There is no denying parties helped expand voting rights at key moments, but looking at the full picture, their record is mixed. Their support for expanded suffrage often appears conditional, influenced by whether the newly enfranchised voters are likely to support them. This "fair weather" support undermines the idea that parties are essential for inclusive democracy. Additionally, independent candidacies and interest groups might be just as effective at expanding suffrage. Civil rights organizations have historically played a crucial role in voter registration efforts and advocating for voting rights. Women's suffrage groups built their coalitions outside the party system, since the major parties mostly ignored them.[15] While political parties have sometimes been pivotal in enacting legislation expanding suffrage, the groundwork and mobilization efforts by interest groups show that in the absence of parties, other organizations can potentially pick up the slack.

Another core democratic norm is the free competition of candidates, where voters have the opportunity to choose from a wide array of political options. Free competition ensures that the electorate can choose representatives who truly reflect their interests. Parties often behave more like cartels than guardians of free competition. Like a cartel in business, they control the political landscape and exclude third-party candidates. Various laws and practices across the United States create significant barriers for third-party candidates, effectively reinforcing the dominance of the major parties.[16]

For example, Georgia imposes stringent ballot access requirements that make it extremely difficult for third-party candidates to compete. To run for a congressional seat, a third-party candidate must gather signatures from at least 5% of registered voters in the district. Candidates and volunteers need to obtain tens of thousands of signatures, a daunting task that requires substantial resources. In Georgia's runoff system, if no candidates gets more than 50% of the vote in the general election, the top two candidates have to face off in a runoff election. This setup squeezes out third-party candidates because it usually means voters end up choosing between the two main contenders in the runoff. Similarly, in Texas, third-party candidates must collect signatures from one percent of the total votes cast in the previous gubernatorial election, all within a narrow timeframe and without including voters who participated in the primaries of other parties. Sore loser laws, like those in Ohio, also prevent candidates

who lost in a primary from running as independent candidates or third-party candidates in the general election. These high thresholds effectively exclude many potential candidates from even appearing on the ballot.

Debate inclusion rules further disadvantage third-party candidates. The Federal Election Commission allows debate sponsors to set their own criteria, often resulting in rules that favor major party candidates. The Commission on Presidential Debates requires candidates to have at least 15% support in national polls to participate. This bar is hard to reach for third-party candidates, denying them the means to broadcast their ideas to a broader audience. Additionally, public funding for presidential campaigns is heavily skewed toward major party candidates. To qualify for general election funding, a candidate must have received at least 5% of the vote in the previous election, which is rarely achieved by third-party candidates.

While third parties are already unlikely to win in a first-past-the-post system, where the candidate with the most votes wins, the exclusionary tactics employed by major parties are still anti-democratic as they intentionally limit the choices available to voters and stifle political diversity. The major parties are not just playing to win within the rules but altering the rules so that they never lose.

Conclusion

Parties increase voting and participation, and both are crucial for democracy. But it is debatable how much parties increase both, and how much better high turnout is compared to moderately high turnout. We have some participation in nonpartisan local elections and one-party primaries. Moderate turnout can still foster participation and potentially with fewer negative effects like misinformation-driven turnout. We should want people to vote, but also to think critically when they do. That's what keeps democracy healthy.

So far, the evidence points to political parties encouraging participation but doing the opposite of what's required for deliberation. We were willing to sacrifice about 20% of voter turnout to reduce Gilded Age corruption. One might argue that sacrificing some more might be worth it to avoid the negative effects of partisanship on a global pandemic. The real challenge is keeping people engaged without falling into the traps of ingroup/outgroup mentality and motivated reasoning.

Notes

1. Selb, P. (2008) A deeper look at the proportionality–turnout nexus. *Comparative Political Studies* 42(4): 527–548; Blais, A. and Dobrzynska, A. (1998) Turnout in electoral democracies. *European Journal of Political Research* 33(2): 239–261; Lijphart, A. (2007) *Thinking About Democracy*. London and New York: Taylor & Francis; Negri, M. (2014) Minority representation in proportional representation systems. Unpublished manuscript, University of St. Andrews; Altman, D., Flavin, P. and Radcliff, B. (2017) Democratic institutions and subjective well-being. *Political Studies* 65(3): 685–704; Radcliff, B. (2013) *The Political Economy of Human Happiness: How Voters' Choices Determine the Quality of Life*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
2. Schaffner, B.F., Rhodes, J.H. and La Raja, R.J. (2022) The conservative bias in America's local governments. *Political Science Quarterly* 137(1): 125–154.
3. McDonald, M.P. and Popkin, S.L. (2001) The myth of the vanishing voter. *American Political Science Review* 95(4): 963–974; Gerber, A.S. and Green, D.P. (2000) The effects of canvassing, telephone calls, and direct mail on voter turnout: A field experiment. *American Political Science Review* 94(3): 653–663.
4. Klar, S. and Krupnikov, Y. (2016) *Independent Politics: How American Disdain for Parties Leads to Political Inaction*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
5. Wasserman, D. (2024) Tale of two electorates: Trump is excelling with lower-engagement voters, but will they show up? *Cook Political Report*, 31 May. Available at: https://www.cookpolitical.com/survey-research/2024-swing-state-project/tale-two-electorates-trump-excelling-lower
6. Cohn, N. (2024) Election 2024: Democrats, Republicans, and turnout. *The New York Times*, 15 June. Available at: https://www.nytimes.com/2024/06/15/upshot/election-democrats-republicans-turnout-trump.html
7. Jones, J.M. (2024) Independent party ID tied for high; Democratic ID at new low. *Gallup News*, 12 January. Available at: https://news.gallup.com/poll/548459/independent-party-tied-high-democratic-new-low.aspx.

8. Klar, S. and Krupnikov, Y. (2016) *Independent Politics: How American Disdain for Parties Leads to Political Inaction*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
9. Mutz, D.C. (2006) *Hearing the Other Side: Deliberative versus Participatory Democracy*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
10. Abrams, S.J. and Fiorina, M.P. (2011) Are leaning independents deluded or dishonest weak partisans? Paper presented at the conference *Revisiting Party Identification: American and European Perspectives*, Rome: Luiss School of Government; Page, B.I. and Jones, C.C. (1979) Reciprocal effects of policy preferences, party loyalties and the vote. *American Political Science Review* 73(4): 1071–1089; Fiorina, M.P. (1977) An outline for a model of party choice. *American Journal of Political Science* 21(3): 601–625; Jackson, J.E. (1975) Issues, party choices, and presidential votes. *American Journal of Political Science* 19(1): 161–185.
11. Reilly, T. and Hunting, D. (2023) The fluid voter: Exploring independent voting patterns over time. *Politics & Policy* 51(1): 59–80.
12. Miller, W.E. (1991) Party identification, realignment, and party voting: Back to the basics. *American Political Science Review* 85(2): 557–568.
13. Fiorina, M.P. (2017) *Unstable Majorities: Polarization, Party Sorting, and Political Stalemate*. Stanford, CA: Hoover Institution Press; Abrams, S.J. and Fiorina, M.P. (2011) Are leaning independents deluded or dishonest weak partisans? Paper presented at the conference *Revisiting Party Identification: American and European Perspectives*, Rome: Luiss School of Government.
14. Reilly, T. and Hunting, D. (2023) The fluid voter: Exploring independent voting patterns over time. *Politics & Policy* 51(1): 59–80.
15. McConnaughy, C.M., 2013. *The Woman Suffrage Movement in America: A Reassessment*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
16. Katz, R.S. and Mair, P. (2009) The cartel party thesis: A restatement. *Perspectives on Politics* 7(4): 753–766.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 7

Political Parties and Democratic Norms

Abstract Party loyalty undermines checks and balances and the peaceful transfer of power. When allegiance to a party superpasses allegiance to basic democratic norms, the health of a democracy is in peril. Parties also foster a "spirit of revenge" that prioritizes defeating opponents over governing responsibly. Preserving democratic norms requires loyalty to constitutional principles above partisan identity, and parties lack the incentive to encourage this kind of loyalty.

Keywords Checks and balances · Congress · Demagoguery · Democratic-republican party · Executive aggrandizement · Federalist 10 · Federalist 51 · Federalist party · Founders · Framers · Groupthink · James Madison · Missouri compromise · Party primaries · Supreme Court · Washington's Farewell Address

Imagine trying to play a game where the players cannot agree on the rules. Even if the rules are written down, without mutual respect for those rules, the game falls apart quickly. This is a lot like what happens in democracies. Democracies need more than just written laws; they need citizens to respect the norms that keep the system running smoothly, such as checks and balances, the peaceful transfer of power, and loyal opposition. Some democracies haven't lasted long because, despite having

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_7

democratic constitutions, they lacked the informal support for democratic norms.

This chapter explores whether political parties help uphold these essential democratic norms. These norms are crucial for the functioning and stability of any democracy. The founders of the United States believed parties could disrupt these norms, leading to factionalism and conflict. On the other hand, modern political scientists tend to disagree with the founder's skepticism, and even claim parties are healthy or essential. As future voters and influencers, you should understand how parties affect the health of the democratic system itself.

Why the Founders' Perspectives Matter

The founders' insights and fears help us see how our system could work differently and the potential pitfalls of the political system they designed. While democracy has evolved significantly since the eighteenth century, revisiting the founders' viewpoints can still inform today's debates about political parties.

When we think of the founding fathers of the United States, we often conjure images of unity and patriotism. But the founders were acutely aware of the dangers of factions, which are groups advancing their own agendas at the expense of the public interest. During the Articles of Confederation, there were no parties as we understand them today, but there were self-interested factions that greatly troubled the founders. A faction, in the lexicon of the time, referred to a group of individuals united by a common interest or passion that ran counter to the general welfare. In other words, factions were seen as self-interested cliques whose primary aim was to advance their own agenda at the expense of the broader populace.

Although the founders wanted to change many features of the Articles of Confederation, the absence of formal parties was something they wanted to preserve. President George Washington tried to avoid political parties by having a cabinet that represented multiple regions and perspectives, thus representing the whole country. Political parties quickly emerged anyway, and they didn't play nice. They published personal attacks and misinformation, some of which were as scandalous and libelous as any misinformation you might come across today. Most of the previous critics of political parties joined either the "Federalist" or "Republican" party but the party competition nonetheless confirmed

their fears about parties. Thomas Jefferson helped found one of the parties, but wrote that "the complete suppression of party" could occur once Republicans ended "the Federalists' slouch toward monarchy."

In their textbook on political parties, Seth Masket and Hans Noel point out that the founders' bias against political parties resulted partly from their desire to protect their own property. They worried that parties that expanded their base by expanding suffrage to those with less property might one day lead to government redistribution of property.[1] This may be true, but if we are evaluating party criticisms by the personal flaws of the earliest critics, the first politicians who defended political parties also had questionable character and motives. The first unequivocal defenses of parties and the popular vote were offered by the founders of the Democratic Party in the 1820s, like Andrew Jackson and Martin Van Buren. To Van Buren, Jackson was the tribune of the people, and only a political party could serve as a permanent tribune of the people. This sounds democratic enough, but the expansion of representation came at the expense of marginalized groups, not just educated elites. Jackson embodied the white men of the frontier who viewed Native Americans as, at best, childlike savages to be looked over paternalistically. He was unwilling to honor even the limited concessions early, less partisan presidents and governors provided for Native Americans. Unlike many of the founders, he felt no shame over owning or even trading slaves, a distinction that mattered at the time. Van Buren explicitly defended parties on the grounds that a cross-national coalition would avoid raising the slavery issue, for fear of dividing parties.

So, the first critics of political parties had many flaws and biases, but so did the first defenders of political parties. The founders' arguments against political parties aren't definitive proof that party politics are either good or bad. The founding documents did not extend rights to multiple races and genders, though they provided intellectual basis for doing so to future reformers at home and abroad. The founders offer insight that we are unlikely to gain from contemporary thinkers because they were born and raised in a world without entrenched party systems. This allowed them to question the inevitability of partisan politics in a way that is more difficult for us, since we've grown up assuming parties are here to stay.

The Mischiefs of Faction

The fear of factions lay at the heart of the founders' distrust of political parties. They thought both parties and interest groups would be susceptible to the same negative dynamics. James Madison, often hailed as the "father of the U.S. Constitution," articulated this concern in Federalist 10. He warned against the "mischiefs of faction," arguing that they arose from the "spirit of party" which was "inseparable from our nature." While Madison acknowledged that freedom of speech and association made factions unavoidable in a free society, he believed in curtailing their power.

Madison argued that a large republic with a diversity of factions could dilute the influence of any single group, thereby preventing any one faction from dominating the political landscape. Although he recognized the necessity of factions to check and balance each other, he was adamant that their power should be limited to protect the public good. Modern defenders of political parties advocate for their strengthening, but Madison saw them as a necessary evil that should be kept in check. At the end of Washington's first term, most of the founders sorted into political parties, but they also hoped parties were only a temporary necessity.

To win elections, founders feared that factions and parties would manipulate public opinion and inflame passions rather than encourage rational deliberation. Appealing to the people was a step along a slippery slope to demagoguery, where candidates would undermine elites and exploit popular prejudices to concentrate power in their own hands. Soft demagogues would flatter the public and turn them against knowledgeable elites, while hard demagogues would rally people against unpopular minorities to gain power. During the Articles of Confederation, Pennsylvania's disenfranchisement of Quakers exemplified the hard demagoguery of factions.

Building on Madison's concerns about factions, George Washington's Farewell Address cautioned that excessive party spirit could empower self-serving candidates:

> The alternate domination of one faction over another, sharpened by the spirit of revenge natural to party dissension, which in different ages and countries has perpetuated the most horrid enormities, is itself a frightful despotism. The disorders and miseries gradually incline the minds of men to seek security and repose in the absolute power of an individual; and sooner or later the chief of some prevailing faction... turns this despotism to the purpose of his own elevation, on the ruins of public liberty.

Washington was concerned that unyielding loyalty to a party could lead to unyielding loyalty to party candidates, facilitating the rise of dictatorship. Parties can encourage a "spirit of revenge," leading their members to wish for the failure of opposing administrations, as disaster might help their own parties win the next election. For instance, in January 2009, conservative radio host Rush Limbaugh said, "I hope he [Barack Obama] fails." Limbaugh's hope was that Obama's failure would prevent the solidification of Democratic power. Similarly, in 2018, comedian and political commentator Bill Maher stated on his HBO show "Real Time with Bill Maher" that he hoped for a recession to prevent President Trump's reelection.

Madison further noted that people might support or oppose a policy simply because it is advocated by the opposite party. He stated, "I say parties and factions will not suffer improvements to be made. As soon as one man hints at an improvement, his rival opposes it. No sooner has one party discovered or invented any amelioration of the condition of man, or the order of society than the opposite party belies it, misconstrues it, misrepresents it, ridicules it, insults it, and persecutes [it]." Let's look at some historical examples. When Federalist Alexander Hamilton proposed the creation of the National Bank, it faced fierce opposition from the Republicans, including future presidents James Madison and James Monroe. They argued it was unconstitutional and would centralize too much power. However, when Republicans gained power, both Madison and Monroe saw the utility of the National Bank and supported it, showing how opposition can be more about party rivalry than principle. Fast forward to 2004, when Republican President George W. Bush proposed a manned mission to Mars in his State of the Union address. Traditionally, Democrats had supported ambitious space missions, and the Kennedy Administration proposed the first manned mission to the moon. Many on the left have since lamented the movement of ambitious space projects from the public sector to the private sector in recent years. Democrats in Congress during the Bush administration, not typically known for fiscal conservatism, emphasized the project's costs. Senator Ted Kennedy said, "If you're going to spend $100 billion or $200 billion, it seems to me we should spend it here on Earth, and I can think of a lot of things we could spend it on. How about spending it on the 44 million Americans who have no health insurance?" And West Virginia Senator Jay Rockefeller added, "I wish we had enough money to do that. It would be wonderful to do it. But we don't."

Needless to say, reflexive partisanship is still with us. During the debates over Trump's controversial 2025 "Big Beautiful Bill," a Republican member of Congress texted Vice President J.D. Vance, "I was undecided on the bill but then I watched Hakeem Jeffries' performance and now I'm a firm yes."[2] It was a striking admission: his support wasn't based on the bill's merits, but on his distaste for the opposing party's minority leader. Partisans oppose proposals from other parties both out of habit and cultivated animosity, as well as the need to deprive the opposing party of the ability to claim credit in elections. All of this shows the founders' fears about the "spirit of revenge" are relevant today.

Parties and Loyal Opposition

While historical examples highlight the dangers of partisan rivalry, some contemporary thinkers argue that strong parties are able to curb excessive ambition and the "spirit of revenge" better than candidates without parties or parties with limited power. Nancy Rosenblum, for example, defends political parties by arguing that they promote the concept of "loyal opposition." Parties have an incentive to transfer power peacefully so that power will be transferred back to them peacefully in future elections. This mutual expectation encourages parties to concede elections that they lost, or at least adjudicate any disputes in the courts. An independent politician has no loyalty to an organization that benefits from the peaceful transfer of power in the future.

Unfortunately, long-term reputations have not kept parties in line. During the Civil War, Democratic plantation owners who supported secession were able to remain influential after Reconstruction. In 1972, Republicans attempted to win an election through chicanery, breaking into the Democratic Party headquarters and spying on their strategy. President Nixon and his associates participated in a cover-up. Members of the Nixon administration went on to hold significant positions, with some becoming cabinet officials or even president. Thus far, Republicans have continued to win primaries even if they denied the results of the 2020 election, even though it hurts them in the general election. One notable exception was the Hartford Convention during the War of 1812, where Federalists in New England considered seceding from the union. Federalists were permanently discredited when Andrew Jackson won the celebrated the Battle of New Orleans, technically after the war was over.

This, however, is an outlier. More commonly, allies of tarnished administrations often return to politics quickly. This undermines the idea that parties keep their candidates within reasonable bounds because they take a long-term perspective on the peaceful transfer of power than candidates do.

Only a tiny fraction of American voters is willing to put democratic principles above their partisan loyalties. In fact, just 3.5% of voters would consider voting against their preferred candidates as a consequence for undemocratic actions like restricting the press or disenfranchising voters.[3]

President Biden echoed Rosenblum's need for loyal opposition. In 2021, he stated, "We need a Republican party. We need an opposition that's principled and strong." Later, he highlighted the dangers of Trump factions in the Republican Party by saying, "Donald Trump and the MAGA Republicans represent an extremism that threatens the very foundations of our republic. Not every Republican, not even the majority of Republicans, are MAGA Republicans. Not every Republican embraces their extreme ideology. I know because I've been able to work with these mainstream Republicans."

However, the actions of Biden's own party sometimes undermined principled non-MAGA Republicans. Some Republicans took huge chances to oppose Trump, and Democrats helped push them out of the party by funding extreme MAGA candidates in primary challenges. If Trump truly posed an existential threat, a loyal opposition party would not aid extreme candidates just to win the next election. This tactic demonstrates either dishonesty about the existential threat or a willingness to undermine democracy for electoral gain, not loyal opposition.

In Michigan, the DCCC spent $425,000 on ads that bolstered John Gibbs against Representative Peter Meijer, one of ten Republicans who voted to impeach Trump after January 6. Gibbs denied the results of the 2020 presidential election, accused Obama administration officials of participating in bizarre satanic rituals, and defended antisemites. The DCCC's $425,000 ad buy to promote John Gibbs over Meijer was more than Gibbs raised over his entire campaign. In New Hampshire, a Democratic-aligned PAC advertised for a Republican Senate primary candidate who called the popular Republican governor a communist sympathizer. Democrats also helped an election denier win Republican primaries in Arizona. The state's Democratic Party sent an email blast highlighting Kari Lake's rival Karrin Taylor Robson's past support of Democrats, thanking her for her donations.

This strategy was reminiscent of Hillary Clinton's "Pied Piper" memo in 2016, where her campaign hoped to help cranks and extreme Republicans win their party's presidential primary. The "Pied Piper" strategy proposed intentionally cultivating them to make them the mainstream of the Republican Party. The idea was to force established candidates toward conspiracy theories or the extreme right, making them less electable in the general election. This tactic backfired spectacularly, as Trump not only won the Republican nomination but also won the presidency, highlighting the dangers of manipulating other parties for short-term gain.

These actions demonstrate a troubling willingness for parties to nurture disloyal opposition in the other party, elevating candidates who can threaten democratic norms for short-term electoral gains, which did not even materialize in the 2016 presidential election.

Political scientist Julia Azari regrets all of these developments but believes that stronger parties are more likely to control their nominees and make them adhere to democratic norms. She believes that robust party structures help select viable nominees for public office in the past, especially in times of high partisanship.[4] When parties are weak, too many candidates run for office and parties find it difficult to weed out bad candidates. Trump's nomination in 2016 highlighted the inability of party networks and leaders to coordinate and control the nomination process. In the general election, he suggested he would "lock up" Hillary Clinton and refuse to concede the election. Then in 2020, he refused to admit defeat and even encouraged protestors who tried to stop the counting of electoral votes on January 6, 2021. While congressional Republicans were privately outraged, the party lacked the power to look after its long-term interest in the peaceful transfer of power or its reputation. The few Republicans who voted to impeach Trump either lost primary challenges (with the help of Democrats in some cases) or retired.

In contrast, Democrats were able to control their nominations in 2016, 2020, and 2024, showing that strong parties could potentially stop or restrain a dangerous nominee. In 2016, Bernie Sanders lost partly because Democratic interest groups supported Hillary Clinton, and the Democratic National Committee appeared to favor her during the primary debates. In 2020, former President Barack Obama and other Democratic Party leaders orchestrated a wave of endorsements for Joe Biden following his South Carolina primary win, demonstrating the influence of party elites. The coordinated effort to endorse Harris in the summer of

2024 also reveals influence of party elites and the broader party network in determining who gets nominated. None of these cases shows that the Democratic Party foiled an attempt to subvert democracy, but they show how strong parties could stop a candidate who did.

There is a crucial distinction between claiming that "political parties are bad for democracy" and asserting that "given the existence of parties, they should control the nomination process." Both statements can be true. But the existence of political parties provided Trump with a platform far larger than he could have achieved alone in a hypothetical party-free country and generated the kind of unyielding loyalty typical of partisans. Conversely, persuading President Biden to step down is a complicated example. Biden's decline in speaking and cognitive abilities was evident long before 2024, and had party elites urged him to step down in 2023, the primaries might have selected a stronger nominee to face Trump. It would have deprived Republicans of the "soft coup" narrative in the 2024 election. Even close allies like Barack Obama and George Clooney were stunned by Biden's condition during private events, but party insiders continued to downplay his decline and discourage serious primary challenges. This left Democrats scrambling when Biden's deterioration became undeniable after his first debate with Donald Trump in 2024. The Democratic Party rushed to hand the nomination to Vice President Kamala Harris and added to the voters' sense that they had been misled. Later, Harris could not easily criticize Biden and his enablers without implicating herself in the cover-up. In shielding their leader for too long, supposedly responsible party insiders may have cost their party the presidency.[5]

Other political scientists believe that the problem runs deeper than the lack of gatekeeping power. Samuel Popkin argues in *Crackup* that the end of the Cold War dissolved the foreign policy consensus that once unified Republicans, while media fragmentation undermined party elites' ability to control narratives.[6] From this perspective, reinforcing party strength would do little if the coalitions in parties are too heterogeneous and lack consistent principles.

Parties and Checks and Balances

When most people use the word democracy today, they don't just mean majority rule; they also mean a system of checks and balances that ensures no single branch of government can dominate the others. James Madison

emphasized this dual necessity, stating, "A dependence on the people is, no doubt, the primary control on the government," as we noted earlier. But he immediately followed up by acknowledging that "experience has taught mankind the necessity of auxiliary precautions." By auxiliary precautions, Madison was referring to checks and balances. The founders of the United States differed from modern democratic theorists in many ways, but both agree on the importance of these checks and balances, which are designed to prevent any one branch from gaining too much power.

In Federalist 51, Madison argued that dividing governmental authority among three separate branches—legislative, executive, and judicial—would prevent tyranny and ensure the protection of individual liberties. The legislative, executive, and judicial branches have distinct functions and tools to check one another, such as the President's veto power, Congress's control over the budget, and the judiciary's power to declare laws unconstitutional. By granting each branch distinct powers and responsibilities, officials would have a natural incentive to defend the authority and prerogatives of their branch against encroachments by the others. Madison wrote that "ambition must be made to counteract ambition. The interest of the man must be connected with the constitutional rights of the place." He anticipated that officials would be more loyal to their branch than to their party because their own power was tied to the power of the branch they served. The point of all of this was to safeguard against tyranny and protect the freedoms and rights of individuals when elections failed to do so.

Despite Madison's vision, the rise of political parties has mostly shifted the loyalty of government officials from their branches to their parties. This shift can undermine the system of checks and balances, as officials prioritize party goals over the constitutional balance of power. When the same party controls both Congress and the presidency, Congress holds fewer oversight hearings, approves more nominees, and generally defers more to the executive branch.

The Republican-dominated Congress of the 1920s delegated tariff-setting powers to the executive branch, then in the hands of Republican presidents. The Fordney-McCumber Tariff Act of 1922 granted the president the authority to raise and lower tariffs within prescribed limits without congressional approval. This shift of power from Congress to the executive branch weakened the traditional system of checks and balances. A century later, Trump raised and lowered tariffs at will, triggering wild

swings in the stock market and shaking confidence in the bond market with unprecedented uncertainty. (In fairness, a small number of Republicans in Congress like Don Bacon and Rand Paul attempted to roll back this authority.) In the 1920s, Congress also passed the Budget and Accounting Act, which empowered the president to prepare the first draft of the federal budget and submit it to Congress for approval. This effectively gave the president greater control over fiscal policy, when one of Congress' main checks on the president is the power of the purse.

Democrats soon followed suit in the 1930s. The Executive Office of the President (EOP), established by President Franklin D. Roosevelt in 1939, brought together various agencies, councils, and staff offices to support the president in carrying out executive functions. The original presidential cabinet was subject to Senate approval, but much of the EOP is not. Advisors and staff members within the EOP serve at the pleasure of the president, enabling them to shape policy agendas, provide counsel, and implement presidential directives without significant congressional interference. Congress, controlled by Franklin Roosevelt's party, did not stand in the way. The establishment of the EOP undermined Congress's check on executive power by centralizing administrative functions within the presidency, reducing the ability of Congress to check the bureaucracy with oversight and the need to approve appointments.

At times, partisans exercise power through inaction. One such example could be the authorization of the use of military force without congressional approval. Presidents have often committed the military to a significant intervention or prolonged conflict without seeking formal authorization from Congress. Barack Obama, for example, waged war in Libya for months and never sought congressional approval. One of the only serious attempts to rein in presidential power was the War Powers Act, passed by Democrats during Nixon's presidency. While the act was used to counteract Trump's foreign policy in Yemen, Trump vetoed the measure, and enough Republicans refused to override the veto, rendering the one invocation of the War Powers Act irrelevant. In 2025, Trump bombed Iran without even consulting members of Congress privy to classified information, let alone getting a declaration of war.

There are exceptions to this pattern. For instance, a Democratic Congress blocked Franklin Roosevelt's proposal to "pack" the Supreme Court. Both Democrats and Republicans in Congress voted together to block Nixon's attempt to impound funds allocated by Congress. During the Watergate scandal, a bipartisan coalition in Congress held hearings,

conducted investigations, and ultimately compelled President Nixon to resign. But all happened in periods of low polarization with conservative Democrats and liberal Republicans.

Partisanship has arguably undermined the federal courts' role as a check and balance as well. The judiciary was designed to make decisions based on good law rather than temporary political considerations. Life tenure insulated them from political pressures and supposedly ensured impartiality. While many decisions are unanimous or don't strictly follow party lines, decisions concerning power exercised by another branch often do. During the Obama, Trump, and Biden administrations, the Supreme Court reviewed several executive orders that plaintiffs considered executive overreach. Typically, justices appointed by presidents of the same party upheld these executive orders, while justices from the opposing party struck them down. Under a Republican majority court, executive orders from Obama and Biden, such as those on immigration and climate change policies, were struck down by Republican appointees with Democrats dissenting. On the other hand, Republican appointees on the court upheld many of Trump's executive orders, like the travel ban, with Democratic-appointed justices dissenting.

As a final touch, six Republican justices voted to grant presidents considerable immunity for official actions when Trump was being charged for crimes in office, while the three Democratic justices dissented. The founders were aware of the concept of immunity for political offices, which they provided for legislators in the Speech or Debate Clause, but deliberately chose not to include it for the President. Furthermore, some state constitutions at the time of the founders specifically provided criminal immunities to sitting governors, yet the founders at the Constitutional Convention did not include similar language for the President. As Justice Sotomayor noted, "The Constitution's text contains no provision for immunity from criminal prosecution for former Presidents." The Impeachment Judgment Clause even presumes the availability of criminal process by establishing that an official impeached and convicted by the Senate "shall nevertheless be liable and subject to Indictment, Trial, Judgment and Punishment, according to Law." The Republican appointments had no rebuttal and instead offered pragmatic grounds for their decision, even though several of them claimed to espouse "originalism," where judges base decisions on the text or intent of the law rather than policy outcomes. This trend raises questions over whether partisanship

can unduly influence judicial decisions, undermining the intended impartiality and effectiveness of the Supreme Court as a nonpartisan check on the other branches. In *Trumpv. CASA, Inc.* (2025), the six Republicans on the Supreme Court curtailed the power of federal district judges to issue nationwide injunctions, making it easier for presidents to implement sweeping policies without judicial interference. The court restricted its own branch's power vis-à-vis the executive branch, which is the opposite of what Madison expected.

Others view the potential for judicial checks and balances more optimistically. The number of cases Supreme Court justices decide unanimously varies between 40–60%, and the number of cases decided along party lines is small. For example, the number of six-to-three decisions divided by purely partisan breakdowns was nine percent in 2025. In *Trumpv. CASA, Inc.*, critics saw an effort to shield the executive branch from judicial scrutiny, but defenders argued that the Supreme Court acted within the bounds of statutory authority. The Judiciary Act of 1789 did not authorize federal courts to issue remedies that extend beyond the parties before them, and the majority noted district courts did not traditionally have the power to issue universal injunctions. In the recent decision *W.M.M. v. Trump*, the same Republican majority blocked President Trump's attempt to rapidly deport Venezuelan migrants using the 1798 Alien Enemies Act, holding that detainees must receive a hearing where they can challenge their removal.[7] Back in the Bush era, a Supreme Court with a different Republican majority also imposed important limits on executive authority. In *Hamdi v. Rumsfeld* (2004), it confirmed that even wartime detainees have a right to challenge their detention, and in *Hamdan v. Rumsfeld* (2006), it struck down military commissions set up without congressional approval. Defenders of the judicial branch use rulings like these to argue that the judiciary is more than another partisan branch of government.

Regardless, the most predictable checks and balances in America today occur when one-party checks and balances the other party. Voters don't expect a Republican Congress to check a Democratic president because they naturally have opposing interests as different branches, but because they belong to different parties. Substituting party checks on other branches is an inferior way to protect individuals from government power grabs. Hypothetically, parties could roll back excessive power granted to another branch when a different party takes control. However, in reality,

parties know their time in power is limited and prefer to use any power available rather than relinquish it.

The examples in this section demonstrate how partisanship can weaken legislative oversight and skew judicial decisions, compromising the integrity of checks and balances and therefore democracy as a whole. The challenge remains to uphold checks and balances, not just as a way to enforce voter will, but as a guardrail against power grabs. The cascading influence of partisanship threatens to erode this foundational principle, reminding us that democracy does not run on auto-pilot or vigilance over the other party alone.

Conclusion

Political parties reveal a stark duality. On the one hand, they've sometimes been the torchbearers of expanded suffrage and political inclusivity. On the other, they've manipulated the very systems meant to prevent the concentration of power, fostering a "spirit of revenge" and compromising essential checks and balances. The founders warned us about the "mischiefs of faction," and today, we see that partisanship often eclipses patriotism, paving the way for demagogues and threatening the rules of the game. If parties continue to undermine norms such as checks and balances and access to elections, we risk not just the loss of rational deliberation, but democracy itself.

Notes

1. Masket, S. and Noel, H. (2021) *Political Parties*. New York: W.W. Norton.
2. Vance, J.D. (@JDVance) (2025). X post, 3 July. Available at: https://twitter.com/JDVance/status/1940744435874324894
3. Graham, M.H. and Svolik, M.W. (2020) Democracy in America? Partisanship, polarization, and the robustness of support for democracy in the United States. *American Political Science Review* 114(2): 392–409.
4. Azari, J. (2020) It's time to switch to preference primaries. *The Washington Post*, 18 February. Available at: https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2020/02/18/its-time-switch-preference-primaries/

5. Tapper, J. and Thompson, A. (2025) 'How Joe Biden handed the presidency to Donald Trump', *The New Yorker*, 13 May.
6. Popkin, S.L., 2021. *Crackup: The Republican implosion and the future of presidential politics*. New York: Oxford University Press.
7. In 2025, Republican judges in lower courts also halted or reversed detentions and deportations to third countries, including the mistaken deportation of Kilmar Abrego Garcia. On the other hand, Brian Murphy, a federal district judge appointed by Biden, barred deportations to third countries like South Sudan in *D.V.D. v. DHS* without a meaningful opportunity to challenge the deportation. In a 6–3 decision along partisan lines, the Supreme Court stayed Murphy's injunction pending appeal, allowing the administration to resume deportations to third countries.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

PART III

The Party in Government

CHAPTER 8

National Government, With and Without Party

Abstract This chapter examines the role of parties in national institutions. In Congress, parties help their members coordinate and pass laws, but they also obstruct good legislation from the minority party. The presidential administrations of George Washington and James Monroe offer evidence that the executive branch does not depend on partisanship. Finally, the Confederate States of America are an important counterexample. This chapter investigates the claim that one-party dominance in the Confederacy stifled decision-making and successful government.

Keywords Bipartisanship · Confederacy · Confederate States of America · Congress · Divided government · Era of good feeling · Long coalitions · Polarization · Presidency · Presidential cabinet

Partisanship among voters leads to an epidemic of motivated reasoning, but perhaps it provides necessary organization to large assemblies like the U.S. Congress. Defenders of political parties argue that legislators need parties to build alliances capable of consistently securing majorities. Detractors highlight a darker facet of partisanship: the deliberate obstruction of proposals from opposing parties solely to stifle their political rivals and safeguard their own interests. This chapter examines the merits and drawbacks of political parties as they are organized in the national government.

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_8

How Parties Might Increase Legislative Productivity

Scholars debate how important parties are in organizing legislatures. A few decades ago, some scholars de-emphasized their role. The earlier literature may be dated, but a book about political parties must also consider how parties operate in both polarized times and less polarized times. Polarization is not the only lens through which to understand parties in Congress.

In *Pivotal Politics*, Keith Krehbiel argued that what really shapes legislation is the preferences of pivotal players in Congress: those whose votes are crucial for forming a majority, overcoming a veto, or ending a filibuster. For example, if 60 votes are needed to end a filibuster, the most influential member will be the one casting the 60th vote. This means that person's stance on an issue can significantly shape what legislation gets passed. Krehbiel's work, along with subsequent studies, shows that legislative rules and the positions of these pivotal players matter more than which party controls the chamber.[1]

Another argument that de-emphasizes parties came from Mayhew's *Divided We Govern*. Mayhew argues that significant legislation can still pass even under divided government, when one-party controls the presidency and the other controls one or both houses of Congress. It's not so much about which party has control but whether the voters and the times demand significant legislation. For example, during Richard Nixon's Republican presidency, Democratic majorities in Congress passed more impressive legislation than during some periods of unified Democratic control.[2]

Critics argue that Krehbiel and Mayhew's findings no longer hold in today's polarized politics. When politics are polarized, party control can have a bigger impact on legislative outcomes, making unified governments more effective at passing laws than divided ones. When the same party is in charge of the presidency and Congress, legislative productivity is usually higher. This means that having a unified government makes it easier to pass laws. The current consensus among congressional scholars leans toward acknowledging the significant role of party control in legislation.[3]

Political scientists usually like political parties in the legislature because they can bundle proposals for allies, overcoming gridlock. To see how this works and why polarization can hinder it, consider a simplified example.

Taking inspiration from John Aldrich's classic book *Why Parties*, imagine a tiny legislature with three members who each have their own pet projects.[4] Let's call them Claire, John, and Charlie. Claire really wants to legalize ferret ownership in Hawaii. John dreams of a giant statue of a gopher in the town square. Charlie envisions a roadkill museum. Each of them loves their own bill and rates it as a 3 on a scale of 3 to −3. Each of them dislikes each other's bills and rates them as a −1 on a scale of 3 to −3. If they vote on each bill separately, nothing gets done because they block each other. But if they team up, they can all get something.

So imagine if Claire, John, and Charlie decided to support each other's bills. In this case, all three bills would pass, and each legislator would end up with one win and two losses. Let's break down what this looks like:

1. Claire gets ferret legalization (+3 for Claire), but she has to endure the gopher statue and the roadkill museum (−2 for Claire).
2. John gets his gopher statue (+3 for John), but has to accept ferret legalization and the roadkill museum (−2 for John).
3. Charlie builds a roadkill museum (+3 for Charlie), but has to put up with ferret legalization and the gopher statue (−2 for Charlie).

In this scenario, each legislator ends up with one win (+3 points) and two losses (−2 points), for a net score of +1.

Now, let's consider why it's better for two of them (let's just say Claire and John) to form a long coalition and exclude the other (let's just say Charlie). When Claire and John team up:

1. Claire gets ferret legalization (+3 for Claire) and John gets the gopher statue (+3 for John), but neither of them has to deal with the roadkill museum. Claire gets ferret legalization (+3) and tolerates the gopher statue (−1) for a net score of +2. John gets his gopher statue (+3) and tolerates ferret legalization (−1) for a net score of +2.
2. Charlie ends up with no wins and has to deal with both the ferret legalization and the gopher statue (−2), for a net score of −2.

Charlie gets nothing and ends up grumpy. In this example, Claire and John formed a "long coalition" by supporting each other's bills and ignoring Charlie. This teamwork is like how political parties work in real

legislatures. Allies stick together and exclude others to get more of what they want done. Poor Charlie can only hope to find new friends among the voters to replace Claire and John in the next election.

As odd as these examples may sound, they show why legislators find parties useful. Party members might even be willing to elect leaders who can strong-arm their colleagues into voting along party lines. You might vote for something you dislike today, knowing your colleagues will return the favor tomorrow. This give-and-take is why the assistant to the party leader in both the House and Senate is called the "whip." Legislators don't call this person the whip for nothing; whips keep party members in line, much like a coach keeps their players focused on winning the game. So, while you might not always agree with the party's stance, the overall strategy is to ensure that the party as a whole can push through the legislation it supports. This system of mutual coercion ensures that while you might have to bend sometimes, others will bend for you too, creating a balanced give-and-take within the party.

Party loyalty not only allows long coalitions to pass more legislation, but taps into the all-too-human tendency for group identity. As congressional scholar Sean Theriault argues, members risk challenges in primary elections if they step out of line, because the party's activist base may view voting against the party as a betrayal of principle. When a party is linked so strongly to group identity, voting against your party seems like a betrayal of identity even on small issues.[5] Writers who focus on polarization, like *New York Times* columnist Ezra Klein, often point to the downfall of House Majority Leader Eric Cantor to show what happens when Republicans in particular step out of line. Cantor was no moderate; he voted repeatedly to repeal Obamacare and backed Paul Ryan's budget cuts. But he also became a target when he was willing to provide a path to citizenship for undocumented immigrants brought to the United States as children. Cantor became a victim of the Tea Party, a conservative political movement advocating for limited government and lower taxes, and often challenging more moderate Republicans in primary elections for being insufficiently conservative. A little-known Tea Party challenger named David Brat painted Cantor as someone who might cut a deal with President Obama, and Cantor lost his primary. Cantor remains the highest-ranking member of the House ever to be defeated in a primary election.

When the Affordable Care Act (ACA) was being passed in 2010, there were several important moments where the bill almost failed. One

big issue was the debate over the "public option." A public option is a government-run health insurance plan that competes with private insurers to offer more affordable coverage. Many Democrats liked this idea because they thought it would increase competition and lower costs. However, not everyone was on board. Some Republicans and moderate Democrats worried that a government-run plan would interfere too much with the private insurance market and lead to too much government control. Because of this opposition, Democratic leaders like President Obama and House Speaker Nancy Pelosi had to negotiate and make compromises to get enough votes to pass the ACA. In the end, they decided to drop the public option to ensure the bill would avoid a Senate filibuster and pass the bill. Instead, they expanded Medicaid and created insurance exchanges.

Parties in the legislature do not always succeed in making compromises sufficient to pass a bill. In 2007, many Democrats and Republicans in Congress wanted to tackle immigration reform. They aimed to improve border security, create a path to citizenship for undocumented immigrants, and make changes to the legal immigration system. However, disagreements within both parties ultimately stopped the bill from moving forward. Some Republicans wanted a comprehensive plan that included all of the above, while others only wanted to boost border security. These Republicans wanted strict measures in place before even thinking about citizenship for undocumented immigrants. On the Democratic side, there were mixed feelings about how to handle guest worker programs and the undocumented immigrants already in the United States.

As they tried to find common ground, various compromises and amendments were proposed. One key amendment was introduced by Senator John Cornyn. This "Cornyn Amendment" focused heavily on border security, including more fencing along the US-Mexico border, more border patrol agents, and stricter checks on employers hiring undocumented workers. Some supporters of the original bill thought this amendment was too harsh and neglected other important parts of immigration reform.

The bill never made it to a vote in the Senate because there were not 60 votes to end the filibuster. On the Republican side, 12 voted in favor of ending debate (supporting the bill), while 37 voted against it. On the Democratic side, 34 voted in favor, while 16 voted against. Two independent Senators voted for it. This example shows the difficulty of balancing different party factions and priorities in a legislature. Nevertheless, more

legislation may pass due to the existence of the long coalitions organized as political parties.

Even without party labels, politicians would still form informal coalitions; the debate is over whether they would pass less legislation. More does not always mean better. In the fictitious example I used, I personally would prefer it if no one's proposal passed. If there were a compelling national emergency, the three quirky legislators might have worked together even without the long coalition. Is the consequence of more legislation under party control to serve the voters better, help politicians win reelection, or serve interest groups? Without parties, legislatures might pass fewer bills but be more thoughtful about what they pass.

Instead of messy, unpredictable alliances forming around each issue, parties in legislatures create a process where the majority decides what issues go to the floor for a vote and who gets to amend bills. This makes it easier to pass legislation when a party is united, but more difficult to compromise between parties or put forward a bill that divides the majority party.

When the Party System Obstructs Policymaking

Congressional partisans help each other pass legislation, but oppose the other party out of habit, cultivated animosity, and the need to deprive the opposition of electoral credit. With the three fictional characters above, Claire and John would never give Charlie anything he wants just because he's Charlie. According to congressional scholar Frances Lee, partisanship in Congress is more about keeping the majority—and thereby maintaining power—than ideology or genuine policy differences. She found that 44% of party-line votes have no ideological significance. If the obstruction were about ideology, then removing parties wouldn't change much. As she quotes an anonymous member of Congress, "In the minority, you are just looking for a reason to oppose what the majority supports."[6]

Lee argues that this tendency is particularly strong when both parties are closely matched in Congress and have a real shot at winning a congressional majority in the next election. As she artfully explains, "when control of national institutions hangs in the balance, no party wants to grant political legitimacy to its opposition by voting for the measures it champions. Instead, parties in a competitive environment will want to amplify the differences voters perceive between themselves and their opposition."[7] Each party tends to use tactics that they will later criticize when the roles

are reversed. For example, Senate Democrats criticized Republicans for refusing to vote for debt-limit increases during the Obama administration, but they rarely supported debt-limit increases when they were the minority during the Reagan administration.[8]

This is less pronounced in periods where one party consistently dominates a legislature. In such cases, the minority has little choice but to cooperate with the semi-permanent majority to achieve anything. In the 1980s, for example, the House was controlled by Democrats, the Senate by Republicans, and Ronald Reagan, a Republican, was in the White House. The Democrats were still something of a semi-permanent majority, reasonably confident of taking back the Senate, and the racial realignment between the parties was already well under way.

People today are nostalgic for the bipartisanship of this era. Facing a looming crisis in Social Security funding, both parties in Congress worked together to save the program. The reforms included raising the retirement age, increasing payroll taxes, and making Social Security benefits taxable for higher-income individuals. President Reagan, normally opposed to well-funded social welfare programs, later called this bipartisan effort his greatest domestic achievement. The National Minimum Drinking Age Act of 1984 was another bipartisan achievement. By incentivizing states to raise the drinking age to 21, the federal government reduced drunk driving fatalities among young people. Another major achievement was the Tax Reform Act of 1986. Both parties came together to eliminate numerous special interest tax breaks and lowered overall tax rates for individuals and businesses. The Immigration Reform and Control Act of 1986 implemented stricter penalties for employers who hired undocumented workers while providing amnesty to millions of undocumented immigrants already in the country. It's rare for any similar high-profile pieces of bipartisan legislation during a period of divided government today.

These examples from the 1980s illustrate that with a semi-permanent majority in one chamber, significant bipartisan accomplishments are possible. Unfortunately, we are now in the longest period of balanced competition in US history. Not even a global pandemic could bring them together.

Taking overt party signals out of the legislative deliberation is actually one of the few remaining options for passing bipartisan legislation. In 2016, Congress passed an ambitious overhaul of the 1976 Toxic Substances Control Act on a bipartisan vote. Chemical industry and

environmentalist group representatives supported more disclosure of information in exchange for a more uniform standard of regulation. One reason for the passage of the law was that President Obama did not take an explicit position.[9] Had such an obvious symbol of the Democratic Party tainted the bill by association, Republicans would have had a more difficult task defending support to their voters.

When you attach a label to a long-term coalition, it becomes easier and more rewarding for opponents to attack it. After these attacks, people from different parties are less likely to cooperate. Additionally, partisans tend to criticize the other party in front of their voters. It can be hard to go back to your voters and justify working with the other party after that. Multiparty systems might be more likely to pull their punches because parties often shift alliances to elect a prime minister. However, this is an unlikely option for the United States, which has a presidential government and single-member districts. Long coalitions help pass legislation, but majorities often support their members for the wrong reasons while excluding the minority even when they have valid points.

Administrations with Minimal Party Influence

Now that we've looked at whether parties are necessary for Congress to function, let's explore whether they are essential for the presidency. Political theorist Russell Muirhead sings the praises of modern political parties partly on presidential projects that depend on partisans for their enactment. Partisan zealotry leads a president's supporters to continue supporting a proposal even after early evidence of failure. He cites presidential initiatives like the Iraq War and the rollout of Obamacare as projects that nonpartisan voters might lose patience with and prematurely reverse course. According to Muirhead, parties create a set of voters invested in the continuation of policies across administrations. They also provide an easy way of identifying which politicians would support continuity or disruption in long-term policies.

Critics might argue that this is a flaw of political parties, rather than an asset. How many Republicans look back at the Iraq War and feel grateful for the partisanship that kept them committed to a failing policy? In 2016, Republican primary voters nominated a candidate who rejected the war and President Bush. Furthermore, one might argue that practical solutions inherently change with the times, and having a party with a lineage creates residual loyalty to outdated solutions. The New Deal was

responding to a different set of challenges than policymakers faced in the 1970s, but Jimmy Carter and other Democrats were not able to make a clean break from New Deal politics and policies because there were a set of institutions and interest groups anchored in them. According to presidential scholar Stephen Skowronek, this dynamic creates a problem for most presidents save for the ones who are inaugurated after following a wholesale rejection a previous era of politics.[10]

We can also investigate Muirhead's claims against the record of two presidential administrations that were at least partly free of political parties. Presidents George Washington and James Monroe managed to govern with minimal partisanship compared to any other administration since. During Washington's presidency, there were initially no political parties, and early politicians formed parties that they hoped had expiration dates. Later, during Monroe's presidency, the Federalist Party had dwindled to a small faction in New England and couldn't even nominate a candidate against Monroe in his reelection. With nearly everyone identifying as part of Jefferson's Republican Party, the federal government at this time operated more like a nonpartisan entity.

Some readers might reasonably ask how much we can learn from presidents from 200 years ago, given how dramatically the country has changed since then. The United States today is far more populous and diverse than it was in the early 1800s, and the administrative state is vastly more expansive. Nonetheless, the country was still the same in several ways that transcend any single era: separation of powers, staggered elections, and bicameralism. Even in the early republic, Congress and the president needed to manage national priorities, respond to crises, and balance ambition against cooperation. Washington and Monroe's accomplishments show that partisan support in Congress is not the only way to build coalitions for long-term projects. Without entrenched party rivalries, branches of government might disagree without becoming paralyzed, or compromise without betraying a team. Although this was a vastly different era, it's the only data we have for an executive branch without parties, and we have to use what little data we have rather than dismissing it because it was from a long time ago.

Early in Washington's administration, Alexander Hamilton's financial reforms, such as the assumption of state debts and the establishment of a National Bank, laid the groundwork for a stable economy and helped establish the young nation's creditworthiness. His initial proposals passed in Congress even before there were organized parties. Activists among

the voters were already spreading information about how members of Congress voted on Hamilton's plan. My dissertation advisor, John Zaller, liked to tell the story of the "Mad Hatter." A hatter from Pennsylvania rode 60 miles on his horse to urge people to vote against members of Congress who supported Hamilton's plan. Zaller considers this an early form of de facto party behavior, but I believe this was better than the two-party system that soon developed. The Mad Hatter focused on a small set of related issues, allowing people to make decisions without bundling unrelated issues into a package deal tied to a group identity. Even if voters rejected the candidates who supported Hamilton's plan, the absence of party identity made them less likely to reject all future proposals from Hamilton simply because they were from Hamilton.

While Federalists arguably had the better public policies, they struggled to win elections against the other party, the Republicans. As some historians depict the partisan conflict, Jefferson and Madison opposed Hamilton's pragmatic policies out of ideological rigidity and lingering animosity toward Britain. They even supported some of the same policies when they were in power. Years later, Madison wrote that "Republicans had been reconciled to measures like that which were 'proper now as they were premature and suspicious when urged by the champions of Federalists.'" The Jeffersonian Republicans exploited anti-British sentiments for partisan advantage. Then the Federalists became the party of ideological rigidity during John Adams' presidency, pushing taxes and political repression disconnected from practical realities.[11] Partisanship often led both sides to extremes and created backlash, a phenomenon that might have been less pronounced without political parties.

The Federalist Party eventually faded after threatening secession during the War of 1812. Republican President James Monroe defeated a nominal Federalist opponent in 1816 and ran unopposed in 1820. This era was termed the "Era of Good Feelings" by a Boston newspaper, suggesting a new sense of unity in the absence of fierce party competition. While societal divisions still existed, most people welcomed the relative calm after years of bitter Federalist-Republican rivalry.[12] More than his Republican predecessors, Monroe believed that the party embraced "all elements of American society" and should "adopt measures meeting the needs of the widest possible spectrum of American opinion," including the National Bank and tariffs once associated with the Federalist Party. Monroe didn't appoint any nominal Federalists to his cabinet to signal unity but passed over Southerners to appoint a nominal Republican, John Quincy Adams,

as Secretary of State. Monroe spent his first summer touring Northeastern states rather than retiring to Virginia. During his procession in Boston, partisan antagonists who had not spoken to one another in years joined at both private and public gatherings.[13]

To be sure, with fewer political enemies came fewer political friends. Without appeals to one's in-group and fear of one's out-group, it could be difficult to rally support for one's agenda. Members of Congress who might have felt allegiance in a real two-party system often were not afraid to openly disagree with the administration. While some may see this as a weakness, it actually encouraged more independent thinking. Members of Congress were fighting for the influence of Congress and not the influence of the president, and this was what the framers of the Constitution intended.[14]

The Monroe administration still achieved significant successes without political parties. For example, it acquired Florida from Spain in 1819 and established the Monroe Doctrine in 1823, warning European powers against further colonization in the Americas. These accomplishments showed that a government without strong party divisions could still be effective. House Speaker Henry Clay was personally offended when Monroe passed over him for Secretary of State but was never able to defeat a single measure proposed by the administration. Congress fought for its own prerogatives, but not to the point of inertia.

The country survived the many challenges and conflicts of the Era of Good Feelings. The Panic of 1819 marred the era, but it was caused by land speculation and changes in international trade, not party politics. The admission of Missouri as a slave state in 1820 threatened to make the slave states more powerful, portending the spread of slavery in the rest of the Louisiana territory. Many feared the dissolution of the union, but the crisis was resolved with a compromise credited with postponing the Civil War.[15] As part of the "Missouri Compromise," Maine was admitted as a free state and the rest of the Louisiana territory would be free.

Rather than being divided between Federalists and the Republicans, the country was mainly divided between Northern and Southern states. Federalists were unknown in most states, and the pitifully small number of Federalists in Congress were not enough to support the antislavery provisions of the compromise. Instead, support for the compromise came from Northern Republicans opposed to slavery's expansion and Southern Republicans who believed it would promote national unity. Northerners who supported the admission of Missouri and Southerners who supported

the antislavery provisions were less likely to be reelected, and they surely saw the danger. Even without a meaningful two-party system, pressure from House Speaker Henry Clay and the anti-partisan White House managed to discipline some members of Congress to set aside their own electoral interests for perceived national interests. Monroe himself largely remained silent on the issue, rightly recognizing that his own statements on the issue might drive moderates to more extreme positions in an effort to remain independent of the president. Monroe's discretion has echoes today in the Obama administration's quiet support of the Toxic Substances Control Act. Sometimes, restraint is the best kind of leadership. While Muirhead argues that parties help maintain long-term projects, these historical examples suggest that significant long-term policies can still occur without intense partisanship and maybe without partisanship at all.

In 1824, many Republicans challenged the congressional caucus' choice for the party nominee, which was then an openly elite process. Monroe despised political parties, calling them the "curse of the country." His successor, John Quincy Adams, aimed to "break up the [last] remnant of party distinction" and refused to appoint government offices based on loyalty to his administration. Adams' policy positions were more extreme than Monroe's in their alignment with the former Federalist Party's idea about ambitious national internal improvements. He was undermined at every turn by the primordial stirrings of what would become the Democratic Party. Adams steadfastly refused to use his appointment power to generate a class of political supporters, which was still possible even without formal parties.

Ultimately, the resurgence of political parties in 1828 not only failed to improve upon the Era of Good Feelings but also undermined genuine policy discourse. The new political parties suppressed the slavery issue and heralded a political discourse of buzzwords and empty slogans. One critic of the Era of Good Feelings, future President Martin Van Buren, urged the formation of parties largely so that party conflict would replace regional conflict. In a famous letter to a Southern publisher, he wrote that "we must always have party distinctions" to "rouse the sluggish to exertion…and prevent that apathy that has proved the ruin of republics." Van Buren complained that without parties, people relied on even more superficial cues, such as region. If the old party feelings are "suppressed, geographic divisions founded on local interests or, what is worse, prejudices between free and slaveholding states will inevitably take their

place. Party attachment in former times furnished a complete antidote for sectional prejudices." Van Buren assumed that suppressing the slavery issue in favor of national party battles was a worthy trade-off. This raises troubling questions about what kinds of conflict party systems actually resolve and, perhaps more importantly, what they avoid resolving.

Van Buren also argued that nonpartisanship encouraged the kind of demagoguery that the founders sought to avoid. A new party system would help avoid presidential selection by Congress, which he believed would be factional. Furthermore, elections with parties would center around the "fair and open contest for the establishment of principles in the administration of government" rather than the personal ambitions of candidates. Yet, there were substantive differences between the presidential candidates in 1824, the last campaign without formal party competition. Much of the support was regional, but there was significant variation within and across the regions. For example, Henry Clay and John Quincy Adams were from different regions, yet both advocated for federal government involvement in transportation projects, a National Bank, and protective tariffs. William Crawford, supported by most of the Republican Party luminaries, favored a continuation of the original principles of the party. It was the future candidates of Van Buren's Democratic Party, like Andrew Jackson and John C. Calhoun, that wavered the most. Calhoun came to waffle between nationalism and sectionalism and ultimately helped enshrine the protection of slavery as part of the party's agenda.

Van Buren dismissed the issues of the 1824 campaign as "shuttlecocks" seized by candidates long before elections. Yet he later wound up using a candidate with few principles but outsized ambition as the figurehead of the Democratic Party. Andrew Jackson had the least developed views of any of the candidates and continued to be evasive in 1828, when he won. As two authors write about the partisan mythmaking of Andrew Jackson:

> The broader acceptance of outright politicking in the 1820s disclosed a major shift in attitudes about the proper methods of winning elections…They made [Jackson] the friend of debtors (he dismissed them as deadbeats), the advocate for low tariffs or high ones (he had no opinion on the matter), and the enemy of grasping bankers (who were some of his best friends). He was made an icon in the tradition of George Washington, though he had been among those most critical of Washington at the end of his presidency. Jackson was made the ideological heir of Thomas Jefferson,

> though he openly opposed President Jefferson, and the Sage of Monticello himself was openly dismayed by Jackson's rising popularity.[16]

The Democrats—and later the Whigs—replaced the substantive debates of 1824 with a cult of personality around candidates like Jackson and later William Henry Harrison. Campaigns were abundant with empty slogans like "Tippecanoe and Tyler Too," symbols like hickory sticks, and downright misleading images like using log cabins and hard cider to represent candidates born with silver spoons in their mouths. This reintroduction of parties did not represent an improvement over the Era of Good Feelings; rather, it marked a shift toward superficial politics and personal ambition over genuine policy discussion.

The point is not to return to the days of Washington and Monroe, which isn't an option for us today. The patriotic unity that characterized the American Revolution and the War of 1812 was a product of a very different era, one where the country was far less diverse than it is now (although it seemed religiously and ethnically diverse to the founders at the time). What we can take away from the Washington and Monroe administrations is a reminder that it is possible, even in the absence of political parties, for presidents to pursue farsighted projects and possible for legislatures to pass important legislation. Significant policy achievements, such as Hamilton's financial reforms and the Monroe Doctrine, shaped the nation's trajectory and foreign policy. Moreover, these early periods demonstrate how branches of government might more appropriately guard their prerogatives without the influence of political parties.

The subsequent emergence of political parties introduced a new dynamic marked by ideological rigidity, superficial politics, and personal ambition. All of this casts doubt on Martin Van Buren's case for political parties. Party competition replaced regional competition over slavery for a time, but temporarily suppressing the slavery issue is not a cause for celebration. Ultimately, the resurgence of political parties undermined genuine policy discourse and heralded an era of political superficiality.

The Confederate States of America

During the Civil War, party competition in the Confederate States of America was even more sparse than it had been in the Washington and Monroe administrations, while Democrats and Republicans continued

to compete in the Union. The written constitution of the Confederacy mirrored that of the Union, but had a greater emphasis on states' rights. Many individuals who held national government positions prior to secession continued their service in the central government of the Confederacy. Comparing the Union and the Confederacy thus provides an interesting comparison between systems: one with robust party dynamics and the other with no party competition to speak of. Despite the numerous differences between the Confederacy and modern times, limited data on party-free government requires us to investigate the history.

Historian Eric McKitrick[17] is one of the few political scientists who has delved into how the lack of political parties affected the Confederacy's governance and operational effectiveness. According to McKitrick, the absence of party competition hampered the Confederacy's political stability and administrative efficiency. President Jefferson Davis was elected unanimously because Confederates believed that the appearance of horse-trading would undermine confidence in the new government. We know little about the convention that selected him. But with no opposition, Davis had less information than Abraham Lincoln about supporters and opponents and which interests needed to be balanced, leading to unstable appointments. Parties would have helped Davis assess which officials were liabilities.

For example, Vice President Alexander Stephens was a critic of secession chosen to appeal to members of the defunct Whig party. Stephens stayed in his home state of Georgia, vocally criticizing the Confederacy in general and Davis in particular. McKitrick believes that organized political parties would have kept Stephens vested in the party's success. The absence of a party system also influenced the behavior of other Confederate officials. Secretary of State Robert Toombs, disgruntled over not receiving his desired appointment, left the administration to join the army and later the legislature. McKitrick argues that a disciplined party system might have led to better appointments and fewer disruptions in Davis's policies. Abraham Lincoln, operating in a two-party system, easily replaced his first Vice President, Hannibal Hamlin, with Andrew Johnson during his reelection. Hamlin's party loyalty ensured that he left the administration without a fuss and eventually was rewarded with a plum patronage position.

Further illustrating the consequences of the lack of parties, McKitrick points to the behavior of Confederate state governments. Many states were reluctant to contribute fully to the Confederate war effort, with

some governors obstructing the draft or asserting state control over their own military personnel. State governments also resisted Davis's efforts to institute martial law. As McKitrick writes, Georgia Governor Joseph Brown saw "Davis's efforts to mobilize the total resources of the Confederacy" as a threat just as dangerous as the Union army.[18] In contrast, Lincoln's Republican coalition provided him with a network of advocates who supported even his most questionable policies. Democratic governors in the Union, such as New York's Horatio Seymour, were less able to hinder the war effort due to careful vigilance by an organized opposition party.

Besides the absence of political parties, other major differences muddy McKitrick's attempt to blame Confederate ineffectiveness on the absence of parties. First, a significant portion of the Confederate male population consisted of disenfranchised slaves. Obviously, clearer alternatives to Davis's policies would have emerged from a population of universal manhood suffrage, with or without parties. This issue of suffrage is distinct from the question of political parties per se. Second, the Confederacy's state governments held more authority to resist centralized control compared to their Union counterparts. This was more of an issue with the greater degree of states' rights in the South compared with the North than of the absence of parties. Finally, the unanimous election of Davis, and the problems this created, was more a reflection of the challenges inherent in establishing a new government than a direct result of the lack of political parties.

One might argue that some of the resistance to Davis's authority was what one should expect from a system of separation of powers. Designing a government for unity during a war can have negative consequences for that government during the more frequent times of peace. The Vice President's criticism of secession was warranted, as was state resistance to martial law. In the Union, Lincoln's imposition of martial law has been questioned ever since. The failure of fellow partisans to criticize a president has led to famous blunders like the Bay of Pigs invasion and the Iraq War, now used as case studies in groupthink. In a system designed to check and balance power, it is preferable for one branch of government to jealously guard its power rather than overlook it to cooperate with a president of the same party. Even so, Lincoln also struggled with subordinates who were recalcitrant, headstrong, and overly ambitious, such as George McClellan, Edwin Stanton, and Salmon Chase. Washington and

Monroe had more respect from their cabinet, suggesting that the issue was challenging nature of the Civil War rather than absence of parties.

We also know very little about elections to the first Confederate Congress, except that they were characterized by apathy.[19] There were many differences of opinion with regard to support for Davis's policies of taxation and wartime emergencies. As problems mounted in the Confederacy, more candidates criticized Davis in the 1863 elections, but without parties, the candidates were disorganized and failed to offer coherent alternatives or policies. By the end of the war, a coalition supported negotiating peace with the Union. Although they were not a formal party, they overlapped with the politicians who had been Whigs before the Civil War.[20] A different study finds that members of the Confederate Congress lacked ideological stability, even among members who were ideologically consistent when they previously served in the US Congress. However, ideological stability in the Confederate Congress improved over time, and members whose districts were occupied by Union forces consistently voted for more centralized power. Thus, parties aided in the contribution of ideological stability but were not the only factor.[21] Furthermore, maybe politicians should have unstable issue positions in times where they are rapidly adapting to new circumstances.

In conclusion, the Confederacy's challenges weren't mainly due to the absence of political parties. The Confederacy faced additional issues like widespread disenfranchisement, strong states' rights, and the difficulties of forming a new government during wartime. On top of these obstacles, the freedom with which critics expressed their views about Davis could be seen positively, as it reflected a system valuing open discussion and resistance to excessive executive power. The changes in the Confederate Congress show that while parties offer structure and stability, their absence allowed for more varied political opinions and adaptability.

The Locked Cabinet

Stacking a cabinet from one party increases the risk of groupthink. Groupthink is when a group of people makes a decision that everyone goes along with, even if some people in the group secretly think it's a bad idea. This happens because people don't want to rock the boat or cause conflict, so they keep their doubts to themselves. Imagine you're working on a group project, and everyone seems excited about one idea, but you think it might not work. Instead of speaking up, you stay quiet

because you don't want to seem like you're not a team player or because you're worried the group might get upset. This can lead to poor decisions because the group is missing out on important perspectives and information that could prevent mistakes.

Presidential advisors inherently lean toward groupthink because the majesty of the office itself can intimidate advisors into conformity. Additionally, advisors know that their status and influence with the administration depend on maintaining the president's favor. The risk of groupthink increases when parties encourage presidents to surround themselves with like-minded individuals, leading to decisions that may not fully consider alternative perspectives or potential consequences.

The Vietnam War is a classic example of groupthink within the Johnson administration. Under President Lyndon B. Johnson, the president's advisors were largely unified in their belief that escalating the US military presence in Vietnam was necessary to prevent the spread of communism in Southeast Asia. Johnson's advisors were reluctant to question the prevailing strategy. The Vietnam War became a quagmire partly because of the administration's failure to critically reassess its purpose and its strategy. As presidential scholar George Edwards has written, "Since they could not bring themselves to consider seriously the option of pulling out of the war, they could not reassess their policy. As a result, no comprehensive and systematic examination of Vietnam's importance to the United States was ever undertaken within the executive branch. Debates revolved around how to do things better and whether they could be done, not whether they were worth doing."[22] The result was the first war America lost, which could have been avoided with less unity.

Influential figures in the George W. Bush administration, all from the same party, reinforced each other's belief that Iraq possessed weapons of mass destruction (WMDs) and posed a significant threat. This consensus was maintained despite conflicting evidence and a lack of similar evidence from other countries. The Bush administration's inner circle dismissed or downplayed dissenting opinions, creating an echo chamber that propelled the United States into a protracted and controversial conflict. They were convinced Iraq had WMD because it would not resist weapons inspections if it had nothing to hide. Because they shared a similar mindset, they did not consider the possibility that Saddam Hussein was simply trying to look tough to maintain appearances with Iraq's neighbors.

In a hypothetical nonpartisan system, the issue of groupthink could be mitigated because presidents would face more challenges finding and

appointing advisors who all share the same viewpoint. The absence of formal party divisions in 1789 allowed Washington to appoint both Alexander Hamilton and Thomas Jefferson to his cabinet. These two men held drastically different views on key issues, such as the role of the federal government and economic policy. In 1817, the lack of meaningful partisan divides meant that Monroe could focus on Secretary of State John Quincy Adams' qualifications and experience rather than his former allegiance to the Federalist Party, resulting in a diversity of views without sacrificing productivity. Jefferson Davis had fewer opportunities to align his administration under a single-party ideology, which resulted in a cabinet and government officials who were often at odds with each other. While McKitrick called this a drawback, it is what we need more of in at least some presidential administrations. The lack of rigorous debate and the suppression of alternative viewpoints contributed to some of the most contentious foreign policy decisions in recent history.

Conclusion

The negative impact of parties on voter deliberation and democratic norms weighs heavily against the existence of political parties. One counterargument is that parties are essential for the government to function effectively. However, this chapter has shown that, at best, parties help legislatures pass more legislation, not necessarily better legislation. At worst, parties often dismiss proposals from the opposing party in Congress, leading to gridlock and partisanship. The policies passed during the nonpartisan periods of the Washington and Monroe administrations, like them or not, focused on long-term benefits. Early administrations show that coordination between branches is possible even without formal parties, and branches were still more likely to look out for their institutional prerogatives. When later presidents were surrounded by appointees of the same party, it often led to groupthink. So, while parties provide some structure to government, the advantages of parties in government do not make up for previous disadvantages discussed in earlier chapters.

Notes

1. Krehbiel, K. (1998) *Pivotal Politics: A Theory of U.S. Lawmaking*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press; Cameron, C., Howell, W. and Adler, S. (1997) Toward an understanding of the institutional performance of Congress in the post-war era: Structural explanations for surges and slumps in the production of significant legislation, 1945–1994. Paper presented at the annual meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, Chicago; Chiou, F.-Y. and Rothenberg, L.S. (2008) Comparing legislators and legislatures: The dynamics of legislative gridlock reconsidered. *Political Analysis* 16(2): 197–212.
2. Mayhew, D.R. (2005) *Divided We Govern: Party Control, Lawmaking, and Investigations, 1946–2002*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
3. Binder, S.A. (1999) The dynamics of legislative gridlock, 1947–96. *American Political Science Review* 93(3): 519–533; Howell, W., Adler, S., Cameron, C. and Riemann, C. (2000) Divided government and the legislative productivity of Congress, 1945–94. *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 25(2): 285–312.
4. Aldrich, J.H. (1995) *Why Parties? The Origin and Transformation of Political Parties in America*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
5. Theriault, S.M., 2008. *Party Polarization in Congress*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
6. Lee, F.E. (2009) *Beyond Ideology: Politics, Principles, and Partisanship in the U.S. Senate*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, p. 65.
7. Lee, F.E. (2014) American politics is more competitive than ever. That's making partisanship worse. *The Washington Post*, 9 January. Available at: https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/monkey-cage/wp/2014/01/09/american-politics-is-more-competitive-than-ever-thats-making-partisanship-worse/
8. Lee, F.E. (2016) *Insecure Majorities: Congress and the Perpetual Campaign*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, p. 88.

9. Eilperin, J. and Fears, D. (2016) Congress is overhauling an outdated law that affects nearly every product you own. *The Washington Post*, 19 May. Available at: https://www.washingtonpost.com/news/energy-environment/wp/2016/05/19/congress-is-overhauling-an-outdated-law-that-affects-nearly-every-product-you-own/
10. Skowronek, S., 1993. *The Politics Presidents Make: Leadership from John Adams to George Bush*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
11. Elkins, S. and McKitrick, E. (1995) *The Age of Federalism*. New York: Oxford University Press.
12. Wood, G.S. (1991) *The Radicalism of the American Revolution*. New York: Vintage Books, p. 298.
13. Ammon, H. (1971) *James Monroe: The Quest for National Identity*. New York: McGraw-Hill Book Company, pp. 366–379.
14. Ammon, H. (1971) *James Monroe: The Quest for National Identity*. New York: McGraw-Hill Book Company, pp. 380–385.
15. Postponing the Civil War probably worked in favor of the Northern states as they had time to become an industrial power that could defeat the South militarily.
16. Heidler, D.S. and Heidler, J.T. (2018) *The Rise of Andrew Jackson: Myth, Manipulation, and the Making of Modern Politics*. New York: Basic Books.
17. McKitrick, E. (1975) Party politics and the Union and Confederate war efforts. *In*: Chambers, W.N., Burnham, W.D. and Sorauf, F.J. (eds.) *The American Party Systems: Stages of Political Development*. New York: Oxford University Press.
18. McKitrick, E. (1975) Party politics and the Union and Confederate war efforts. *In*: Chambers, W.N., Burnham, W.D. and Sorauf, F.J. (eds.) *The American Party Systems: Stages of Political Development*. New York: Oxford University Press, p. 143.
19. McKitrick, E. (1975) Party politics and the Union and Confederate war efforts. *In*: Chambers, W.N., Burnham, W.D. and Sorauf, F.J. (eds.) *The American Party Systems: Stages of Political Development*. New York: Oxford University Press, p. 149.

20. Beringer, R.E. (1972) The unconscious "spirit of party" in the Confederate Congress. *Civil War History* 18(4): 312–333.
21. Jenkins, J.A. (1999) Examining the bonding effects of party: A comparative analysis of roll-call voting in the US and Confederate Houses. *American Journal of Political Science* 43(4): 1144–1165.
22. Edwards, G.C. III and Wayne, S.J. (2019) *Presidential Leadership: Politics and Policy Making*. 9th ed. Boston, MA: Wadsworth Publishing.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 9

State and Local Governments Without Parties

Abstract By comparing partisan and nonpartisan legislatures at the state and local levels, this chapter shows that effective state and local governance is possible and maybe even better under a nonpartisan system. In Nebraska, currently the only state legislature without parties, lawmakers show greater collegiality and satisfaction with their jobs. However, the historical example of the one-party South offers one of the strongest cautionary tales in the book. In this case, partisan entrenchment produced state legislatures more conservative than their electorates.

Keywords City managers · Cross-filing · Ideology · Jim Crow · Local elections · Mayors · Nonpartisan elections · One-party systems · State legislatures · Voter turnout · The white South

In this chapter, we will compare nonpartisan state and local governments with their partisan counterparts. Unlike national politics, where political parties are everywhere, many local governments (and some state governments) have had either nonpartisan elections or no meaningful party competition. Scholars have examined these elections to understand how the absence of party labels affects voter turnout and policy decisions. I will mention the study authors in text to emphasize how vast the literature is and how wildly the outcomes vary. A solid body of research finds that nonpartisan elections lead to lower voter turnout, but they find only

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_9

minor differences in policy outcomes. This challenges the common belief that political parties are necessary for governments to function, which is how many people justify parties in spite of their negative consequences for voters.

Evidence from Local Governments

Around 70% of local elections in the United States don't have official party affiliations, giving us some perspective on how well the government can function without parties. Classic studies argue that the lessons of local government are not applicable to other kinds of government. Since state laws limited what local governments could do, political scientists once believed that local governments had too many policy constraints for partisanship to matter.[1] Local issues were also thought to be more problem-oriented than ideology-oriented; as one old study quipped, there is "no Republican way to pave a street and no Democratic way to lay a sewer."[2] Additionally, many voters can readily vote with their feet by moving somewhere else if they don't like local policies, rather than trying to change local government.

Other research shows that ideology can shape local politics and that local opinion often influences policy decisions. Whether having party labels on the ballot matters for the differences in policy outcomes is a separate question. The bottom line: for every study showing an impact of partisan or nonpartisan elections, there's another that finds no significant difference.

Most studies find that nonpartisan elections are associated with lower voter turnout. For instance, Schaffner, Streb, and Wright found that nonpartisan elections can reduce turnout by about eight percent.[3] Without the party label shortcut to guide them, voters might struggle to make informed decisions, especially if they don't have the time or resources to dig into each candidate's platform (for more on this argument, see Chapter 1). Political parties sponsor grassroots organizing and campaign ads that boost turnout and clarify elections for voters. They can recruit candidates and tell voters when the elections are being held.

Lower voter turnout has other consequences besides less of a connection between voters and their governments. Some perspectives are typically less well-represented among the voters who do turn out. At times, scholars argue that reduced local election turnout could benefit higher-income groups[4] and Republicans.[5] Not all research supports this view.

Welch and Bledsoe found that in larger or lower-income cities, nonpartisan elections don't benefit higher-income groups and may even favor Democrats in wealthier areas.[6] Along with Schaffner et al., Anzia[7] and Kogan et al.[8] observed that special interests like public employee unions can become more influential when turnout is low. The marginal voter is the one who might turn out in a high turnout election but not in a low turnout election. As we showed in Chapter 2, marginal voters are less educated, and less educated voters have been more likely to vote Republican in recent years.

In cities with unelected, nonpartisan city managers instead of mayors, interest groups often wield less influence.[9] Those who value public policy that acts in the interest of the people according to some objective measure (like local economic growth or low crime) may differ from small-d democrats who value public policy that either replicates public opinion or pluralists who focus on a compromise between diverse groups. If people want more multifamily housing but fail to understand how zoning works, they may unintentionally elect mayors or parties opposed to zoning reform. A city manager who understands the relationship may be more likely to deliver the results people want rather than the policies they think they want.

When voters make decisions without party cues, they might rely on other indicators like race and ethnicity, which predict policy preferences even less accurately as party affiliation.[10] Newer studies suggest that removing party labels can actually boost the chances of minority party candidates.[11] Studies on partisan mayors reveal mixed results. Kessner and Warshaw[12] found that Democratic mayors tend to spend and borrow more, and Einstein and Glick[13] find that they redistribute money more. Since Democratic mayors are aligning with national Democratic Party economic perspectives, party labels might be helping voters understand local fiscal policies. On the other hand, Gerber and Hopkins discovered that while Democratic mayors spend less on police and fire services, there aren't major differences in other policy areas.[14]

In a study of 151 cities, Bucchianeri concludes that parties help to structure debates among local government officials, fostering stable alliances and therefore facilitating collaboration.[15] But—you guessed it—other studies show that nonpartisan city governments can be more efficient in decision-making and governance because they reduce political polarization and promote consensus-building. For example, Meier and O'Toole Jr. argue that nonpartisan city governments may experience less

gridlock and fewer delays in policy implementation compared to partisan counterparts.[16] Bucchianeri mentions that parties provide structure by suppressing issues that divide a party, but obviously that disenfranchises voters who invested in the suppressed issues.

While some studies highlight the influence of parties on decision-making in local governments, competing studies show that elitism prevails under any system. Still more studies stress that partisanship leads to ideological rigidity and the nomination of candidates whose opinions are much more extreme than local public opinion. Research by Erie[17] and Trounstine and Valdini[18] shows that political elites adapt their strategies so that both traditional political machines and cities with Progressive Era reforms can fail to represent marginalized communities. From politics at the national level, we also know that political systems with stable alliances run the risk of being rigid alliances. Broockman et al. show that local party leaders tend to nominate extreme candidates, with Democratic leaders overestimating public liberalism and Republican leaders overestimating public conservatism even more.[19]

In one of the largest quantitative analyses of city governments and their responsiveness to local opinion, Warshaw and Tausonavitch discovered that there are only small differences in the policy outcomes regardless of how city politics are structured. It matters little whether local governments have elected mayors, term limits, initiatives, and most importantly for our purposes, partisan elections. One conclusion they draw is that local elections are as ideological as other elections even without the party labels. Essentially, liberal cities continue to implement liberal policies while conservative cities stick to conservative policies, no matter what kind of election system or government structure they have.[20] Burnett finds that voters can find out how a candidate aligns with the parties even when there is no label.[21]

In summary, studies on partisan and nonpartisan cities have conflicting findings on the importance of parties in local elections. If there is no evidence or conflicting evidence that partisanship makes for good local policies, the case for political parties will have to rest on some other factor. The largest studies find that cities reflect their populations' political leanings rather than the effects of party labels on the ballot. One's evaluation of the importance of parties might depend on how much one values voter turnout even when policy outcomes are the same. While nonpartisan elections do not save us from the problems of ideological reasoning, they also do not interfere substantially with representative government. As a point

in favor of local partisan elections, it might be that voters can figure out local politics because they get some ideas about government from national politics with the help of party labels. If so, parties may be helpful after all.

Evidence Across the States

By examining both the impact of party control in state governments, we gain a fuller picture of how essential political parties truly are at representing voter interests and shaping policy outcomes at different levels of government. We can then assess whether parties in government are as essential as party scholars often suppose.

In *The Inevitable Party,* Seth Masket argues that polarized state parties give voters a binary choice, allowing them to clarify which candidates align with their personal beliefs and values. Wisconsin Republicans worked to weaken public employee unions. Colorado Democrats pushed for handgun restrictions. Texas Republicans moved to close abortion clinics. According to Masket, this kind of polarization means voting decisions have a greater impact, as the outcomes are more likely to reflect the winning party's values and priorities.[22]

While state parties may offer clear choices, they are often choices that large pluralities of their electorate do not want. Consider abortion. Even in conservative states, a significant plurality of voters support access to abortion under certain circumstances. In 2022, voters in Kentucky and Kansas upheld abortion rights in referendums against the wishes of state Republicans. On the other hand, even in blue states, voters typically do not support unrestricted abortion in all circumstances, but Democratic state legislatures protect them in all circumstances. Nebraska, a conservative state with a nonpartisan legislature, passed abortion laws that more accurately reflect public opinion than most states, allowing abortion up until the 12th week of pregnancy. This middle-ground position might have been harder to achieve in a state legislature that openly used party labels. Referendums, a tool developed by Progressive Era reformers as a workaround to political parties, have moderated abortion policies in states where partisan legislatures would have adopted more extreme policies than voters wanted.

Similarly, public opinion in Wisconsin was deeply divided during the 2011 collective bargaining dispute in which collective bargaining was abolished for many public employees. Polling revealed that the public's view depended heavily on how the questions were framed. When

the collective bargaining reforms were presented as a budget-balancing measure, support for Governor Scott Walker's position increased. However, when the issue was focused solely on collective bargaining rights, support shifted toward the unions.[23] Walker survived a recall attempt but the polling supported collective bargaining.

Finally, same-sex marriage was often legalized by judges rather than enacted into law by partisan legislatures. This highlights the importance of checks and balances more than partisanship. Judges are socialized into making decisions on the basis of good law, though of course they are not immune to partisan pressures. Some Republican Supreme Court appointees and some Republicans in state legislatures supported same-sex marriage.

Even without strong party influence, state legislatures often reflect the local values of their populations. The effect of party control of state government has increased in recent decades, but the effects are still modest compared to the overall policy differences across the states. From the 1930s to the 1980s, Republican governors were sometimes associated with more liberal policies than their Democratic counterparts. Recently, as the ideological gap between party candidates and their voters has grown, the impact of party control on state policy has become more noticeable. Even with this shift, the election of a Democratic governor over a Republican one only slightly increases monthly welfare payments by $1–$2 per recipient and raises the proportion of liberal policy options by just half a percentage point. How much party control affects state policies really depends on how far party candidates' views are from what the public actually thinks. A switch in party control doesn't have a huge impact; it has about one-tenth of the typical differences we see between states. In other words, even though Democrats and Republicans disagree a lot, these differences don't always lead to major changes in policy. So, the actual effect of party control on state policies isn't as dramatic as you might expect.[24]

The one-party South is a unique case study in which we can investigate the effects of the absence of competing parties in a region. From the end of Reconstruction to the 1960s, the Democrats controlled nearly every branch of government in every state in the South, making it a prime example of what happens when there's no meaningful party competition. In theory, having just one party should be similar to having no parties at all when it comes to policy outcomes. Since the black population in the South was largely disenfranchised, we should not expect Southern states

to have policies that took into account all of their citizens. But the question relevant to today is whether the absence of parties mattered for the white population that could vote.

Traditionally, scholars have argued that Southern lawmakers were less attuned to their constituents' needs, including their white constituents. For instance, Domhoff and Webber argue that the small electorate led to politicians who catered mainly to planter interests, blocking broader programs that might have challenged white supremacy.[25] V.O. Key also argued that without the party label shortcut, white voters had difficulty distinguishing between candidates and holding politicians accountable. This lack of party competition made it challenging for reformers to rally voters around change, benefiting economic elites who could leverage favors and local politics to win elections. Moreover, the seniority system in Congress allowed Southern incumbents to become powerful committee chairs at the national level, extracting concessions from a national party that was becoming increasingly racially liberal.[26]

However, Devin Caughey's book, *The Unsolid South,* casts doubt on much of this research. Caughey argues that Southern politics could be better understood through a "white polyarchy" model. While Southern politics were authoritarian in excluding African Americans, the absence of party competition didn't necessarily disrupt the connection between white voters and their representatives. Southern members of Congress, despite being conservative on civil rights issues, had diverse views on economic issues. For example, when Southern constituents supported New Deal programs in the 1930s, their representatives generally did as well. Conversely, when post-World War II sentiment shifted toward skepticism of economic liberalism, representatives adapted to that as well. From 1931 to 1958, no Southern member of Congress was more conservative on economic issues than the median member of Congress nationwide. This indicates that Southern representatives were not unusually unrepresentative compared to their counterparts elsewhere in the country.[27]

Caughey argues that Southern states represented white constituents well in part because there were visible national parties. Southern voters were able to determine how their own members of Congress stood relative to members of Congress from other regions, particularly whether their own members supported the New Deal or not. Southern state legislatures, which also lacked parties, were uniformly more conservative than the white voters they represented. Therefore, national representation in

the South could work without parties because the South was "free riding" off of party competition in other regions.

This section offers important research into the question of whether "democracy is unthinkable save in terms of party" as Schattschneider claimed. Caughey's research into the one-party South reveals that, even in a region dominated by a single party, Southern representatives were not out of touch with their constituents; the problem was that the constituency was (unconstitutionally) restricted. Despite the authoritarian nature of Southern politics and the exclusion of African Americans, Caughey finds that Southern Congress members responded to the economic opinions of their voters.

However, Caughey's findings also suggest that the presence of national parties provided an important benchmark for evaluating congressional candidates in one-party elections. While nonpartisan institutions can function under certain conditions, they may also depend on the national party competition they try to avoid at the state level. This consideration complicates any conclusion that parties-in-government are not necessary for representation. Still, voters might have made informed choices if nonpartisan leaders had publicly championed a coherent agenda akin to the New Deal or Contract with America. Such agendas could have informed voters about important issues without triggering the entrenched group loyalties associated with partisan politics.

Individual States

A closer look at individual cases of states without parties helps reveal whether parties are necessary for legislatures to function.

Nebraska

Nebraska is currently the only state with a completely nonpartisan legislature. This means that in Nebraska, you won't see party labels on the ballot at all or partisan designations in the unicameral state legislature. Nebraska's system was enacted after a 1934 referendum and has remained a focal point for people who question the need for political parties. Critics of traditional party systems often point to Nebraska as a model for how governance might function without party affiliations. So, let's take a closer look at how Nebraska compares to other states.

Wright and Schaffner compared Nebraska to Kansas, a state with similar demographics but clear party affiliations. They found that Kansas was much more polarized than Nebraska.[28] Masket's interviews with Nebraska legislators showed that they were happy with the nonpartisan system. Even though they don't have party labels on their ballots, these legislators go out of their way to work together and keep partisanship in check. Nebraska has become more polarized recently and parties matter even though they are not on the ballot. The media still highlights candidates' party leanings, and both parties and interest groups remain active in recruitment efforts.

As with local government, supporters of political parties argue that it is harder for voters to gauge where representatives stand on key issues. Wright and Schaffner point out that this lack of transparency can make it tough for voters to hold their representatives accountable. If voters can't easily see how their representatives align on issues, it can undermine the basic idea of representative democracy. Without strong party competition, there might also be less incentive for legislators to stay responsive to their constituents. There are fewer contested elections, so legislators may be less accountable to public opinion. Nonpartisan elections could therefore lead to lower voter turnout and make it easier for incumbents to stay in power without facing real competition.

On the flip side, Nebraska's nonpartisan legislature allows for more flexible alliances. This flexibility can lead to more cooperation and compromise, potentially resulting in more effective governance. Over time, the polarization of other state legislatures eventually caught up with Nebraska. But the point of public policy is not always to eliminate a problem; sometimes it is enough to produce friction. People still consume addictive substances even when they are illegal, but laws against them make them more difficult to obtain. Formal nonpartisanship might create friction for hyperpartisanship. If hyperpartisanship is undesirable, a reform that delays hyperpartisanship is a successful reform.

Case Studies in Nonpartisan Reform: California and Minnesota

California and Minnesota also tried out nonpartisan systems at different points in history. California had "cross-filing" from 1909 to 1957. This allowed candidates to run in any primary regardless of their political party. The idea was to reduce the power of corrupt party bosses and make elections more about candidates than party politics. During this

period, political parties didn't have much influence over what laws actually got passed and elections often came down to personal familiarity with candidates rather than ideology.

Scholars usually pan the results of the California experiment. New regional divides, like north-south and urban-rural splits, became more pronounced without the unifying influence of parties. Some research finds that legislation had a conservative and upper-class bias. Cross-filing gave incumbents a significant advantage, raising concerns about democratic accountability. Worst of all, special interest groups sometimes filled the void. The powerful liquor lobby, led by Artie Samish, had a significant impact on campaigns, financing, and candidate selection. Labor unions, frustrated by their limited successes during this time, played a role in ending the nonpartisan elections in 1957.[29]

However, blaming all the issues of this period solely on the absence of political parties would be too simplistic. Many states with strong parties, like Illinois, also had abnormally high levels of corruption and government favoritism. Factors like low salaries for California legislators also played a role in the influence of special interests. In environments where incumbents consistently secure reelection, like nonpartisan state legislatures, there's potential for increased stability and continuity in governance. Long-serving legislators in such environments often develop deep knowledge of policy issues and strong connections within their communities, acting as a counterbalance to the influence of lobbyists and special interest groups. This can foster a greater degree of independence among lawmakers, allowing them to prioritize the needs of their constituents over the demands of parties or interest groups. As the UCLA Theory of Parties notes, groups like the liquor lobby can sometimes become part of a party coalition, continuing their influence over the legislature but masking their influence as part of a broad party movement. Instead of counteracting the influence of interest groups, parties can sometimes make it harder to see who is really driving the agenda.

Minnesota also experimented with nonpartisan politics in 1913. By the late 1930s, coalitions resembling political parties fought in the legislature despite the formal absence of parties. Masket shows that when Minnesota reintroduced partisan elections in 1975, the increase in polarization was relatively minor. Minnesota's experience suggests that formal parties made little difference to how politics functioned on the ground.

While Nebraska may no longer be better than other states, it's also hard to find evidence that it is worse off. California and Minnesota had their

issues, but they were not wildly ineffective or unrepresentative. Political parties are not strictly required for sound public policy, but some studies do fault nonpartisan governments for not representing the voters well.

Which system is better or worse depends on what you value more: the flexibility and cooperation that come with nonpartisan systems or the higher turnout and clearer choices provided by party labels. But as said in an earlier chapter, the party shortcut saves more time for rigid partisans than moderates or cross-pressured voters.

Conclusion

We're still figuring out the impact of nonpartisan systems in state and local governments. The results are far from consistent. Caughey's evidence on Southern state legislatures is admittedly troubling for advocates of nonpartisanship across-the-board, showing that one-party environments only work when informed by the signals that national parties provide. Most studies also show modestly lower voter turnout in nonpartisan elections; readers may differ on how important this is relative to polarization and gridlock. On the other side, lawmakers often work together more amiably in Nebraska's nonpartisan legislature. As in the previous chapter, the evidence surrounding parties-in-government is too mixed to justify a clear endorsement of political parties. In my opinion, a more definitive case is needed to counteract the disadvantages of parties discussed in the first two sections of the book.

Notes

1. Ferreira, F., Gyourko, J. and Tracy, J. (2010) Housing busts and household mobility. *Journal of Urban Economics* 68(1): 34–45.
2. Adrian, C.R. (1952) Some general characteristics of nonpartisan elections. *American Political Science Review* 46(3): 766.
3. Schaffner, B.F., Streb, M. and Wright, G. (2001) Teams without uniforms: The nonpartisan ballot in state and local elections. *Political Research Quarterly* 54(1): 7–30.
4. Karnig, A.K. and Walter, B.O. (1983) Decline in municipal voter turnout: A function of changing structure. *American Politics Quarterly* 11(4): 491–505.

5. Lee, E.C. (1960) *The Politics of Nonpartisanship: A Study of California City Elections*. Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press.
6. Welch, S. and Bledsoe, T. (1986) The partisan consequences of nonpartisan elections and the changing nature of urban politics. *American Journal of Political Science* 30(1): 128–139.
7. Anzia, S.F. (2019) When does a group of citizens influence policy? Evidence from senior citizen participation in city politics. *The Journal of Politics* 81(1): 1–14.
8. Kogan, V., Lavertu, S. and Peskowitz, Z. (2018) Election timing, electorate composition, and policy outcomes: Evidence from school districts. *American Journal of Political Science* 62(3): 637–651.
9. Trounstine, J. and Valdini, M.E. (2008) The context matters: The effects of single-member versus at-large districts on city council diversity. *American Journal of Political Science* 52(3): 554–569.
10. Wright, G.C., 2008. Charles Adrian and the study of nonpartisan elections. *Political Research Quarterly*, 61(1), pp. 13–16.
11. Schaffner, B.F., Streb, M.J. and Wright, G.C. (2007) A new look at the Republican advantage in nonpartisan elections. *Political Research Quarterly* 60(2): 240–249.
12. de Benedictis-Kessner, J. and Warshaw, C. (2016) Mayoral partisanship and municipal fiscal policy. *The Journal of Politics* 78(4): 1124–1138.
13. Einstein, K.L. and Glick, D.M. (2018) Mayors, partisanship, and redistribution: Evidence directly from US mayors. *Urban Affairs Review* 54(1): 74–106.
14. Gerber, E.R. and Hopkins, D.J. (2011) When mayors matter: Estimating the impact of mayoral partisanship on city policy. *American Journal of Political Science* 55(2): 326–339.
15. Bucchianeri, P. (2020) Party competition and coalitional stability: Evidence from American local government. *American Political Science Review* 114(4): 1055–1070.
16. O'Toole, L.J. Jr. and Meier, K.J. (2011) *Public Management: Organizations, Governance, and Performance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
17. Erie, S.P. (1988) *Rainbow's End: Irish-Americans and the Dilemmas of Urban Machine Politics, 1840–1985*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.

18. Trounstine, J. and Valdini, M.E. (2008) The context matters: The effects of single-member versus at-large districts on city council diversity. *American Journal of Political Science* 52(3): 554–569.
19. Broockman, D.E., Carnes, N., Crowder-Meyer, M. and Skovron, C. (2021) Why local party leaders don't support nominating centrists. *British Journal of Political Science* 51(2): 724–749.
20. Tausanovitch, C. and Warshaw, C. (2014) Representation in municipal government. *American Political Science Review* 108(3): 605–641.
21. Burnett, C.M. (2019) Parties as an organizational force on nonpartisan city councils. *Party Politics* 25(4): 594–608.
22. Masket, S. (2016) *The Inevitable Party: Why Attempts to Kill the Party System Fail and How They Weaken Democracy*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, p. 163.
23. Clarus Research Group. (2011) Clarus poll: 64 of voters oppose government employee unions. Press release, *PR Newswire*, 23 February; Keen, J. and Cauchon, D. (2011) Public favors union rights. *USA Today*, 23 February; Rasmussen Reports. (2011) Wisconsin poll: Support for budget cutting, not for weakening collective bargaining rights. 3 March; Rasmussen Reports. (2011) What you can learn about Wisconsin dispute from differences in poll questions. 3 March; *Wisconsin Reporter*. (2011) New poll: Wisconsinites split on Walker's budget proposal. 24 February.
24. Caughey, D., Xu, Y. and Warshaw, C. (2017) Incremental democracy: The policy effects of partisan control of state government. *The Journal of Politics* 79(4): 1342–1358.
25. Domhoff, G.W. and Webber, M.J. (2011) *Class and Power in the New Deal: Corporate Moderates, Southern Democrats, and the Liberal–Labor Coalition*. 1st ed. Studies in Social Inequality. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
26. Key, V.O. (1949) *Southern Politics in State and Nation*. Knoxville, TN: University of Tennessee Press.
27. Caughey, D. (2019) *The Unsolid South: Mass Politics and National Representation in a One-Party Enclave*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
28. Wright, G.C. and Schaffner, B.F. (2002) The influence of party: Evidence from the state legislatures. *American Political Science Review* 96(2): 367–379.

29. Van Vechten, R. (2002) *Taking the Politics out of Politics? State Legislative Term Limits and Institutional Political Reform in Twentieth Century California*. Unpublished PhD dissertation, University of California, Irvine.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

CHAPTER 10

~~Party On~~

Abstract Parties will not fully disappear, but there are some realistic options for reducing the negative results of political parties and partisanship. States can reduce their influence by preserving nonpartisan elections where they already exist and expanding ballot access for independent candidates. Other strategies, such as ranked-choice voting and improved civic education, are also considered. Partisanship will most likely remain a persistent feature of American politics, but from time to time, states should experiment with new strategies to encourage nonpartisanship in order to revitalize representative democracy.

Keywords Ballot access · Campaign finance reform · Civics education · Independent candidates · Multi-party systems · Nonpartisan elections · Open list voting · Proportional representation · Ranked choice voting

What do you do with an old, rickety car with faulty pollution controls and brakes? It's gotten you where you needed to go, but now it's belching smoke, guzzling fuel, and threatening to give out on the freeway. Your car is by far the simplest way to drive to your destination, but there are risks that come with its continued use. Accidents with your old car can affect you, your loved ones, and strangers. Few drivers intend to have accidents, but car accidents are one of the leading causes of death.

© The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3_10

That's a bit like our relationship with political parties. Political parties can be just like these old cars; they provide a straightforward way to navigate complex political landscapes, but they come with significant dangers. If it's a familiar commute, many people check their phones while driving because they think they know what's ahead. Similarly, many people vote for the same party election after election without reconsidering their views in light of changing circumstances. Some people drive drunk either for the convenience or even for the thrill of it. Similarly, many partisans cheer for all of their party politicians and denigrate their critics, boosting their dopamine with confirmation bias. Choosing public transportation might not be the most convenient way to travel, but it improves safety and air quality. Similarly, taking the time to research individual candidates and make informed decisions can lead to a healthier democracy.

Some might argue that political parties are an unavoidable part of our system, so why try to change the system? We advertise public transportation, even though it's unrealistic to expect everyone to use it. We discourage texting while driving, even though it's unrealistic to expect everyone to stop. Is it so different to encourage people to research candidates and vote on the research rather than party labels? And just as we can make cars safer with catalytic converters and antilock brakes, we can improve politics by discouraging proud partisanship. I don't think we'll be getting rid of political parties or cars anytime soon. But that doesn't mean we can't think about ways to reduce their harmful impact. And who knows? Maybe someday, we will all have pie-in-the-sky inventions like emission-free, safe, driverless cars, and correspondingly pie-in-the-sky political developments like more nonpartisanship.

First, we'll review the previous chapters to understand the pros and cons of political parties. By reviewing earlier chapters, we can assess which parts of the car are functioning well, and which might need repairs. Maybe parts of the landscape can be changed as well. Some places are better suited for nonpartisan systems than others, just like some bus stops are too far from some workplaces. While political parties may seem inevitable, we can still find realistic ways to minimize their impact. So, let's buckle up and see what we can learn about this old, worn-out vehicle we've been driving for so long.

Chapter 1 presented the arguments for parties as an information shortcut. On the one hand, parties help voters navigate complex political landscapes by providing a general sense of where candidates stand on key issues. Without the party label, voters will not necessarily research

the candidates conscientiously. But this is already what many voters have to do. All voters do it in primaries. In general elections, moderates need to research which party's nominee is more moderate, either overall or on the issues they care about most, and this will change every election. Either they cast an uninformed vote, or they have to do new research every time.

Chapter 2 explained how parties rely on ingroup/outgroup mentality. It doesn't take much to turn people against each other. Social psychologists note that simply forming a group based on a minimal difference and giving it a name can create division. Political parties go beyond this by braiding numerous group identities with party personalities and a value-laden platform. This mentality exacerbated the global COVID-19 pandemic, leading to vaccine hesitancy on one side and developmental delays for school children on the other. While independent voters are not perfect, they are more receptive to new information and less likely to condone a party politicians' misdeeds.

There is also a concern that this reliance on party labels can sometimes lead to voters adopting party positions without much independent thought or evaluation. When voters align too closely with their party's stance, they are less likely to accept facts that do not fit their preconceived views. This can create a "follow-the-leader" mentality, where party loyalty overrides individual judgment. Additionally, voters following the party line might be victims of manufactured preferences rather than deliberators arriving at authentic choices. Given these costs, I believe that political parties would need to offer extraordinary benefits to compensate.

In Chapter 3, we explored two competing theories about the nature of political parties. The UCLA Theory of Parties posits that political parties pretend to serve a broad coalition of interest groups but are more responsive to a small number of intense factions than to the general electorate. This theory worries that parties often serve dedicated factions rather than the broader public interest. The competing candidate-centered model argues that parties are driven by politicians who aim to align with voter preferences to win elections. Politicians will adopt policies that reflect the preferences of the median voter to maximize their chances of winning. Readers who believe in candidate-centered theories of parties might be more optimistic than me about the responsiveness of parties to voters. They view parties as organizations of politicians who aim to align their issue positions to voter preferences to win elections.

Chapter 4 shows how parties can both empower and sideline small groups of voters, often prioritizing the interests of intense factions over the broader public. This can be desirable when intense factions have rights being infringed upon by majorities. Political parties have occasionally championed the rights of marginalized groups, but as an exception rather than a rule. Parties can "capture" these groups, taking their support for granted once they become a reliable voting bloc. The Republican Party's role in ending slavery in the nineteenth century and the Democratic Party's role in advancing civil rights in the twentieth century are examples of parties at their best. But these salutary endings are once-in-a-century events. Parties sometimes provide cover for factions that work against marginalized groups, as well as stealthy factions that are self-serving but well-organized.

Parties also overlook unorganized groups like moderates, who inherently have a hard time organizing themselves into aggressive party factions. Not being organized is not an excuse for not being represented. Chapter 5 explores how the two-party system in the United States leaves many Americans without proper representation, as it fails to accommodate diverse political beliefs beyond the traditional liberal and conservative ideologies.

Chapter 6 discusses how parties promote voter turnout. Historical examples, such as Gilded Age corruption and Progressive Era reforms, show that trade-offs exist between turnout, rational deliberation, and democratic integrity. Americans have historically been willing to trade off lower turnout for good governance, and the record of political parties on expanding suffrage is mixed.

Chapter 7 argues that parties undermine several other democratic norms. Parties can foster a "spirit of revenge," leading members to obstruct policies from the opposing party out of spite rather than principle. Far from encouraging loyal opposition, one party has nominated candidates that refused to admit defeat, and the other has helped those candidates win the nomination on the assumption that they would be easier to defeat in the general election. And when party loyalty overtakes allegiance to one's governmental branch, the essential system of checks and balances is compromised, weakening legislative oversight and judicial impartiality. For instance, when one party controls both Congress and the presidency, Congress often defers to the executive, neglecting its role as a check and balance.

Chapter 8 examines the role of parties in Congress and presidential administrations. Parties often bring organization and stability to legislative bodies, helping to advance bills through enduring coalitions. However, parties prioritize keeping legislative majorities over serving the broader public interest. Historical examples, such as the administrations of Washington and Monroe, also demonstrate that governance can function effectively without entrenched partisanship, raising questions about whether we need parties for effective leadership.

Chapter 9 questions whether political parties consistently benefit state and local governance. For the most part, studies on local government contradict each other. It is hard to find a consistent difference between partisan and nonpartisan local governments. In the South, one-party dominance produced a troubling imbalance: while Southern members of Congress closely represented their white constituents' interests, state legislatures frequently leaned toward more conservative policies than that of their white voters. On the other hand, Nebraska, California, and Minnesota legislatures are or were nonpartisan. They were no more corrupt than many partisan legislatures during their period of nonpartisanship.

Parties are such an ingrained part of the system that you might ask what people who don't want them can do about them. Most people who have opposed parties or tried to reduce their influence, like the founders, were thwarted. Like other seemingly intractable problems, intractability doesn't mean we should stop calling them problems or stop trying to find solutions. Some reforms aimed at limiting party influence have at least worked temporarily. For example, the nonpartisan legislature in Nebraska delayed the polarization that affected other legislatures. We won't know what truly works until multiple solutions are tried. The fact that many reforms have been repealed shows that negative effects are not intractable. History shows that parties adapt, so perhaps there can be a cycle of reform and diminished partisanship, followed by partisan adaptation and a return to partisanship. Future reformers can then experiment with other approaches. This cycle, although imperfect, is better than the status quo of permanent excess partisanship.

We have some ideas of anti-party reforms that are not worth their cost. Banning voluntary associations like political parties could end up being a lot messier than the problem we're trying to fix. Such a ban violates the First Amendment, which guarantees our right to freely assemble and speak. Madison tackled this issue in Federalist 10, where he pointed out

that nefarious political factions are an inevitable byproduct of the freedom to associate. Trying to suppress them could lead to even bigger issues, like concentrating power in the hands of the people doing the banning. However, states do have some leeway. They're not required to include party labels on ballots, and they can allow "cross-filing," where candidates can run under multiple party affiliations. These options can help balance representation and accommodate different political viewpoints without throwing out the foundational freedoms that keep our democracy running.

Campaign finance laws that restrict party spending can weaken party organizations but can also have unintended consequences. When the Bipartisan Campaign Reform Act (BCRA) and comparable state laws limited "soft money" donations to candidates from parties, it forced candidates to seek funding from more extreme factions within their parties. Formal party organizations at least balanced the party network demands with the need to win general elections. Party factions may push for more extreme positions at the expense of general elections. So while these reforms weakened the party *family*, they strengthened the more extreme *extended family*.

Public financing of campaigns is also a proposed reform. States that have adopted public funding have not seen a clear shift toward more liberal or conservative public policy, but candidates often appreciate spending less time on fundraising.[1] Still, campaign money may be an overrated factor in electoral politics. Donations played a major role in encouraging fiscal conservatives to run against establishment Republicans during the Tea Party's peak, but since then, Donald Trump has defeated more economically conservative primary opponents despite receiving significantly less funding from millionaires and billionaires, and went on to win two presidential elections (2016 and 2024) against Democrats with more millionaire and billionaire donations. After Mitt Romney's 2012 defeat, Republicans like freshman Tea Party Senator Marco Rubio promoted immigration reform as a way to broaden the party's appeal to minority voters without alienating key Tea Party donors and influencers. Republican Party leaders got approval from a "Who's Who" of Tea Party influencers and media moguls to greenlight immigration reform: billionaire donors such as Charles Koch and Sheldon Adelson; media moguls like Rupert Murdoch and Roger Ailes; conservative talk show hosts like Rush Limbaugh, Sean Hannity, and Bill O'Reilly; anti-tax activists like Grover Norquist; and prominent Catholic and Evangelical groups.[2] However,

this strategy ultimately collapsed when Trump won the 2016 primaries by leaning heavily into anti-immigrant rhetoric, signaling the end of that phase of Republican politics. Campaign funding cannot trump such a salient issue among party voters.

Ranked choice voting (RCV) is also a reform that has failed in the past and has been recently readopted by a few cities and states. RCV is a system in which voters rank candidates in order of preference, and the votes of eliminated candidates are transferred to the next preferred candidate on each ballot until one candidate achieves a majority. During the Progressive Era, many cities adopted RCV to weaken party bosses but eventually repealed it. Jack Santucci, who has studied the policy extensively, explains that party bosses continued to win as often as they had before. Moreover, the adoption of RCV didn't lead to a multiparty system, as some hoped. RCV worked in other countries that already had multiple parties but the United States had only two parties in place.[3] Alaska Senator Lisa Murkowski credits RCV with making elections more civil because candidates want supporters of other candidates to rank them as their second choice.[4] While it may promote civility, RCV helped a moderate (Lisa Murkowski) win an Alaska Senate race in 2022 but helped a socialist (Zohran Mamdani) win in a New York City mayoral election in 2025, so it hard to say whether it uniformly favors less extreme candidates. A more ambitious idea is a multiparty system through open-list proportional representation, in which political parties obtain seats in a legislature based on the percentage of votes they receive. Right now, our two-party system forces people into choosing between just two sides, which can be really limiting. With more parties, people wouldn't have to see everything in such black-and-white terms. There would be more overlap between parties, which could help reduce the extreme "us vs. them" mentality that's so common today.

It might seem like the solution is more education, but merely spending more years in school hasn't helped. In fact, polarization has grown even as education levels have risen. One casualty of standardized testing is less civics education. That means many students never learn how democracy actually works or how to respectfully disagree. Some programs that do focus on civics, especially ones that include debate, discussion, and real-world political thinking, show promise. Students in these programs tend to become more open-minded and less likely to follow the crowd blindly.[5] But not all civics education works this way; merely memorizing the branches of government isn't going to fix polarization. The key is

teaching students to challenge their own side just as much as the other. But teachers are often reluctant to hold debates that do this, especially when the topics are seen as challenging students' self-identity.[6] In an age of party polarization, all issues can be enfolded into party identification and therefore self-identification. Even formal debate teams have shifted attention from *what* they are debating to *who* they are debating. One student lost a debate at the prestigious Tournament of Champions in Kentucky because of a tweet he had written earlier in the month about prejudice, despite the debate round being about US water policy.[7] When students are taught that winning depends on aligning with a worldview rather than developing strong, evidence-based arguments on the issue in question, debates in school no longer cultivate the critical thinking that students need to resist excess partisanship.

Here are some realistic recommendations.

First, it's cliché, but a major part of the solution is for scholars to admit that parties are a problem. If we don't think it's a problem, the best and brightest minds among us will not be working on solutions. Consider the problem of reducing smoking rates. For years, it seemed impossible to significantly lower smoking prevalence. But when experts put their minds to it, through public health campaigns, regulations, and education, smoking rates dropped dramatically. This success wouldn't have happened if experts hadn't seen it as a problem so intractable that it was not worth trying to solve.

Second, inertia means that political parties will continue to exist at the national level and in most states for the foreseeable future. One realistic solution is to keep nonpartisan elections where they already exist. Nebraska's state legislature and many local governments operate nonpartisan elections. Here, inertia works in favor of nonpartisanship. We should extol examples of nonpartisan systems and encourage other levels of government to consider following suit.

Third, give party legislators more say in nominations for now. Unlike activists, who often push for ideological extremes, legislators are invested in down-ballot races so that they can become a legislative majority. They will push back against candidates for executive offices that are too extreme and harmful to candidates in more moderate districts. While this strengthens one aspect of parties, it weakens the more dangerous factions within parties. Parties could better align with the candidate-centered model, which is more responsive to voters' needs than the activist-driven UCLA Theory of Parties. Parties currently seem to be moving in the

opposite direction, with the Democrats eliminating superdelegates in 2020.

Fourth, extend the social rewards for nonpartisan expression to nonpartisan thinking. Klar and Krupnikov argue that the social stigma for partisanship has turned overt partisans into closet partisans rather than rational deliberators. Instead of turning shadow partisans back into overt partisans, as Klar and Krupnikov seem to want, I would prefer that we turn shadow partisans into real independent voters. Call people out when they fail to acknowledge trade-offs in party proposals. Congratulate partisans when they admit fault with their own party or admit that the other party has a point. Discourage people from watching partisan-affiliated media that mix news with the entertainment of attacking the other party. Social norms change more often than we expect. There are words everyone used when I was a child that shock people now. If we can successfully pressure people to stop using slurs or offensive language, we can also persuade people to stop treating political parties like sports teams. It starts with rewarding people for questioning their own side and being curious about the other side.

Fifth, encourage partisan leaders to work behind the scenes rather than use the bully pulpit. Presidents are symbols of their party and their own position becomes identified as the party position, telling voters that this is how support and opposition for a proposal should break down. Historically, the bully pulpit has rarely persuaded Americans to support something they previously opposed; it only rallies Americans around something they already support. While occasionally effective, this approach more often splits people along partisan lines and inhibits rational discussion of issues. The politicization of the COVID-19 and HPV vaccines sorted the public into irrational partisan divides. In contrast, the Toxic Substances Control Act of 2016 passed largely because high-profile partisan leaders stayed out of the spotlight. Without being visibly associated with a party or its president, the public did not perceive the bill as controversial, allowing for more rational deliberation and bipartisan support.

Finally, encourage independent candidacies. Party nominees only go so far to accommodate public opinion because they have to keep their party activists happy. Independent candidates can demonstrate that there's a price to be paid for going too far to accommodate party activists. For example, most Americans believe abortion should be legal in some circumstances but not others. A plurality of voters supports the right to

abortion in the first trimester and in cases of rape, incest, and threats to the mother's health, while opposing it in the third trimester. Just the same, many party nominees take all-or-nothing positions on abortion. Independent candidates can represent these more nuanced views of the electorate better than major party nominees. The threat of being a "spoiler" can force parties to address issues they would otherwise ignore. For example, antislavery and prohibition parties in the nineteenth century could not win but they cost major parties enough votes that major parties could no longer ignore the issue.

Increasing ballot access and lowering the bar for participation in debates can help encourage independent candidacies. The more serious obstacle is the opposition to independent candidates among the intelligentsia, which goes hand in hand with academics extolling the virtues of parties. Independent candidates encourage other candidates to consider the broader electorate rather than just their party's base.

Even with more parties on the menu, some people will still cling to their political comfort food, defending it no matter how stale or overcooked the arguments. This is why I ultimately think independent candidacies or nonpartisan elections are a better approach. With independent candidates, voters can focus more on the candidate and their individual platform and consider new kinds of candidates from election to election, rather than slouching back into the same party platform every election.

***

Imagine someone who believes in every tenet of their religion, regardless of evidence to the contrary. He holds up signs, proselytizes family members, and even rejects medical treatments. He sometimes calls people names in other religions. Intelligent people often disdain the religious zealot and call their beliefs dogmatic. However, when similar fervor and unquestioning loyalty are directed toward political parties, some of the same intelligent people call it healthy civic participation.

The comparison to religious dogma is not intended to alienate but to provoke critical thinking. Just as unwavering religious belief can overlook broader realities and truths, blind loyalty to political parties can lead to two sides, each with their own alternate facts. This inhibits discussion, obscures important issues, and privileges the most intense voices, rather than the most representative voices.

This book challenges the conventional wisdom that equates party loyalty with civic engagement and political parties with democracy. Democracy should be about deciding which issue positions you support rather than which group you identify with. Checks and balances should be about branches counteracting branches rather than parties counteracting parties. We need a system where the open-mindedness of the true independent voter meets the motivation of the partisan.

Parties aren't going away. And getting rid of parties would not turn voters into angels. But by treating parties as valuable civic organizations rather than fonts of groupthink, we miss the chance to remind voters of the excess of political parties, and from time to time, get voters to step back from the edge of the cliff that parties lead them to.

Notes

1. Prokop, A., February 9 2016. *Why the left's favorite idea for campaign finance reform doesn't work as well as they hope*.
2. Popkin, S.L., 2021. *Crackup: The Republican implosion and the future of presidential politics*. New York: Oxford University Press, pp. 78–81.
3. Santucci, J. 2022. *More Parties or No Parties: The Politics of Electoral Reform in America*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
4. Hoover, M., June 27 2025. *Firing Line with Margaret Hoover* [podcast]. Firing Line Productions.
5. Niemi, R.G. and Junn, J., 1998. *Civic education: What makes students learn*. New Haven: Yale University Press; Westheimer, J. and Kahne, J., 2004. What kind of citizen? The politics of educating for democracy. *American Educational Research Journal*, 41(2), pp.237–269; Hess, D.E. and McAvoy, P., 2014. *The political classroom: Evidence and ethics in democratic education*. New York: Routledge.
6. Sawchuk, S., 2023. Student debates might not be such a great lesson idea. Here's why. *Education Week*, [online] 21 Nov. Available at: https://www.edweek.org/teaching-learning/opinion-student-debates-might-not-be-such-a-great-lesson-idea-heres-why/2023/11.

7. Fishback, J., 2023. Kids are losing high school debates because of their personal tweets. *The Free Press*, 26 June. Available at: https://www.thefp.com/p/kids-are-losing-high-school-debates-because-of-personal-tweets.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives 4.0 International License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/), which permits any noncommercial use, sharing, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons license and indicate if you modified the licensed material. You do not have permission under this license to share adapted material derived from this chapter or parts of it.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons license, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons license and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.

Index

A
Abolitionists. *See* Slavery
Abortion, 3, 5, 14–16, 39, 45, 48, 59, 141, 159, 160
Adams, John Quincy, 124, 126, 127, 133
Affiliations, 16, 138, 144, 145, 156
Affordable Care Act (ACA). *See* Health care
Aldrich, John, 117
Antislavery, 72, 73, 125, 126, 160
Articles of Confederation, 98, 100
Azari, Julia, 104

B
Ballot access, 75, 92, 160
Bawn, Kathleen, 40, 41, 53, 63
Biden, Joseph, 7, 27, 39, 57, 68, 70, 88, 103–105, 108
Bipartisan, 107, 121, 159
Blind Spot, 40, 45, 57, 59, 60
Bosses, 87
Broockman, David, 80, 140
Budget deficit, 76
Bully Pulpit, 159
Bush, George H.W., 45, 47, 75
Bush, George W., 5, 26, 78, 101, 132

C
Cabinet, 98, 102, 107, 124, 131, 133
Campaign finance, 156
Candidate-centered model, 41, 153, 158
Candidate-centered parties, 52
Candidate-centered theories, 153
Capture, 57
Carter, Jimmy, 58, 76, 123
Caughey, Devin, 143, 144, 147
Checks and balances, ix, 97, 105, 106, 109, 110, 142, 154, 161
Christian conservatives, 47, 48, 68
Christian Right, 47, 52, 69
Christian Right realignment, 47
City managers, 139
Civics, 5, 157
Civics education, 157
Civil liberties, 21, 22
Civil rights, 23, 41, 43, 44, 46, 47, 52, 56–58, 61, 69, 71, 76, 89, 92, 143, 154

© The Editor(s) (if applicable) and The Author(s) 2026

C. Baylor, *The Case Against Political Parties*,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-032-10891-3

Civil War, ix, 37, 56, 58, 73, 91, 102, 125, 128, 131, 135
Clay, Henry, 125–127
Clinton, Bill, 58, 70, 75
Clinton, Hilary, 53
Clinton, Hillary, 7, 42, 70, 74, 76, 104
Cognitive dissonance, 8, 14–16, 68
Confederate States of America, ix, 128
Congress, 17, 43–45, 47, 48, 67, 70, 72, 75, 77, 91, 101, 102, 106, 107, 109, 115, 116, 119–127, 131, 133, 143, 144, 154, 155
Congressional, 8, 17, 21, 49, 75–77, 92, 104, 106, 107, 116, 118, 120, 144
Conspiracy theories, 39, 104
Converse, Philip, 21
COVID-19, 25, 90, 159
Cross-filing, 42, 145, 156
Cross-Pressured Voters, 6, 67, 147

D
Davis, Jefferson, 129, 133
Debates, x, 22, 25, 28, 51, 52, 69, 75, 86, 93, 98, 102, 104, 105, 108, 116, 119, 120, 128, 132, 133, 139, 157, 158, 160
Deficit, 76–78, 88
Deliberation, 16, 23, 51, 89, 90, 93, 100, 110, 121, 154, 159
Deliberators, 153, 159
Demagoguery, 100, 127
Demagogues, 100
Democratic National Committee (DNC), 89, 104
Divided government, 116, 121
Downs, Anthony, 4, 5, 15, 16, 38, 39, 43
Drutman, Lee, 75
Duverger, Maurice, 75

E
Echo chambers, 69, 132
Edwards, George, 132
Eisenhower, Dwight, 9, 46, 49
Electoral college, 43, 74, 88, 91
Era of Good Feelings, 58, 124–126, 128
Evangelical, 45, 46, 49, 156
Evangelical Christians, 19, 45, 48
Evangelical churches, 68
Executive power, 21, 51, 107, 131

F
Farmers, 41–43, 46, 62, 72, 73
Federalist Party, 91, 123, 124, 126, 133
Federalists, 41, 98, 99, 101, 102, 124, 125
Feminist, 61
Fifteenth amendment, 91
Filibuster, 116, 119
Fiorina, Morris, 67, 90
First-past-the-post, 93
"First Past the Post" systems, 70
Founders, 98–100, 102, 106, 108, 110, 127, 128, 155
Free Rider Problem, 60
Frymer, Paul, 57, 63

G
Gay rights. *See* LGBTQ rights
Gingrich, Newt, 77
Green party, 70, 74
Ground game, 89, 90
Group affiliations, 13
  ingroup/outgroup mentality, ix
Group identities, 153
Groupthink, ix, 22, 23, 130–133, 161

H
Haidt, Jonathan, 14, 20

Hamilton, Alexander, 101, 123, 124, 128, 133
Harris, Kamala, 27, 105
Hartford Convention, 102
Health care, 17
Heritage Foundation, 48, 51
Heterogeneous, 18
Hoover, Herbert, 8, 9
Humphrey, Hubert, 47, 76

I
Identity, 15, 16, 18–20, 22, 23, 62, 66, 82, 118, 124, 158
Ideological, 6, 39, 41, 51, 81, 120, 124, 127, 128, 131, 140, 142, 158
Ideology, viii, 18, 21, 26, 28, 37, 38, 41, 45, 65–69, 72, 78, 88, 103, 120, 133, 138, 146, 154
Ignorant, 4, 10
Immigrants, 5, 41, 57, 78, 79, 91, 118, 119, 121, 157
Immigration, 3, 7, 57, 59, 89, 91, 108, 119, 121, 156
Implicit association test, 20
Independent, 15, 22, 86
Independent candidacies, 159, 160
Independent candidates, 22, 23, 28, 86, 159, 160
Independent voters, 21, 22, 25, 26, 68, 78–80, 86, 87, 89, 90, 153, 159, 161
Information shortcut, 152
Ingroup/outgroup mentality, ix, 71, 89, 90, 93, 153
Ingroups, 16, 125
Interest groups, vii, viii, 42, 50–52, 57–63, 71, 73, 92, 100, 104, 120, 123, 139, 145, 146, 153
Iraq War, 21, 49, 122, 130
Irrational, 16
Issue-based approach, 16

J
Jackson, Andrew, 99, 102, 127
Jefferson, Thomas, 24, 99, 124, 127, 133
Jim Crow, 91
Jim Crow laws. *See* Civil rights
Johnson, Lyndon, 44, 132

K
Karol, David, 46, 75
Kennedy, John F., 44, 101
Klar, Samara, 79, 89, 90, 159
Klein, Ezra, 19, 118
Krehbiel, Keith, 116
Krupnikov, Yanna, 79, 89, 90, 159

L
Labor politics, 73
Labor Unions, 46, 62, 71, 146
La Follette, Robert, 73
LaFollette, Robert, 74
Lau, Richard, 7
Lee, Frances, 120
Left-right spectrum, 7, 67
LGBTQ, viii, 47, 48, 58, 59, 61
LGBTQ rights, 48, 58, 59
Libertarianism, 66, 67, 80, 81
Libertarian party, 74
Limbaugh, Rush, 101
Lincoln, Abraham, 85, 129
Local, 6, 28, 61, 69, 87, 94, 126, 138–143, 147, 155
Local elections, 138
Local government, 137–140, 145, 147, 155, 158
Local partisan elections, 141
Lockdowns, 25, 27
Long coalition, 117, 118, 120, 122
Loyal opposition, 97, 102, 103, 154

M
Madison, James, 63, 91, 100, 101, 105
Maher, Bill, 101
Manufactured beliefs, 15
Manufactured preferences, 14, 68, 153
Marginalized factions, 57
Marginalized groups, 56, 57, 59, 61–63, 86, 99, 154
Masket, Seth, 99, 141
Mason, Lilliana, 18
Mayors, 47, 139, 140
McConnaughy, Corrine, 62–64, 95
McKitrick, Eric, 129
Media, 10, 24, 25, 28, 42, 48, 70, 74, 79, 105, 145, 156, 159
Medicare. *See* Health care
Mental health, 24, 25, 28, 29
Milkis, Sidney, 74
Miracle, 10
Miracle of aggregation, 9, 10
Misinformation, 10, 28, 89, 93, 98
Moderates, x, 6, 66–70, 75, 79, 80, 93, 118, 119, 126, 147, 153, 154, 157, 158
Moderation, 67, 71
Monroe, James, 101, 123–126, 128, 131, 133, 155
Motivated partisan reasoning, 87
Motivated reasoning, ix, 14, 20, 22, 26, 71, 89, 93, 115
Muirhead, John, 22, 23, 122, 123, 126
Muirhead, Russell, 22
Multiparty democracy, 72
Multiparty system, 71, 157
Multiparty systems, 70, 71, 86, 122, 157

N
National Bank, 101, 123, 124, 127
Native Americans, 99
Nazi Party, 9
Nazis, 71
Nebraska, 141, 144–147, 155, 158
New Deal, 9, 49, 56, 74, 122, 123, 143, 144
Nixon, Richard, 9, 45, 49, 76, 78, 102, 107, 108, 116
Noel, Hans, 99
Nonpartisan, ix, 6, 7, 20, 28, 58, 86, 87, 90, 93, 122, 132, 133, 137–141, 144–149, 152, 155, 158–160
Nonpartisan elections, 6, 137–140, 145–147, 158, 160
Nonpartisan legislatures, 141, 144, 145, 147, 155
Nonpartisan local elections, 86, 93
Nonpartisanship, 155
Nonpartisan system, ix, 7, 28, 86, 90, 132, 145

O
Obama, Barack, 5, 7, 17, 42, 57, 104, 105, 107
Obamacare. *See* Health care
Olson, 60
Olson, Mancur, 60, 61
Outgroups, ix, 16, 17, 24, 125

P
Page, Benjamin, 9
Party bosses. *See* Political machines
Party capture, 57
Party-line voting, 5, 90, 120
Party realignment, 43, 46, 47
Perot, H. Ross, 23, 28, 75–78, 83
Pied piper memo, 104
Pluralism, 56
Pluralists, 55, 59

Polarization, 24, 25, 29–31, 62, 80, 82, 87–89, 108, 110, 116, 118, 139, 141, 145–147, 155, 157, 158
Polarize, ix, 6, 17, 24, 89, 116, 141, 145
Political machines, 140
Political parties
  as information shortcuts, 14
  bipartisanship, 107
  candidate-centered, 28, 38, 154
  heterogeneity, 18, 105
  polarization, 24, 116, 147, 155
  realignment, 41
  whips, 117
Popkin, Samuel, 105
Populism, 66, 67, 73, 74, 80, 81
Populist party, 73
Presidency, 6, 9, 49, 58, 68, 75, 104–107, 116, 122–124, 127, 154
Primaries, 7, 11, 22, 42, 44–46, 48, 50, 68, 70, 73, 75, 78, 80, 90–93, 98, 102–106, 110, 118, 122, 145, 153, 156, 157
Primary elections, 6, 44, 88, 118
Pro-choice. *See* Abortion
Progressive era, 87, 140, 141, 154, 157
Progressive Party, 73, 74
Pro-life. *See* Abortion
Proportional representation, 157
Proslavery, 58

R

Ranked choice voting (RCV), 157
Rational, 4, 6, 14–16, 20, 39, 89, 90, 100, 110, 154, 159
Rational ignorance, 4
Rauch, Jonathan, 60, 61, 64
Reagan, Ronald, 26, 45, 47, 58, 76, 121
Realignments, 45, 47, 52, 71, 121
Reconstruction, 91, 102, 142
Referendums, 42, 73, 141, 144
Reform Party, 48, 78
Republican, 98, 99
Republican National Committee (RNC), vii, 45, 49, 89
Republican Party (Jeffersonian), 8, 9, 14, 18, 37, 39, 40, 43, 44, 46, 48, 49, 51, 52, 69, 72, 73, 91, 103, 104, 123, 124, 127, 154, 156
Republicans, vii, viii, x, 6–9, 14, 15, 17–19, 21, 24–26, 28, 30, 31, 37, 39–46, 48, 49, 51, 52, 57–59, 66, 68, 69, 72, 73, 77–80, 82, 88, 90, 91, 101–109, 111, 116, 118, 119, 121–128, 130, 138–142, 148, 154, 156, 157
Retrospective voting, 8, 10, 11
Romney, Mitt, 21, 42, 156
Roosevelt, Franklin, 8, 9, 43, 49, 74, 107
Roosevelt, Theodore, 73, 74
Rosenblum, Nancy, viii, 22, 51, 102
Rosenfeld, Sam, 56

S

Same-sex marriage, 79, 142
Sanders, Bernie, 23, 70, 104
Schattschneider, E.E., 7, 40, 49, 50, 60, 144
Schlozman, Daniel, 56
Schwarzenegger, Arnold, 79
Selective incentives, 61, 62
Shapiro, Robert, 9
Shortcuts, ix, 4–7, 10, 11, 13, 15, 16, 18, 20, 29, 138, 143, 147
Single-member districts, 70, 75, 122
Slave, 72

Slavery, 51, 56, 72, 73, 99, 125–128, 154
Slaves, 99, 125, 130
Social identity, 13, 14
Social media, 16, 20, 50, 70, 88, 89
Somin, Ilya, 5
South. *See* White South
Southern, 9, 44, 45, 49, 58, 59, 69, 72, 73, 78, 91, 125, 126, 142–144, 147, 149, 155
Southerners, 19, 49, 58, 124, 125
Southern faction, 9, 44, 49
Southern identity, 14
Spoils system, 87
State legislatures, 141–147, 149, 155, 158
Suffrage, 62, 63, 72, 91, 92, 99, 110, 130, 154
Superdelegates, 159
Supreme Court, 47, 48, 76, 77, 107–109, 142

T
Tajfel, Henri, 17, 18
Tariffs. *See* Trade
Tea Party, 118, 156
Theriault, Sean, 118
Third parties, 72–75, 78, 80, 93
Third-party candidates, 92, 93
Third-party organizations, 77
Trade, 10, 23, 41, 46, 48, 78, 89, 125, 154, 159
Truman, Harry, 44
Trump, Donald, 7, 21, 25–28, 31, 32, 48, 51, 52, 54, 57, 68, 69, 74, 78, 82, 88, 94, 101–109, 111, 156, 157
Turnout, x, 23, 83, 86–89, 93, 94, 138, 139, 147, 154
Two-party systems, ix, 31, 66, 67, 71, 75, 80, 86, 124–126, 129, 154, 157

U
UCLA Theory of Parties, 38–44, 48, 49, 51, 52, 56, 62, 73, 146, 153, 158
Unions, 19, 28, 38, 41, 44, 46, 47, 53, 58, 69, 78, 102, 125, 139, 141, 142, 149

V
Vaccines, 26, 27, 153, 159
Van Buren, Martin, 99, 126–128
Vietnam War, 132
Voluntary associations. *See* Interest groups
Voter deliberation, x, 133
Voter ID laws, 92
Voter ignorance, 5
Voter irrationality, 16
Voter turnout, ix, 70, 85–89, 93, 137, 138, 140, 145, 147, 154

W
Wallace, George, 75–78
Warren, Elizabeth, 7
Washington, 98, 100, 101, 123, 127, 128, 130, 133, 155
Welfare, 5, 45, 73, 76, 98, 121, 142
Whig Party, 72, 129
Whigs, 37, 41, 72, 128, 131
White south
  as a political faction, 22, 72, 156
White Southerners, 14, 43
White Southern identity, 14
Wilson, Woodrow, 74
Wolbrecht, Christina, 57

Z
Zaller, John, 124